

Psych 350 On Narcissism

Course transcript with numbered paragraphs

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Highlighting key

key vocabulary terms and concepts distinctive to this course

key figures thinkers, characters, and figures central to the lectures

Paragraphs are numbered lecture.paragraph (e.g. 3.12 is the twelfth paragraph of Lecture 3). Each lecture opens with an "At a glance" overview, which is not part of the transcript.

1. The Faces of Narcissism

AT A GLANCE

Introduces the instructor as a research psychologist who studies the self and self-enhancement, then retells the myth of Narcissus and Echo and traces the history of the concept: Guislain's mania of Narcissus, Havelock Ellis, Freud's On Narcissism, Murray's first measure, the NPI, Kernberg and Kohut, and the sociological turn with Tom Wolfe and Lasch. Defines narcissism by positive self-views, low emotional warmth, and self-regulation strategies, and distinguishes its three faces: grandiose, vulnerable, and NPD, plus communal and collective forms. Covers self-report measures (SINS, NPI, HSNS), demographics, heritability and parenting, and the cousins of narcissism: self-esteem, entitlement, and the Dark Triad.

- 1.1 Hey, welcome to my course on narcissism. This will be fun. This will be interesting. We're going to learn a whole lot over, I think, eight hours of discussing this topic. But why am I here? Why are you listening to me talk about narcissism? Well, there are different ways to get into the narcissism business. You can get into it through clinical psychology. You can get in through psychiatry. You can get into it through research. You can get in through marketing. There's different ways. I'm a researcher. I'm a research psychologist. My training is in what we call social personality psychology. I study the self, I study personality structure, I study relationships.
- 1.2 My focus has been mostly on studying the normal range of people in normal behaviors, normal relationship behaviors, normal workplace behaviors. I say that because I'm not a clinical psychologist. When we come to talk about narcissism, a lot of what we talk about is narcissistic personality disorder, which is the clinical face of that. I'm going to talk about that, but I want you to know where I'm coming from, which is from a research background, studying more normal individuals. I should say I do have a master's degree in clinical. I've done some clinical work, but I'm not trained, I'm not licensed, I'm not diagnosing anybody up here. It's not what I'm doing.
- 1.3 Then people always ask, "Why did you study narcissism? Are you a narcissist?" Maybe. But that's not why I started. I didn't wake up one day and go, I got a—you know, a lot of people in psychology, we say, "Research is me-search." What's your personal problem? I'm going to spend my life studying my own issues. I didn't study narcissism as much because it was a personal issue. I was studying what we call self-enhancement processes, basically, processes whereby people feel they're better than they are. Most of us do this. Most of us have, show what we call the better-than-average effect. If I said, "How attractive is everyone in here?", the average would be 7 out of 10. Just because we always inflate ourselves a little bit. It's a very interesting topic in psychology.
- 1.4 When I was in grad school, I started going, "Maybe some people are more like this than others." I was having breakfast at, I think it was Ye Olde Waffle House or Ye Olde Pancake Shop in Madison, Wisconsin, with Constantine Sedikides, my advisor, and Glenn Reeder. This is probably in 1990 sometime, maybe 1991. Good times back in the '90s. If you guys were there, it was

awesome. I remember Glenn going, "Hey, we should study narcissism." I thought, "Well, I'm a Freudian. I'll study narcissism. That sounds cool." That's where it started. It was that, and I was also always interested in Buddhism and Vedic philosophy and the non-self and how you could study selflessness. I could never figure that out. But when I started studying ego, I'm like, "I can study ego."

- 1.5 So narcissism is a way of—when you study narcissism, you learn how the ego works, and you can really see it because with big personalities and self-centered and all the stuff we'll talk about, you can watch ego working. We all have egos. We're all playing games. We're all telling stories. Narcissism allows us to understand the ego in this really triumphant form. But I think it's useful for understanding the ego in everybody, not just people who are narcissistic. It's useful for just understanding how these processes work. That's the background. I've been studying narcissism, I guess, for 25, 30 years. Written three books on it, I think, and very interested in all aspects. That's where I'm starting.
- 1.6 Now that I've talked about what my own interest in narcissism, I probably should talk about what narcissism is a little bit. That's what I'm going to do today. My goal is today, in this first quick lecture, is to talk about what narcissism is. I'm going to give you the history of narcissism, and it's a really interesting and complicated history. It's not as simple as it sounds, so I like the history stuff. Then I'm going to talk about three faces of narcissism, primarily. I'm going to talk about the two big faces we talk about, which is **grandiose narcissism**, the more over-the-top form, and then **vulnerable narcissism**, which is a more defensive form. I'll talk briefly about **NPD**, but I'm going to do a whole lecture on **narcissistic personality inventory**, which we often shorten to **NPD**. I'm going to do a whole lecture on that.
- 1.7 Today, I'll talk about some of the demographics of narcissism, where it comes from, and then I want to talk about the cousins of narcissism. How is narcissism different from **self-esteem**? How is narcissism different from **psychopathy**? How is narcissism different from **entitlement**? There's a lot of these psychological traits that go together. I was going to talk about that. Sometimes we talk about these, like the **Dark Triad**, if you've heard that term, so these different models. I'll go through some of that, and that'll be it.
- 1.8 To start, the word narcissism is a strange word. People, when you hear it, they're like, "What, narcissism? Why are there so many S sounds in there? Where does that come from?" Well, it's a strange word because it comes from a myth, the myth of **Narcissus**. This is a myth that it goes back to ancient Greece. The most popular telling was a Roman telling by **Ovid** in his *Metamorphoses*. If you read it, it's fascinating. It's like these Greek tragedies where it just goes back in time and all these different people. It's a very complicated story, but I'm going to give you the CliffNotes version of this. Once upon a time, let's see, a nymph and a river god, whose names I can't pronounce, fell in love. Let's just say that. They had a baby, and that baby was so beautiful that the day he was born, people were falling in love with him. That baby's name was **Narcissus**. **Narcissus** was born as this beautiful son of a river god and a nymph, and he was destined to have a great life.

- 1.9 But somebody asked the great seer Tiresias, who appears in a lot of Greek myths, said, "What's going to happen to Narcissus?" The story, Tiresias says is, "He's going to be awesome as long as he doesn't know himself." So Narcissus will be just perfect as long as he doesn't know himself. That was the prophecy. You always have to have a prophecy in a Greek tragedy. Narcissus is going around, doing his thing. He's maybe 16 years old. He's a young guy. He has all these people who are into him. He's got a bunch of dudes who love him. He's got women doing him. This is Greece. Everybody's into Narcissus. No one's good enough for him. One day he's out tending his—I think he's out with deer. I don't know if he has a flock of deer. I don't know why he's with the deer.
- 1.10 Echo hears him. Echo is another beautiful—I don't know if Echo is a nymph or what Echo is. Echo is beautiful. Echo hears Narcissus, and what Echo does is repeat everything Narcissus says. I'm not going to give you the history of why Echo does that. It's in the story. You can read it yourself. Echo repeats everything. There's an exchange where Narcissus is like, "I love you," and she says, "I love you." Then he looks at her and goes, "You're not good enough for me." He didn't say, "You disgust me," but it's essentially that. "Get out of here. I'm over you." He drives Echo away. Echo gets really depressed. She takes off into the woods and ends up in a cave. Echo ends up in a cave somewhere. Narcissus, after blowing her off, one of the guys that was into him calls the gods, and I don't know if it's Zeus, or I mix them all up. Let's just say it's Thor, just to make it real interesting here. He calls up Zeus and says, "Hey, you got to do something about this Narcissus guy. This guy's a problem."
- 1.11 What happens is, Narcissus wanders into the woods. There's this beautiful still silver pool of water. He looks into the pool and he sees himself in the water and he falls in love. He's like, "That's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen. I love myself." God, when you read the story, it's just heartbreaking. He reaches for himself and it's like, "I can see myself reaching back, but I can never touch myself. Every time I smile, I smile back, but I can never connect. I cry and my self cries, but we're never together." So he basically falls in love with himself, dies, just breaks down from this pain of not being able to connect with himself. He breaks down and turns into a flower. That flower is what we call the narcissus, a day lily, a white lily with a yellow center.
- 1.12 At the same time he dies, Echo feels his death and she withers away. She dies, loses her body, and just becomes a spirited voice. That's why when we go into caves, we hear echoes, because she's just a spirit left in the cave, and Narcissus is dead as a day lily. Sorry, that was a real sad story. I shouldn't have started with that one. But that's how it works. That's the story of Narcissus. It's a story of beauty and love. And then it's really a story of unrequited love because it's a story about "I want to love myself, but it's never going to work." It's never going to work out. And it's a story about relationship problems. "I'm going to just break a bunch of hearts. I'm going to destroy a bunch of people on the way."
- 1.13 So the story of Narcissus is a guy who's got so much going for him. He falls in love with himself. That absolutely destroys him. His own self-love destroys him. But in the meantime, it destroys everybody around him, too. So not just Narcissus dies, but Echo's gone. These other people are all heartbroken. That's the story. This idea of Narcissus as a representation of the problems with

ego was around, and it got absorbed into psychological theory. Back in the day, people started using these Greek terms. You've heard about the Oedipal complex or Electra complex, and this was narcissism. The first use I've seen for narcissism in the literature, in the research literature, is back from the 1850s. It was a guy named Dr. Guislain, if I'm pronouncing—he's French. I'm probably mispronouncing it; it's probably "Guss-lan" or something, I don't know. He had a book on insanity, and he wrote about narcissism. He called it The Mania of Narcissus.

- 1.14 He described it as, "This is usually manifested under the form of a tranquil mania in which we behold the patient infatuated with his beauty, his charms, his wit, his dress, his talents, titles, and birth." That was the first, at least the first I've ever found, written description of narcissism in the literature almost 150, 200 years ago. What's cool about that is it's about self-enhancement. It's about "I'm awesome." It's about being preoccupied with yourself. It's very much like what we talk about today as grandiose narcissism, which we'll see. It also talks about being preoccupied with titles. Imagine 150 years ago, this is pre-World War I, people had titles back in Europe that they were into. "I'm the Archduke of Athens, Georgia," or something. That was a big deal.
- 1.15 The term we use now for having a title, or feeling you have a title, is entitlement or sense of entitlement, psychological entitlement. Even in this early definition of narcissism, they were capturing this idea of entitlement. "I deserve special treatment. I'm better than people," etc. That was the earliest form I've seen. Then another, this is later 1800s, another really interesting figure in psychology named Havelock Ellis. This guy, just a guy I would have loved to have a drink with back in the 1800s sometime. He was Australian-British, and he got into this idea of narcissism, but he was looking at more of it like a sexual disorder, like a paraphilia. "I love myself. No, I really love myself, like physically." He took it in that direction.
- 1.16 Then what really set the course for narcissism in psychology was, of course, Sigmund Freud. Freud was the father of psychoanalysis. He's one of the foundational figures in modern psychology and psychiatry. Freud wrote this famous monograph. They called big papers monographs. It's called On Narcissism. Freud wrote this big treatise on what narcissism is. What's really cool about Freud's writing on narcissism is he talks about it in all these different ways. Freud talks about narcissism as a developmental phase. He goes, "Yeah, kids are really narcissistic. You ever notice that?" Then if you have kids, you've noticed it. You've noticed, "My kids are dancing around naked, saying, 'Look at me.'" Well, if that were a 25-year-old, you go, "Well, that's narcissistic." If you're a kid, you go, "That's normal." So Freud thought of it as a normal developmental phase.
- 1.17 He thought narcissism was related to survival instinct. So it wasn't like narcissism was bad. It was, you got to have a real strong, healthy ego to not die. Narcissism was about survival to him. Then he came up with this interesting conception, and I'm going to talk about this in detail when we get to the more clinical work, because this gets a little bit dicey. But essentially what he talked about is that narcissism is identification with the ideal self or the ego ideal. Might be Freud's term. What Freud was talking about was, you learn as a child to identify not with who you are, not with your strengths and weaknesses, but you learn to identify with an idealized

image of yourself. This idea is pretty powerful, and this we'll see come up again and again. But it's the idea that, "Hey, I'm identifying, and maybe this is with **libido**, maybe it's something else, I'm identifying with this really positive inflated self-image, and that's me, not the true me." We'll get to that again. Sometimes they call it the **false self**. But this is what Freud was doing.

- 1.18 Then we start seeing the more modern use of narcissism come around after 1900s, 1920s, 1930s, up to the '80s, really. People started using narcissism as a personality trait, meaning, "Hey, everybody's sort of narcissistic. Some people are really low **on narcissism**, and some people are really high **on narcissism**, and most of us are somewhere in the middle." People started thinking about this, "Hey, maybe narcissism is a trait. It's not a disorder. It's just a personality trait that we all have." This is how I think about it. Typically, this is a very common way to think about it.
- 1.19 Freud first wrote about this in a theory he called of **libidinal types**. He had this theory of **libidinal types** where there were basically three different personality structures—oral, anal, phallic. This is getting a little wonky. I'll save it for later. Basically, it was a narcissistic personality type that he talked about. Another really famous personality psychologist named Henry Murray, who was at Harvard, wrote *Explorations in Personality*, just a real personality genius. He developed a measure of—he called it narcism, not narcissism. People have called it narcism, narcissism, different versions. But he did the first **self-report** questionnaire, first **self-report** measure, and I'll talk about what those are in a bit, of narcissism in the '30s. He started measuring narcissism.
- 1.20 Then in the '70s and '80s, there was a real interest in building good personality measures of narcissism. The first and probably the most, not the first, but the most influential of those was called the **narcissistic personality inventory**, which came out in, I think it was '79, '80, depending on the version, out of Berkeley. I'll give you some examples of that. So we have narcissism as sort of this clinical mania. We have narcissism as a developmental phase. Now we have narcissism as a personality trait, a normal personality trait. Then we move into this 1960s and '70s, and we really start talking about narcissism as a **personality disorder**.
- 1.21 What happened in the 1960s in the US, and '70s, this is the baby boomers coming of age, there was a real interest in ego. You had a lot of people with disorders of the self. They go to a psychiatrist. What's your problem? I've just got too big of an ego. You started seeing those issues. The people you associate that are Heinz Kohut. It's Kernberg and Kohut. If you go into clinical psychology, these are the two names you're going to hear talking about narcissism. Kohut wrote a book called *The Analysis of the Self*, which is a very well-known narcissism book. Then Otto Kernberg wrote, **Borderline** Conditions and Pathological Narcissism. Again, I'll talk about this more with **NPD**. But they were really looking at these more **psychoanalytic personality disorder** models. This is if you end up seeing a therapist for your **narcissistic personality disorder** in Manhattan next month, they're going to have Kernberg and Kohut on their shelf, along with some other great thinkers.
- 1.22 Then this is where Narcism gets—this is what I think is really cool about it. You have narcissism as a normal trait. You have narcissism as a clinical disorder; that's extreme. Finally, you have

narcissism as a sociological variable. You can talk about a narcissistic culture, a narcissistic era, a narcissistic generation. Talk about whatever you want. This sociological approach to narcissism goes back to the '60s and '70s, mostly '70s as well. I think probably the first instance I've seen of this is the great American writer Tom Wolfe, who wrote a lot of great, you know, The Electric Kool-Aid Acid Test. He wrote a lot of classics, just books about American culture.

- 1.23 He wrote an article called the Me, Me, Me Decade, which was about the baby boomers. This was the first, really, idea I've seen in literature of like, "Hey, we're getting pretty self-absorbed as a culture. We're getting pretty self-centered as a culture." It's gotten worse, but the baby boomers were the first example of this. This article is wonderful. Tom Wolfe describes it. He said it's like everybody acted like a rich guy from Europe in the 1800s. It's like, normal people had rich-person problems from the 1800s. There is some economic stuff to it. I think that was pretty neat.
- 1.24 That was the first. The other big work in this area from, I guess it was '79, '80, I'm getting my dates wrong, was The Culture of Narcissism by Christopher Lasch. This was a famous book that used a very psychoanalytic or psychodynamic model of narcissism to understand American culture. This was read by Jimmy Carter in the White House. I'm getting a little wonky here, but whatever, it's my course. If you listen to Jimmy Carter's famous malaise speech, that was influenced by Lasch's Culture of Narcissism. We're reliving this time, so it might be worth revisiting that. That was a book looking at the culture of narcissism. Then Jean Twenge and I wrote a book, I guess it's been 10, 15 years ago now, I think it was '09, called The Narcissism Epidemic, which was really a work looking at cultural changes and trying to look at narcissism as a cultural variable over time. Are we getting more narcissistic as a culture? I'll do a lecture on that in a few lectures from now, just focusing on cultural change.
- 1.25 You put it all together and you can think of narcissism as this really complicated thing. It's a trait, it's a developmental phase, it's a disorder, and it's a cultural construct. We're going to touch on all those things and talk about what they have in common, what they have different. That's the goal here. In terms of defining narcissism, now that I've talked about it for 15 or 20 minutes, I figure I can give you a definition. Typically, when we think about narcissism, we're thinking about three primary qualities. The first is a positive view of yourself. You're narcissistic, you think you're kind of awesome. This gets complicated with vulnerable narcissism, but generally, you think you're better than other people. You think there's something special or unique about you. You're a little different than other people, a little more better.
- 1.26 Typically, narcissists think they're more attractive than other people, physically attractive. You get some vanity in there. You get a sense of entitlement, I deserve special treatment, a sense of grandiosity, I'm just inflated. So you usually have these positive self-views. Coupled with that is a lack or relative lack of emotional closeness or empathy or warmth. Meaning, I think I'm awesome, but I don't really have warm, caring, emotionally connected relationships with other people. I like to hang out with people. It might be fun to hang out with people who tell me I'm awesome, or it's fun to hang with cool people. So I like relationships. It's not that I'm not a loner,

but I'm not really that interested in caring or warmth or knowing a lot about your deep feelings and sacrificing myself for you. That's just not my agenda.

- 1.27 So the narcissism **empathy** piece gets really complicated and confusing. To summarize 20 years of research, people who are narcissistic have the capacity to take perspective. They know what you're thinking. They're not like, "I just see myself. Everyone else is just like a walrus." They can see you. They can see what you're thinking. What seems to be missing or less apparent is that emotional warmth. "I can see you're in pain. I just don't care that much. Care a little bit. Just don't care that much." That's the idea. "I'm really awesome. I get along fine with people, but I don't really care about them that much." You've got that set up right there.
- 1.28 Then what you have, the third big piece, are what we call **self-regulation** strategies. How do I keep myself looking and feeling good? This is kind of how it works. I'm going to hit this theme a hundred times. "In my mind, I'm a 10. I'm a 10 out of 10. I wake up in the morning, I look in the mirror, I'm a freaking 10. I'm rocking, I'm a 10. I'm high-fiving people, I'm a 10." I am not really a 10. I'm actually a 6.5. It's a bummer. I'm really a 6.5, but I got to think I'm a 10. That makes my life a little bit of a challenge, right? Because I think I'm better than I am. I have this margin of illusion, this fantasy I'm living with. But the good news is, I don't care about other people that much. So maybe I can get other people to conspire with me or to work with me to help me feel like I'm a 10, even though I'm a 6.5.
- 1.29 How would I do that? Well, I could find people who think I'm a 10, who suck up to me, or I'm trying to think of the appropriate term I should have used instead of suck up. There's a technical term for that. I can find people who will tell me I'm great. I can find sycophants. The joke about Washington, DC, is like, Washington, DC, is Hollywood for ugly people. I heard that from a Congressional quarterly reporter. I didn't make it up. Because you go to DC, you see these ugly people, but there's all these kids following them around with suits because they have power. One way I can do it is, if I'm a 6.5 but get power, people will treat me like I'm a 10. I can do that.
- 1.30 Or I can focus on my appearance and make myself look good. Or I can put out a —and if I can't really become a senator, I can act like a senator on social media and put out all these tweets like I'm a legend and then have people put a bunch of hearts next to it or whatever, and then I feel good about myself. If I can't do it in real life, maybe what I can do is I can fantasize about how great I am. I can sit at home and watch TV and go, "I'm awesome. I should be on that reality television show." Maybe if people threaten me and say, "Keith, you're a 6.5," I can punch them in the head. I can say, "No, I'm not. I'm a 10." They go, "You're a 10. You're a 10." I'm going to go, "Awesome. I'm a 10." That's the more hard-core way of doing this.
- 1.31 What's going on with narcissism is you have an inflated self-view, this ability to manipulate or use people to feel good, and then this game or this process of pumping yourself up. That's the narcissistic life right there in a nutshell. If you think about it clinically, the description given in the Diagnostic and Statistic Manual, the **DSM**, is describing narcissism as "a pervasive pattern of **grandiosity**, **need for admiration**, and **lack of empathy**." That's a very simple definition, but I like it because it's just what I said. **Grandiosity**, I think I'm awesome. A **need for admiration**, meaning

I need to use social relationships to keep myself feeling awesome. I need that feedback from other people to keep feeling awesome. And a **lack of empathy**. Don't really care that much about people. As long as they're giving me my ego needs, that's pretty much it. That's just the very basic idea of narcissism. You'll see there's these more grandiose and vulnerable faces that are more defensive or offensive, but that's the idea.

- 1.32** In terms of how this strategy or structure of this self works, as I said, the grandiose form of narcissism is what most of us think about. I'll talk about that in a second. That's the more offensive form. When I say offensive, I mean more self-promotional, attention-seeking, exhibitionistic, running in front of cameras whenever you get the chance. The more vulnerable form of narcissism is just more focused on defense. It's like, "People are going to find out I'm really a 6.5. I'd better stop them. Oh, that person thinks I'm a 6. They're a bad person." Those are the two different primary directions narcissism can go. It can go in a more grandiose and a more vulnerable direction. There's also a clinical disorder, which I mentioned, which is the **narcissistic personality disorder**. Those are the three primary faces of narcissism, like faces, more grandiose face, more vulnerable face, and then this clinical face.
- 1.33** There's also some other forms of narcissism I'm going to talk about just briefly, but I'll mention them right now. There's **communal narcissism**. There's not as much work on this, but this is when you're —it's like a form of **grandiosity** where you think you're the nicest person ever. "I'm the nicest person ever. No one's more giving than I am." Really? I'm just the most giving person. You do get that flavor of narcissism. There's a more **collective narcissism** where it's not about me, it's about my group. "My group is the most awesome thing ever. My group's a 10. Anyone who says my group's a 6.5 gets punched." There's that. There's different flavor of **grandiose narcissism** I'll hit a little bit, but I'm not going to do a lot in them during the course.
- 1.34** Starting out with a little more of a dive into **grandiose narcissism**. Again, **grandiose narcissism** is what most normal people will think about when you think about narcissism. What I mean by normal people—I shouldn't use the word—is people who aren't clinical psychiatrists or psychologists or clinicians or psychiatrists, just normal people in real life. When they run into narcissism, here's where people talk about narcissism. My ex-boyfriend is number one narcissistic. Number two is the last politician I voted for. They're number two narcissistic. Number three is my boss. He's pretty narcissistic. Number four is that Hollywood person, whoever it is. I don't know. Whoever that celebrity is, is narcissistic.
- 1.35** That's kind of, when we think about narcissism, the classic narcissistic figures we think about are like politicians, charming boyfriends that did us wrong, bad bosses. I tend to think of—my example in my own head has always been, lately, has been **Doctor Strange** from the Marvel movies. I don't know if you guys are familiar with him, but the reason I like his character as a grandiose narcissist is he really captures—I mean, he's a surgeon. Classic grandiose. I'll talk about all this, but classic **grandiose narcissism** is surgeons versus general practitioners. So he's a surgeon, well-groomed, attractive guy, custom suits, the whole deal. Gets his total life, his entire ego depends on his status and performance as a physician.

- 1.36 The plot of the movie is a guy is a physician, and then his fingers get broken, and he can't be a surgeon anymore. That's his entire meaning of life. He's empty after that. He goes from, "I'm the most important person and worth, to I'm empty, I am nothing if I don't have my social status." Now, a lot of us would be like, "Hey, I'm a great psychologist. I got bumped in the head. I'm dumb now. Well, at least I'm a dad. At least my kids will like me still, even if no one cares what I said. At least my dogs like me. I can be a good dog dad with 100 IQ. I might even be a better dog dad." But in Dr. Strange's case, he's got nothing because his whole life is his ego. Then the story is the hero's journey. He sets off on a journey to transcend himself.
- 1.37 If you watch those movies, it's funny because there's one movie where there's like 100 Doctor Stranges in 100 universes, and he destroys the universe in every single one, except the one in the movie where he turns out to be a really charming guy and a good husband. I'm sorry. There's a movie cycle where you have to take a really narcissistic character, and then they always turn into a good person at the end. It's this cycle of narcissism we see in movies. You don't see it as much in real life, but you see it in movies.
- 1.38 I got off on a Dr. Strange tangent, but that's a good example, this **grandiose narcissism**. We got somebody who's bold, somebody who's assertive, very confident in how they present, charming and charismatic. This guy's a jerk. I mean, Dr. Strange is a jerk. I wouldn't put up with that guy for one minute, but he's so charming and good-looking and smart, and I probably would put up with him and want to ride his Audi with them or whatever fancy car he had. You get a **sense of entitlement** and **antagonism**, so meanness. That **sense of entitlement** often you won't see right away. Often when you meet people who are grandiose, they're charming, they're extraverted, you really like them when you meet them, and then something gets in their way and you go, "Oh, my god, what an angry person. Man, you're really a monster underneath that." Sometimes there's this **entitlement** piece, this antagonistic piece.
- 1.39 Then with **grandiosity**, the **self-enhancement** isn't so much defensiveness. It's not like, "Hey, if people are looking at me and thinking I'm not as cool as I am," what you're seeing with **grandiosity** is more opportunities to **self-enhance**. Imagine with **grandiosity**, you're like, "I'm a 10, like legit, I'm a 10." And then they're like, "Hey, we're doing this, we're filming this thing. Do you want to be on TV?" And you're like, "Of course. Who wouldn't want me on TV?" And you just go on TV. So you're not going through life defensively. You're going through life offensively, like looking for opportunities. This is just more the wiring with **grandiosity**. Then if you get belittled, if you're like, "Here, it's my turn on TV," and somebody's like, "Get out of there, loser," then you'll get pissed off. But before that, you're just going to be moving and feeling good.
- 1.40 A final way, I love scales. I'm going to do a lot of scales today. I hope you don't get bored. But I find these useful because scales are interesting. It's a good way to get in the mind of somebody filling them out. These are some **self-report** items one of our Georgia grad students came up with that work really well. These are **self-report** traits for **grandiose narcissism**, meaning people who are grandiose narcissists will endorse or report that these traits reflect their own personality. Traits are glorious—I love that—acclaimed, high status, prestigious, powerful, and prominent. I like those words. Glorious, acclaimed, high status, prestigious, powerful,

prominent. But you can get a flavor of that, right? The term we use a lot is agency. Agentic. It's moving on itself. With **grandiose narcissism**, what you're seeing is a lot of agency. I'm awesome. I'm acclaimed. People care about me. I have prestige. I have status. I'm going to go win. That's **grandiosity** without vulnerability. That's just the grandiose part.

- 1.41 Now, we go in the other direction of vulnerability. That's grandiose face of narcissism. What's the vulnerable face? Well, the vulnerable face of narcissism is not what most normal people see. You might see it, but you might not recognize it. The people who end up seeing **vulnerable narcissism** are more clinicians. They're more psychiatrists or clinical psychologists, social workers, whatever. They'll see somebody in therapy who seems depressed, a little bit like, not the world. Life isn't going the way it should for them. They go, "Oh, this person's sad," and they start to talk to the person. They go, "Wait a second. This person thinks they're a big deal. Wait a second. Life's not going their way because people don't respect their natural talent and ability. There's some narcissism here."
- 1.42 And so it's a little harder to see this **vulnerable narcissism** right away. Sometimes people call it **covert narcissism** as opposed to overt because it's hard to see. In terms of vulnerably narcissistic figures, I'm stuck on **Woody Allen**. I'm sorry, I'm from a different generation, and no one talks about **Woody Allen** anymore. The other version that's from the '90s would be **George Costanza** from *Seinfeld*. I know the kids still watch *Seinfeld* a little bit, so that might be a better example. But it's this very neurotic, anxiety-filled, a little bit depressed, more defensive, anxious, self-centered presentation of narcissism. So with somebody like **Woody Allen** or **Costanza**, you're like, well, that person seems a little neurotic. They seem a little anxious. They don't seem narcissistic. They don't seem that confident. But what happens is, you push him a little bit and they go, "Yeah, I should be running the show. I should be a big deal. I should be important."
- 1.43 And there's this tremendous amount of self-focus, always thinking about yourself. How does this situation affect me? How does that situation affect me? It's a much more defensive flavor of narcissism without the obvious **grandiosity**. Where you see the **grandiosity**—this is an example from when I was a kid. It was one of my buddy's roommates, and he was sitting on a couch, this is in Costa Mesa, California, eating an In-N-Out burger, which was a big deal back in the day, about this big, watching *Jeopardy* and he goes, "That prize should be mine." He yells at the TV, "That prize should be mine," because he solved the final *Jeopardy* problem sitting on his couch, eating this gigantic cheeseburger the size of a kilo of gold.
- 1.44 And I thought, "Dude, you're sitting on your couch eating a cheeseburger. You didn't even apply. What are you thinking?" That's **vulnerable narcissism**. This guy, in his mind, he's a winner. He's really smart. People don't appreciate it. And when that nerd won that award, that award should have been his. So that's vulnerability. But people don't pick up on that as narcissism as much because it seems so pathetic. I shouldn't say that. That's a little judgmental. Yeah, but it seems a little pathetic in a judgmental way. That's how you end up in psychotherapy. You're in therapy because you're depressed. Then the reason you're depressed is because people don't see what a genius you are, and the therapist goes, "Well, how would they know you're a genius? What genius things have you done?" You go, "Well, I haven't really manifested my genius yet, but I

have an inner genius that's going to be manifested, and people should respect that." That's **vulnerable narcissism**. You're defending against your unmanifested genius.

- 1.45 In terms of the **self-report** traits that—this is [inaudible] **self-report** traits for vulnerability, which are great—I feel underappreciated. I love that word. I'm underappreciated. I feel insecure. It's that instability. I feel ashamed. The word shame in narcissism is really interesting. That's one of those emotions that you see every once in a while with narcissism, especially with vulnerability, a sense of shame. You got to get rid of that real fast. I feel envious because other people are getting the attention that should be mine. I feel resentful because I'm not getting everything that should be mine, and I'm self-absorbed. I don't have time or energy to really think about other people because I need to focus on myself and the attention that I'm not getting.
- 1.46 If you think about that, vulnerability and **grandiosity** are very different presentations of ego. One is much more in your face and confident and frankly, likable, even though they can do tremendous—so this is where it gets where grandiose narcissists can do much more damage because they're so likable, so charming. It's like they have a megaphone all the time. Vulnerable narcissists don't do as much damage, typically, because they're not out there impressing people as much, but they end up suffering a little more internally. It's a trade-off.
- 1.47 Oh, by the way, I'm using the term, like, narcissist, like grandiose narcissist. I'm doing that shorthand. These are dimensions. Instead of saying, "People who tend to score high on traits of **grandiose narcissism** also tend to score high on traits of defensiveness," I'm just saying grandiose narcissists are defensive. I'm just doing a short-circuit here. It's not technical. That's **grandiosity** versus vulnerability. People have talked about these two different forms of narcissism for, I don't know, 80, 90 years. I was just going to give you some of the different terms. It'd be manipulative narcissists, which is grandiose, versus craving, which is vulnerable. One is more about going out there and doing something. One is more about, I need something. Overt versus covert. Overt is what you can see, which is grandiose. Covert, you can't see vulnerable.
- 1.48 Thick-skinned versus thin-skinned. Grandiose narcissists are often very thick-skinned. You'd see somebody, and you're like, "You're a dork." They're like, "Yeah, shut up. I don't care." Somebody vulnerable is going to melt a little bit. Oblivious versus hypervigilant. Oblivious is a good term for grandiose narcissists. "I'm just thinking about myself. I just didn't notice that you were suffering because it just didn't quite hit my radar." What's that saying? It's below my line. "I'm suffering." "Just below my line. Sorry." That's oblivious narcissism. Vulnerability, we might call hypervigilant narcissism. I'm always looking for who's sliding me, who's making fun of me, who doesn't respect me. That kind of thing.
- 1.49 Exhibitionistic versus closet. I like that. Grandiose is more exhibitionistic, more attention-seeking. Sometimes we call it closet. **Vulnerable narcissism**, we used to call living in my mom's basement narcissism because I always imagined somebody living in their mom's basement on the internet, going, "Pay attention to me." Arrogant versus shy. That's pretty good. Classical narcissism versus diffident, so grandiose is more classical, vulnerable is more diffident. There's a

lot of these traits. These two dimensions of narcissism are just seen in a lot of places and a lot of people. I was writing about this once, and I got an email from a psychiatrist who said he'd retired, but written an article on these two forms of narcissism, and thought maybe he invented the two of them. He sent me this. He goes, "Mostly I'm retired playing pickleball. But I wrote this article," and I was like, "Well, that's great. There's a lot of people who've written this."

- 1.50 It was something that a lot of different people, a conclusion a lot of different people came to independently, which is what you want in science. What you want in science is a bunch of independent people coming to the same conclusion because that's how you validate what you have. This report of these two forms of narcissism, pretty well validated, pretty well established. In terms of how we measure these things, because this is science and we have to measure narcissism, the easiest way to measure any personality trait is with a **self-report** measure. A **self-report** measure is you give people a list of questions, 10 questions, 10 items, 20 items. A classic **narcissistic personality inventory** is a 40-item. It's called the 40-item **NPI**. You give them a list of items and they just answer it. I'll go through some of these scales.
- 1.51 People will ask, does **self-report** really work? Don't people lie about that? The answer is no. Typically, people who are narcissistic are like, "I like to look at myself in the mirror. Well, of course I do. Who doesn't?" They say that because that's what they do. "I look out for number one." It's a **psychopathy** item. Yeah, I look out for number one. When I first started doing this personality work, this is back when I was at University of Wisconsin, and another grad student there, **Don Lynam**, who's actually a professor now studying **psychopathy**, I remember asking him about it. He goes, "When I asked psychopaths about themselves, they'll say, 'I look out for number one, and you're an idiot not to.'" People are happy to report their own narcissism, their own **psychopathy**, their own meanness, because in their world, that's what they value. It's ego-syntonic for the most part.
- 1.52 But I should say this. **Self-report** only works in what we call low-stakes environments. If I have a bunch of kids filling out questionnaires on a computer screen and it's anonymous, people just tell the truth. But if I say, "Hey, want to work for my job? Here's a narcissism scale. What do you think?", the scores will be very different. When it's a high-stakes environment, people can manipulate their scores. So **self-report** works well for research, but it doesn't necessarily work as well in high-stake settings. What you tend to do, if you're in a setting that matters—a leadership setting, a forensic setting, a legal setting, a mental health setting—what you can do is you can do **self-report**, but you can also do other reports.
- 1.53 So I say, "Hey, Keith, fill out this narcissism questionnaire. Oh, by the way, can you get your wife to do it and your boss and your daughters to do it?" You want to see if the answers line up. If I'm like, "I'm the nicest guy ever," my daughter's like, "Dad's a narcissistic jerk." Wife's like, "I'm just waiting for the divorce papers to come in." Boss is like, "This guy's fired as soon as I can replace," you'll see an issue, right? So doing that peer report is really useful. If you get into the clinical world, what you're going to do are what are called **structured clinical interviews**. So you're going to sit down with somebody, you're going to go through a structured interview with questions,

and that's going to allow you as a clinical psychologist, not me, which I'm not, but a trained clinician to probe the responses a little bit, make sure they're right.

- 1.54 Typically, self-reported narcissism and clinical interviews line up pretty well. I mean, they line up remarkably well, to tell you the truth, but it's important to think about that. Then in terms of the measures, there's a few different measures. The shortest measure we have for narcissism is called the **SINS**. We always try to be clever in academia because we're so empty inside. The **SINS** is the **single item narcissism scale**. It's a one-item question. Here it is. "To what extent do you agree with this statement? I am a narcissist." Note, the word narcissist means egotistical, self-focused, and vain. That's the **single item narcissism scale**.
- 1.55 It actually works. It works reasonably well. It captures some **grandiosity**, but it also captures some vulnerability. Grandiose people usually don't want to say they're vain. Grandiose people usually say they're hot. Are you vain? No, I'm hot. They're different. Vain people are ugly people who think they're hot. But when you're just plain hot, you're just hot. It captures both of those things, but it works reasonably well. I think that was cool. Then for **grandiose narcissism**, again, the most popular questionnaire is the **Narcissistic Personality Inventory**. I'll show you some items from that in a second. There's the **vulnerable narcissism**, which the most common is the **Hypersensitive Narcissism Scale**. I'll show you a couple items from that in a second.
- 1.56 Then I wanted to mention two other scales really quickly, just because you might run into these if anyone's interested. One is a scale called the **Five-Factor Narcissism Inventory**, which when I talk about the next lecture, you'll see why this makes sense. Breaks narcissism into three different components, so that can be really useful for research side. There's another measure that's really big in Europe. Sounds like a rock band, big in the UK, but it's really big in Germany, called the **NARC**, which breaks narcissism in these two components that are more—they're called admiration and rivalry, which are a lot like **grandiosity** and vulnerability, but a little bit different. I'm mentioning that because there's a lot of good research on it, but it's a little different flavor to it.
- 1.57 But in terms of measuring **grandiose narcissism**, again, the classic measure back in the day is the **Narcissistic Personality Inventory**. Here are some items. I know that I am good because everybody keeps telling me so. I like to be the center of attention. I think that I'm a special person. I like having authority over other people. Everybody likes to hear my stories. I'm going to be a great person. I'm more capable than most other people. I like to look at myself in the mirror, and my favorite, if I ruled the world, it would be a much better place. That one is the only one I agree to. I'm like, yeah, I definitely would like to rule the world.
- 1.58 If you just listen to those items, those are capturing a sense of **grandiosity**, a sense of self-importance, a sense of mattering, a sense of worth, a sense of specialness. Generally, if I gave that to a bunch of 18-, 20-year-olds, people are going to respond positively to maybe a third of the questions, maybe a little more than that. They're going to endorse. It's not like people are like, "I like to be the center of attention. No way." Some people like to be the center of attention. Where it gets weird is if I like to be the center of attention and everyone recognizes

my authority and I'm really attractive and someone should write my biography and I should rule the world. That's **Napoleon**. I guess not like the new **Napoleon** movie, but like the original **Napoleon**. It's like, I'm really attractive, I'm hot, everyone looks up to me and I want to rule the world and someone should make a painting of me on a horse. That would be really good with my world ruling. That's **grandiose narcissism**, all those things together.

- 1.59 **Vulnerable narcissism** has a very different flavor to it. So these are items from the **Hypersensitive Narcissism Scale, HSNS**. I feel that I'm temperamentally different from most people. It's specialness, but not quite as special. I often interpret the remarks of others in a personal way, so I take things personally. I easily become wrapped up in my own interests and forget the existence of others. It's self-absorption. I feel I have enough on my hands without worrying about other people's troubles. It's narcissistic, but it's not so much grandiose. I love this one. I'm secretly put out when other people come to me with their troubles, asking for my time and sympathy. Darn those people, asking for my time and sympathy. But I like that item. It's a great one because I'm secretly put out. I won't tell them because that would be grandiose. I just fume a little inside.
- 1.60 My feelings are easily hurt by ridicule or by the sliding remarks of others. That's classic vulnerability. I dislike sharing the credit of achievement with others. I don't like sharing credit. That's something you see with grandiose and vulnerability. I dislike being with a group unless I know that I am appreciated by at least one of those present. That's again a very **vulnerable narcissism** line. I want to be respected, and I don't want to be in a group unless somebody there respects me. Whereas with **grandiose narcissism** is like, I don't want to be in a group unless it's a bunch of winners, and then they're lucky to have me. It's both about ego, one's offensive and promotional, one's defensive.
- 1.61 How do the demographics break down? Where do you find these different forms of narcissism? There's a new **meta-analysis**, a new study of studies that came out this year with about 400 authors on it, I think, like a quarter-million people. We have some really good data. What you'll see generally is men are more narcissistic than women. Just pretty much across the board, but it's not even across the board. So men are more narcissistic than women. The biggest difference is in **narcissistic personality disorder**, where you're looking at maybe two-thirds, three-quarters are diagnosed as men, depending on the data, say two-thirds men. You see a relatively large difference with **grandiose narcissism**. I mean, it's a correlation between gender and **grandiose narcissism**, it's like 0.2. It's not enormous, but there's, that's the larger of the differences, and then a smaller difference with **vulnerable narcissism**.
- 1.62 So men are a little more vulnerably narcissistic than women. They're meaningfully more grandiose narcissistic and significantly more likely to be diagnosed with **NPD**. Some of that diagnosis could just be bias in clinicians, and I'll talk about later, but sometimes they'll put men as narcissistic and women as **borderline** or **histrionic**, and it's a bit of a gendered diagnosis thing. In terms of age, where you see the most narcissism is young people, especially young males, which makes sense. You're out there trying to start your life, you got to get attention. You got to go build something. Being a little self-centered probably makes the most sense at that point. The

highest is at a young age. As people get older, narcissism tends to drop. It's a little higher in young men. It drops over time.

- 1.63** Being old and narcissistic is hard, and it's not who you want to be. You don't want to be my age. You don't want to be 20 years older than me going, "Yeah, I'm hot." You're not hot at 75. Maybe, I don't know, maybe that soccer player who's really good-looking will be or something. Nobody's really good-looking at 75. If you're 75 going, "Yeah, I'm going to get a bunch of status needs met because of my looks or my career performance," I mean, dude, if you're still working at your career at 75, you did something wrong. I shouldn't say that, but maybe you did something right. But typically, my point is, it's hard to be narcissistic when you're old, so it just drops as people go.
- 1.64** In terms of where narcissism comes from, it's very, at least the personality trait is very genetic. Just like a lot of personality, it's got a pretty good—it's inherited. It's **heritable**. We know this from looking at families. About 40 or 50%—these numbers are always a little rough—but about 40 or 50% of narcissism is just what you got wired from your family. In terms of the genes, we know enough now, I think I can safely say that there is no narcissism gene. There's not a single gene. There's not a group of two genes or three genes. What you're going to see in these large genetic studies is that narcissism is associated with a whole cluster of genes. It's not really going to make sense why, but we'll know from the twin studies and other **heritability** studies that a lot of it is genetic, and that's pretty much where we are. We know it's inherited, but we don't know what the genes are. I can tell you pretty certainly, it's not going to be a single narcissism gene. We gave up on those single genes about 10 years ago.
- 1.65** A big part of it is just how we're wired. A smaller percent, maybe 10, 20%, is parenting. People think parenting matters a lot, and parenting does matter a lot. It matters a lot that you love your kids and you feed your kids and you keep them safe and you keep a stable environment. But parenting doesn't make that much of a difference within the normal range. Within the normal range, this is like of who we study, you can take a kid and put them in a closet for five years and beat them, and they're going to be messed up. I'm saying within the normal range, parenting doesn't make that big a difference on a kid's personality.
- 1.66** People usually have, parents have their first kid. They're like, "I'm the greatest parent ever." Then they have the second kid. The second kid is totally different. They're like, "What the heck?" Then they become geneticists. They're like, "Oh, my god, it's just genetics. I thought I was a legend." The parenting is really a small part of narcissism. The difference, as you see with vulnerability, you see this sort of more cold and abusive parenting, the more conflict-filled negative parenting. With **grandiose narcissism**, you see a little more permissive parenting, putting your kid on a pedestal, making your kid feel like a big deal. It's a little more like a spoiled child would be your grandiose model.
- 1.67** Then the rest, like 20, 30% is just noise. It's random social life. It's who you end up hanging out with. It's your TikTok video you get in when—you're 14, You're totally fine, you watch TikTok, and next thing you know, you think you're Chris Pratt or something. Is that an actor, Pratt?

There's a Pratt. He's a good-looking guy, right? Yeah. I don't know if TikTok does that, really. In fact, I don't think so. But there's something about that non-shared environment that we just can't figure out. You have families. It's not like a family of narcissists. Usually, you might end up with one kid who's got really narcissistic traits, and the others don't. It's just a lot of variability in it.

- 1.68 I talk so much. I'm looking at that clock going, man, you talk. OK, I got to keep going. There are a lot of variables related to narcissism that come up all the time in these discussions, and I wanted to finish up touching on some of these. The first two I wanted to hit on are basically forms of **grandiose narcissism** I mentioned, which are collective and **communal narcissism**. **Collective narcissism** is really collective **grandiose narcissism**—it's the idea of, it's narcissism that doesn't apply to me. It applies to my social group or my state or my nation, whatever it is. It's questions like, my group deserves special treatment. If my group had a major say in the world, the world would be a much better place. The true worth of my group is often misunderstood. I will never be satisfied until my group gets the recognition it deserves. Again, **collective narcissism** is taking individual narcissism, but applying it to a group. It's like a form of toxic patriotism or something.
- 1.69 This scale is really interesting to people in political science because it predicts a lot of group conflict. Obviously, if you have a very narcissistic group and you run into your buddy down the street who's like, "My group's the best." "My group's the best!" And you start fighting it out. So **collective narcissism** is really interesting. Again, if you're into political science, I'm not going to talk about it much just because there's not a ton of data. It's a little different topic. The other form of narcissism I wanted to mention, because this is coming up in the research—I'm not going to talk about as much, but it's cool—is this idea of **communal narcissism**. When we talk about **grandiose narcissism**, it's generally about being high in status, being popular, being attractive, being smart, being clever, being powerful. That's your classic, "I'm a hot surgeon who has a cool car and a rocket ship." **Communal narcissism** is, "I'm the nicest person ever." It takes that **grandiosity** and it bends it towards **agreeableness**.
- 1.70 These are items from the **Communal Narcissism Scale** that was developed by a German psychologist named Jochen Gebauer. He's a very nice guy. So these are questions. I am the most helpful person I know. I'm going to bring peace and justice to the world. So instead of I'm going to make the world a better place, I'm going to bring peace and justice to the world. I am the best friend someone can have. I'm an amazing listener. I'm going to be the best parent on this planet. No, you're not. I'm sorry. But that's **communal narcissism**. So it's an inflated self, but it's in terms of these more prosocial domains.
- 1.71 When I was a kid, there was a skit on Saturday Night Live about the church lady, this moralistic church. I think it was played by Dana Carvey or something. That's what I always think about when I think of **communal narcissism**. It's like, I'm really nice. You're not really nice. You're being competitively nice. You bring a gift, and someone brings a better gift, and you go sabotage their gift because you want to have the best gift and stuff. It's an interesting form of narcissism. It's not as toxic. If you look at the data, people with more **communal narcissism** are nicer, generally

a little nicer than more grandiose narcissists that are more agentic. But it's a cool concept I wanted to bring up.

- 1.72 Another concept that gets mixed with narcissism a lot is **self-esteem**. **Self-esteem** is a positive attitude towards yourself. It's like an attitude you have about chocolate or cars or Miami. You just have an attitude about yourself. I like myself. That's **self-esteem**. When you measure **self-esteem**, the classic measure is the **Rosenberg Self-Esteem Inventory**. It has items like, I take a positive attitude towards myself. I feel that I'm a person of worth, at least on an equal plane with others. I feel I have a number of good qualities. You get the sense with **self-esteem**, it's like, I like myself, but I have a number of good qualities. Not like, if I ruled the world, it would be a better place. It's a more muted, more agreeable, more social form of narcissism.
- 1.73 Narcissism is not super-high **self-esteem**. They're a little different. They correlate. Narcissism is also not hidden low **self-esteem**. Another idea people have thought about, and I'll talk about this more clinically, is that, well, maybe people who are narcissistic, if you measured, really hated themselves deep down inside. We don't really see that, and I'll talk about what we do see later on. But basically, narcissism and **self-esteem**, they go together, but people with high **self-esteem** are a little more prosocial and a little less grandiose.
- 1.74 Another trait that goes with narcissism is **entitlement**, a **sense of entitlement**. That person has a pretty keen **sense of entitlement**. **Entitlement** is an aspect of narcissism. People who are narcissistic tend to have a high **sense of entitlement**, but they're not the same thing. They tend to be, one is sort of a subcomponent. These are some items from the **Psychological Entitlement Scale**, which we made —I mean, this was back in the '90s, I think. I honestly feel I'm just more deserving than others. Great things should come to me. I demand the best because I'm worth it. If I were on the Titanic, I would deserve to be on the first lifeboat. It's a terrible item. It doesn't translate at all, but I really like it. I feel entitled to more of everything. **Entitlement** is this sense of being deserving or being entitled to special treatment, special things. Remember I said, I care about my titles back in that first definition of narcissism? That's **entitlement**.
- 1.75 That is something that correlates with narcissism. Generally, high **entitlement**, you don't see the **extraversion**. So entitled people aren't as much fun as just, straight-up narcissists can be more fun to hang out with. I made this **entitlement** scale and I never studied it because I'm like, I just don't really like **entitlement** that much. I don't mind narcissism. **Entitlement**, I don't love. So that's **entitlement**.
- 1.76 There are a few other things people have done. One is they've looked at what's called the **Dark Triad**. This is a group of traits of three separate traits that go together, hence the name triad. What they all share is **antagonism** or meanness or callousness. The **Dark Triad**, and you see, you'll hear that, if I mention it, you're going to see it all over the place because this is pretty common. The three traits that make up the **Dark Triad** are **Machiavellianism**, **grandiose narcissism**, and **psychopathy**. **Machiavellianism** is a really interesting trait. The term **Machiavellianism** comes from, well, it comes from Niccolo, Niccoli, **Machiavelli**, who wrote a book called *The Prince*, which was a manual for how to manipulate middle-aged Italian kinglets

or whatever you call them, little principalities. It's a wonderful book about how to work your way through a political system.

- 1.77 People who are Machiavellian are very manipulative. Game of Thrones had lots of these very Machiavellian and Little Finger and the Bird guy, and these great Machiavellian figures. Items that measure Machiavellianism are things like, it's not wise to tell your secrets. I like to use clever manipulation to get my way. Whatever it takes, you must get the most important people on your side. It's wise to keep track of information that you can use against people later. I mean, that's just classic. That's Machiavellianism. It's related —you should wait for the right time to get back at people. I like that. Machiavellianism is really about manipulateness, but not so much about being the king. It's about being the manipulative thing behind the throne.
- 1.78 We've talked about grandiose narcissism. The third aspect of this is psychopathy. Psychopathy has a lot of aspects of narcissism, but also a lot of impulsivity, low self-control and meanness. It's things like payback needs to be quick and nasty. People often say I'm out of control. People who mess with me always regret it. I'll say anything to get what I want. That's more this more psychopathic, it's more aggressive and out of control, a lot more impulsive, but they're related. That's the Dark Triad. There's a few other triads people have talked about. Some of those people are me, and I don't know if I like them or not, but I'll just give you a few of these in the remaining moments.
- 1.79 You can think about a vulnerable Dark Triad. The same way grandiose narcissism goes into the Dark Triad, you can think of vulnerable narcissism, aligning with other more vulnerable neurotic or anxiety-filled traits like borderline personality and Factor 2 psychopathy. The vulnerable Dark Triad would be like vulnerable narcissism, borderline personality traits, and Factor 2 psychopathy, which is a more neurotic, impulsive form of psychopathy. I'm getting in the weeds here. I'll just jump out of the weeds real fast. You can play with that idea of neuroticism.
- 1.80 You can play with the more energized piece of grandiose narcissism and talk about an energized triad. So grandiose narcissism looks a bit like a trait hypomania. Hypomania is a low level of constant mania or energy you see. So it's a very energized form of life. And also, psychological boldness. So boldness is a really cool trait. This is like the Chuck Yeager fighter pilot trait. Just very high extraversion, very high assertiveness, but not necessarily self-centered or mean, just bold. So the energized triad is that grandiose narcissism, boldness, and hypomania.
- 1.81 Then there's a Light Triad. This is my friend Scott Barry Kaufman talks about. I don't use this, but I like it because it's positive. But it focuses on more the more positive aspects of human ego. It is made up of humanism, which is this belief that other people are valuable. A faith in humanity, this willingness to see the best in people. I have faith that people are going to come through for me. Then this word Kantianism, based on the philosopher Immanuel Kant, which is like, I prefer honesty over charm. Instead of like, I like charming, shallow, fake stuff, I prefer honesty over charm. This more Light Triad is a more pro-human approach to narcissism.

- 1.82 Just to wrap this up in the final minutes, narcissism has been around a long time. We're looking at, well, thousands of years from the myth, and as a psychological construct, a couple hundred years. That's a lot. It's really complex, which I think is cool because I've been studying it for 25, 30 years. But it also has these really important core features, and we're going to see these over and over and over, which is, I'm pretty awesome. I don't really connect with people that well emotionally, but I like to be around them. And then I like to self-regulate. I like to enhance myself or protect myself. What else do I want to mention? We can measure narcissism easily. It relates to a lot of other traits. And in our next lecture, I'll do a deep dive into how narcissism works and how the traits of narcissism work. That's it. Thank you very much.

2. Unveiling Narcissism

AT A GLANCE

Explains the mechanics of narcissism from two directions. First, dynamics: narcissism as a self-regulation system modeled on a thermostat, with grandiose self-enhancement (sex, status, stuff) and vulnerable self-protection triggered by ego threat, producing pride, rage, and shame, plus consequences such as failed narcissism, situationally acquired narcissism, and easy manipulation by flattery. Second, traits: the lexical hypothesis, the Big Five (OCEAN), and the nomological network, leading to the trifurcated model in which antagonism is the core, extraversion produces grandiosity, neuroticism produces vulnerability, and both together approximate NPD. Ends with questions on collectivist cultures, narcissists together, parenting, and why narcissists attract us.

- 2.1 Welcome back for the second lecture. What I wanted to do is drill into some of the mechanics of narcissism. This is how narcissism works. These are the things that I get excited about because they're a little bit nerdy. They might not be that interesting to you, but it's a cool way to think about the processes and structure that underlie narcissism.
- 2.2 What I wanted to do today was come at this from two different directions. First thing I want to do is talk about the dynamics of narcissism. Dynamics is a term that means movement. What I mean by that is something like self-regulation, goal-related behavior, motivation, emotion, those kind of things. There's this dynamics that go with narcissism. I'm not going to talk about the real intense psychodynamics that we talk about in narcissistic personality disorder. I'm just going to talk about the normal dynamics. Then I want to talk about narcissism as a personality variable and come at it from sort of a quantitative personality approach. I'm going to come at it both as a dynamical system and as a personality model. These are just two different ways to think about it, and both of them are really useful.
- 2.3 So thinking about self-regulation, humans can be thought of as self-regulating, goal-directed machines. There's a lot of interest in this, a lot of things in the middle of the last century, in the '50s, '60s, '70s. People talked about cybernetics, cybernetic models, or control theory. Basically, this was a bunch of people taking ideas from engineering and saying, "Hey, how can we apply those engineering-like models to human behavior? How can we use that to model human behavior?" So, I'll give you just a very simple example. About the simplest example of a self-regulatory device you can think of, as something like a furnace or a thermostat in your house. It's wintertime, I'll think about it like a thermostat.
- 2.4 Imagine you go in your house and it's 60 degrees and you want it to be 70 degrees. You go to your thermostat and you push 70 degrees. So then the magic happens. The machine tests the air, goes, "Well, my goal is to be 70. It's really 60. I'd better start doing something. I'd better turn the heat on. I'd better operate." So they turn the heat on. The heat starts running, then the thermostat tests again. It's not quite this simple, but I'm making it more simple. How is it now? "Oh, it's 65. Well, we're going in the right direction. That's awesome. But better keep going."

Keep the heat on." Heat goes on. Tests again. "How hot is it? 70 degrees. Oh, perfect. 70 is where I want to be. Let's shut off." What that is called in engineering is a **tote loop**. Test, operate, test, exit. It's a very simple **self-regulation** idea. I test my environment, and then I operate to get where I want to be. Once I get to my goal, I shut down the system.

- 2.5 Now, instead of turning on a thermostat, what if we just thought about this as turning on my ego? How do you want to be? I want to be a 10 out of 10. How do you feel right now? Dude, I feel like a 6. Well, what do we do? I'd better start to operate. How do I do that? Well, I go **self-enhance**. I'm going to go get a haircut. I'm going to go buy a Beemer, and then I go test. How is my ego? Well, I'm in an 8 now. Well, that's better. That feels good. I'm going in the right direction. What am I going to do? Better operate. I'm getting a good-looking girlfriend. That's what I'm going to do. I'm going to start posting on the Instagram. I'm going to start a Facebook club. I'm starting a YouTube channel. I'm a 10. And so you test, I'm a 10. You go, OK, now I can stop and relax.
- 2.6 That's the idea. That's a very, very simple model of how **self-regulation** works. You set up a goal, you operate to that goal, and when you get to that goal, you stop the system. That's a very simple dynamic model of narcissism. You can think about narcissism as a strategy for **self-regulation**, meaning I'm regulating an aspect of myself. What am I regulating? Well, there's been several different descriptions of what narcissists want. Some people talk about **self-esteem** regulation. Maybe what I want to do is, my thermostat is set to have a really high **self-esteem**, and as long as my **self-esteem** is high, I'm good, and when it drops, I go operate and to get some more **self-esteem**. So maybe it's about **self-esteem**.
- 2.7 Maybe it's not so much **self-esteem**. Maybe it's maybe what I call narcissistic esteem. Maybe it's more about a little more self-centered, prideful **self-esteem** that's a little bit more energetic. Maybe that's it. Maybe what I'm regulating is the positivity of myself. I just want to think I'm a 10 out of 10. It's not so much I'm regulating my feelings, I'm regulating how I see myself. Sometimes people think about it, this is just **ego inflation**. I'm just puffing up my ego. A lot of times people use a metaphor like blowing hot air into something. I got to keep my ego inflated. I got to keep it puffed up. You can think about this as maybe just **ego inflation**.
- 2.8 There's something going on that narcissists are getting, which has to do with esteem and positivity. That's what your goal is. There's two different directions for getting that **self-regulatory** goal. The grandiose direction, and we're going to come back to this theme, is about looking for opportunities to **self-enhance**. So grandiose narcissists, to get to that goal of being awesome, that narcissistic goal, are looking for opportunities to **self-enhance**. How do you do that? Well, you seek fame, you seek attention, you seek admiration, you seek leadership, you seek social status. You do all sorts of things in that direction. You're going and looking for opportunities to look good. I want to shine.
- 2.9 Vulnerability is the path of **self-regulating** in a defensive way to avoid more ego threats. So vulnerability is about hiding from threats, about people not detecting how negative you are. Instead of being aggressive, maybe it's about being a little passive-aggressive because then you

won't get confronted with your aggression. But it's much more in the direction of **self-protection**. So again, think about, I want my ego to be in this awesome space. To do that, I have to keep putting it up there. I have to keep enhancing it, but I also have to protect it from people that are going to bring it down. You need both those aspects of **self-regulation**.

- 2.10** The classic, if you boil down **grandiose narcissism** into **self-regulation**, there's three things that come up: **sex, status, and stuff**. That's the big three. Sex means you want a lot of sexual partners or you want attractive sexual partners. When we talk about relationships, you'll see it. It's very much about boosting one's ego via having an attractive partner or having lots of partners. You can do it either way. That's one path. Status is another path. People who are narcissistic can seek it through status, becoming a leader, becoming an expert, becoming a—hanging out with people from important associations. Saying that I went to an Ivy League—well, I guess until about a month ago—saying I went to an Ivy League school was, like, a real flex. That's when people will—I associate with these popular people.
- 2.11** Whatever they're doing, they're trying to look at material. Marketing is all about a lot of the stuff part of it. So sex, status, and then stuff. So stuff is, I want a fancy car, I want a cool watch. I want to wear an awesome suit. I want to be well-groomed, etc. So this is the basis of a lot of marketing and a lot of consumer behavior is—sorry, let me just make it real simple for you. A lot of marketing is you tell the world, "Hey, you're a loser." Then the world goes, "I'm so sad." They go, "But you can be a winner if you buy our product." You go, "Oh, I feel happy." Then you buy the product. Marketing is just making people feel they have a deficit in their ego and then selling them something to fill it up.
- 2.12** How would you feel driving that new Porsche 911? I think I'd feel quite proud. I would feel quite good. That's marketing. I drive a really, I drive like a 2013 minivan. I shouldn't say that. Now, I'm going to be attacked by somebody. But if you find me, I'm usually in my Honda Odyssey, called the Hodessey. I bought my girls a car. I bought them a 4Runner. I shouldn't tell you that either. But that's my girls' Runner. I drove it from the dealership, driving this 4Runner, which isn't a super fancy car. I love it, man. It's nice. All of a sudden, I felt I had **self-esteem**. I'm driving down the interstate, and I'm like, people are looking at my car and I'm like, "I feel good. Is this what it's like having a nice car?" It was just this whole game in my head. I'm like, "I need one of these. I don't care what it costs. I need to feel this feeling more." That's marketing. That's buying a product.
- 2.13** The term we can use for this sometimes in social psych is **symbolic self-completion**. "I feel I should be this person. It's hard for me to get there, but I'm going to buy something to complete that symbolism." I want to be an intellectual. I could either go get a PhD or I can get some cool glasses, and that'll short-circuit that or whatever. That's the stuff part of it. But this is all about **self-regulation**. It's all about ego regulation, and it's a huge part of life.
- 2.14** The other side of it is classic **ego threat**, which is ego protection. What triggers **self-protection**? The classic trigger is what we call **ego threat**, which is somebody—how do I define **ego threat**, other than saying somebody threatening your ego? Somebody telling you or presenting you

information that yourself isn't as positive as you think it is. I walk out of here. I'm like, I'm feeling pretty good. Someone goes, "Hey, loser." I feel bad. That's the **ego threat**. Or like, I don't know. I might even thinking about—sorry, I'm just thinking of every insult people could tell me, and I don't really need to share those with you, but there's lots of insults that would work on me.

- 2.15 **Ego threat** triggers sometimes shame, but a lot of times it triggers anger. "Hey, loser." "Shut up. You're the loser." That's the narcissistic aggression. **Ego threat** is the primary trigger. You sometimes see this narcissism defensiveness with social rejection. "Hey, you're not invited to my team," or, "Hey, you can't be a member of the country club," or, "Hey, you didn't get into my fancy university." That's going to trigger—that kind of rejection is going to trigger defensiveness, and it's going to be, "Your university sucks. I didn't want to go there anyway. I hate your club," whatever it is.
- 2.16 So you have **self-protection** and **self-enhancement** and **self-protection**, and they have different emotions that go with them. **Self-enhancement** is accompanied by a sense of esteem, a sense of positive emotionality, a sense of energy, and a sense of pride. There's some really interesting work Jessica Tracy did on pride and narcissism, but the pride, you seem, is a little more of what they call **hubristic pride**. It's like, "Oh, I'm better than you," with the arms akimbo. I love that word akimbo. It's more that. It's not like, "Yes, I did it." It's more "I'm better than you" pride. You get that positive stuff.
- 2.17 And with the more **ego threat** and defensiveness with narcissism, you classically see hostility, that slow-burn stuff. You see anger. Sometimes you see **narcissistic rage**. That's the clinical term for this, when people just lose their mind. I can get this at the airport. "Oh, no, your flight was delayed 6 months." You're like, "It's all about me. The weather's out to get me." You get rage, and sometimes you see shame. Occasionally, you see shame. Usually, the shame gets covered up very quickly if you see it, but that's the more defensive reaction.
- 2.18 You can think about narcissism as a dynamic, as very much of a cycle. You start off with some narcissism. You're motivated to go get more. I want to go get some of this stuff. I go get some sex, status, or stuff. I get a cool car, and then I get a cool girlfriend. That reinforces my sense of esteem. It reinforces my ego. I'm like, "Man, I'm awesome. I'm going to go do more." Get a fancy new suit, get a better car, and it just works like a cycle. If you're building your ego, it works great. Then when it stops working, it stops working. It doesn't work. I'll talk about this in a second. But there's a dynamic with narcissism.
- 2.19 If you think about it, your cup—this is like the myth of **Narcissus**, right? Like your cup's never filled because you're an 8. I keep changing the numbers here; I apologize. You're an 8, but you want to be a 10. So you're always trying to fill that cup up to get to a 10 instead of just going, "Dude, I'm an 8. God bless, I'm lucky to be an 8. It could have been a 6. Those poor 6s out there." So it's a constant game. It's a constant dynamic to keep narcissism moving.
- 2.20 In terms of these dynamics of narcissism, there's some things here that are really interesting just to point out before I go into the personality models. The first is that because narcissism is a

dynamic, as I just said, you've got to keep going like a shark. I think of, like, sharks—you know, you can never sleep. You've just got to keep swimming. Sometimes I think of hurricanes, like you just got to keep over that warm water, keep sucking up warm water. As soon as that stops, you turn into a tropical depression. It's all over. With narcissism, you've got to keep moving. You've got to keep filling yourself with **self-esteem**. You got to keep filling the bucket. It just never stops. That's a hard life.

- 2.21** Everything, or almost everything in your life, if you're narcissistic, can be used as a tool for regulating **self-esteem**. What that means is whatever social circumstance you enter, it's about that circumstance plus **self-esteem**. So you start, you go meet your new girlfriend, and it's about a relationship, and it's about your ego. You go start a new job, you've got a new day at work—it's about the work, but it's also about your ego. You go shopping for groceries. It's about eating, but it's also about your ego because you want to bring home the right brand so no one thinks you're not cool. Everything in your life becomes part of this giant effort to self-regulate and inflate your ego. It really sucks because everything gets covered with just this ego needs. And it's not everything. I mean, it's not the only thing, but it becomes part of everything in your life. You can't get rid of it.
- 2.22** The other thing that's really cool, or a couple of other things are really cool with the idea of a narcissistic dynamic, is you can intervene in this cycle at any point and stop it. Imagine I'm getting esteem from my looks. Well, if you make it so I'm not attractive anymore, you change the norms of attractiveness, or I just get ugly—I don't know what happens. You just uglify me, put an ugly filter on me—my narcissism stops working. And what you end up with then is **failed narcissism**. You end up with somebody who's trying to be narcissistic, and it's just not working for them. Then you start to see people really spin out of control because they get angry, they start to break down, you start seeing drug use or alcohol use. The **failed narcissism** is a hard thing to go through. But that's because it's a system you can intervene.
- 2.23** That way, you can also potentially intervene in a system where if somebody's, even if they're a pretty normal person, you start giving them a lot of narcissistic or very positive feedback, there's the potential that you can create narcissism. The way they talk about this in the clinical literature is **situationally acquired narcissism**. Imagine you're a celebrity. All of a sudden, you're on a celebrity TV show or something, and then you become famous. Then everybody, once you're famous, your life's different. Everyone's nice to you. Everyone thinks your jokes are funny. I remember when I was a department head, it was great. Everyone laughed at my jokes. I thought I was so funny. Then when I didn't have any power anymore, my jokes weren't funny anymore. It's just magic.
- 2.24** The idea is that if you start inflating somebody's ego, it can essentially go to their head. It can go to their head, and they can become narcissistic. There's not a ton of evidence for this. Well, I can't think of anyone who's really done a study where they made people famous. They've looked at famous people. Anyway, I don't know if this happens, but you will talk to people who are celebrities who make a very intentional effort to keep themselves grounded. So you'll hear some celebrities say, "Yeah, I live in a tiny shack in Idaho somewhere, when I'm not working in

Hollywood because it keeps my ego grounded," or "I hang out only with old friends that I knew before I was famous," or "I hang out with, you know, whatever. I do a lot of woodworking because that keeps me grounded, whatever." People will do things to avoid some of that fame from going to their head. That's another idea of a system.

- 2.25 Then finally, with narcissism being a system, it means we can manipulate people who are narcissistic very easily. How do you manipulate somebody who's narcissistic? Well, the easiest thing to do is flattery, which is not complicated. Somebody thinks you're a big deal. You're like, "Hey, you're a big deal. Great to meet such a big deal as yourself." The person goes, "God, I really like you, Keith. There's something about you I like." We feel real simpatico. I'm like, "Of course we do. You're a legend. I mean, I'm just glad to be here with you." "Thanks, man." Easy, right?
- 2.26 Back in the radio days, I did a radio talk show with these pair of women. One of the women was a madam. She ran a brothel. I don't know what you, I guess, technically call that, brothel owner. We were talking about narcissism, and she starts laughing. She goes, "Yeah, you know what we call these people?" I said, "What?" She goes, "We call them marks." Marks is, like, when you con people, like in confidence games; it's a sucker, a mark. "Why do you call them marks?" "Well, they're just so easy to take their money. All we do is just tell them how great they are, how attractive they are, how powerful they are, and they just keep paying us money. Just the easiest job in the world, just sucking up to some narcissists and have them just write you checks." I thought, "Well, that's pretty sad, but it makes sense." That's just using **self-regulation**.
- 2.27 The other way you can use **self-regulation** with people who are narcissists are destabilizing them. So this is the classic court case. You have the person on trial. "I'm really nice. I've really got it together." You say, "Yeah, how was that time in 1984 when they took that picture of you in that ugly lime-colored suit and then showed it on the Instagram?" And then they got all angry and destabilized. That was a terrible example, and none of that made any sense. I'm sorry. It's like, what a dumb example. What lime suit in the Instagram? They didn't wear lime suits when they had Instagram. That was the '70s. It's all stupid. But the idea is if you threaten somebody—imagine somebody's on the stand and you're like **Perry Mason**, who is an old TV lawyer. Then you tell them an **ego threat**, and they get angry. Then everyone in the jury goes, "Oh, that's really an angry person. I wouldn't have seen that." You can use that **ego threat** to destabilize people.
- 2.28 Narcissism makes you weak because you're so desperate. It's like being an ego addict. It's you're desperate, and so people can control that ego supply and manipulate you. They don't teach you that in narcissism training, but it makes you vulnerable to all those things. So this idea of narcissism as **self-regulation**, as goal-setting, as an emotional process, I think it's really important. And when we start talking about relationships, when we talk about narcissism in the workplace, when we talk about narcissism in social media, which we're going to do, it's all going to be about **self-regulation**, or a lot of it's going to be about **self-regulation**, **self-enhancement**, and **self-protection**. But what I wanted to do now was go in to another direction, was thinking about narcissism as a personality trait. I want to talk about how we can think about narcissism

as a trait and map it on to a broader model of personality traits. This is more classic personality psychology or quantitative personality psychology and narcissism.

- 2.29 What is a personality trait? A personality trait is a consistent pattern of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors across time and situations. A personality trait is something that we possess as individuals that makes us consistent in our behavior across time. I'm this way now. Like I always say, I'm very extraverted. I'm very extraverted now. If you met me in 6 months, I hopefully will be very extraverted. If you met me 5 years ago, you'd be like, "Well, that's a pretty extraverted guy." I haven't changed that much. I used to be more neurotic when I was a kid, a little shy. I'm generally extraverted across time and also across situations, meaning, I'm here, I'm pretty extraverted. I'm at the airport, I'm pretty extraverted. I'm teaching class, I guess this is the same. I go to a funeral, I'd probably be pretty extraverted. I mean, any situation, I jump in a cab, I'm best friends with everybody. That's just how I am. Across time and across situations.
- 2.30 The other thing to mention is that it's an individual difference, so suggesting that some people are more extraverted and some people are less extraverted. So there's going to be variability on these traits. So most personality traits, there's an average, and they fall in a normal bell-shaped distribution, and there's probably an optimal level, which is somewhere in the middle, and then there's the extremes that are high or low. How many personality traits are there? Well, conceivably, we have thousands, literally thousands, of individual personality traits we could study. The way we know this goes back to an idea called the **lexical hypothesis**. This lexical means word, something like word. I forget my Latin. I hope it's not Greek. That would be really embarrassing. Maybe it is Greek.
- 2.31 The idea with the **lexical hypothesis** is that, if there is a personality trait that's important to us in our culture, we will come up with a word for it. It's a very simple idea. If something matters enough, we will come up with a single word for it. If being creative matters in our culture, we will come up with a word for creative. If being kind matters in our culture, we will come up with a single word for kind. Occasionally, there are things we don't have a word for, and we want to come up for it, and we have to grab it from another language. In psychology, a word that people like is *schadenfreude*. It's sort of taking pleasure in somebody else's suffering. There isn't a good English word for that, so we had to go to the Germans and get a word from them. Sometimes we have to go borrow words from people. It's not really a personality trait, kind of is, *schadenfreude*-ish.
- 2.32 If you start looking at trait adjectives in English, you end up with several thousand, 4,000, 3,000, 6,000, depending on how you do that. So you imagine a thousand different traits, kind and clever and cautious and extraverted and anxious and angry and hostile and all these different traits. There's thousands of these traits. Well, you can't really do a science with a thousand traits. That's just too much. So over the past, it's been over, it's been about 120 years, what people have done is they said, well, let's take these thousands of personality traits and try to make a narrower model, a smaller model. Let's try to group them together. Let's take kindness and compassion, and we'll say they're kind of the same. We'll say cooperative, and that's kind of

the same. Being agreeable is kind of the same. That's the opposite of being mean, but they're kind of the same. We'll throw those all in one big bucket.

- 2.33 We'll take all those traits, and we'll take another group of traits, like creative and curious and thoughtful and philosophical, and we'll take those and throw them in another bucket. We'll take another group of words like extraverted and assertive and energized, and we'll throw those in another bucket. We do that. I kept going. But you end up with five buckets. These aren't magic buckets. It's not like God made five buckets of personality traits, and this is what, on the fifth day or whatever, he said, "Fifth day, there's five traits." It's just this is what's useful for the science. Some people like six buckets, some people like three buckets, some like two buckets. It's cool. You can like as many buckets as you want. Five buckets work pretty well.
- 2.34 Those five buckets of personality traits, we called the **Big Five**, because they're such big buckets of traits. And those **Big Five** traits represent our most common general model of personality, meaning it captures a lot of personality in those **Big Five** traits. The way you remember those **Big Five** traits is that they spell **OCEAN** or CANOE. But mostly you remember **ocean** because canoes aren't cool, apparently, but oceans are cool. The easiest way to remember the **Big Five** is remembering that they spell **OCEAN**, the first letter of each one. I can go through those very quickly. I'm going to talk about these **Big Five** traits, personality traits, and I'm going to bring this back to how narcissism fits in, just so you know where we're going. But I got to set it all up first.
- 2.35 The **Big Five** that spell **OCEAN**, first of these is **openness** or **openness** to experience, sometimes called intellectance. This is a combination of curiosity, creativity, interest in aesthetics or art, and maybe an interest in philosophical or intellectual pursuits. It's this creative, artistic, philosophical personality trait. It's just a trait that's high in artists, trait that's high in philosophers, that kind of thing. The next is **conscientiousness**. **Conscientiousness** is a combination of organizational skills, discipline, but also things like industriousness and grit. If you ever heard of the trait grit, which is a common personality trait, that's an aspect of **conscientiousness**. **Conscientiousness** is the work trait. This is what you want in a worker. Well, this is the trait you want if you want to succeed in a lot of things because it's just work, especially that industry piece. So **conscientiousness**.
- 2.36 The E is for **extraversion**, which **extraversion**, most of us know of as sociability, that talkative and gregarious and sociability. That's a big piece of it. The other piece of **extraversion** we don't see as much is assertiveness or drive for leadership. Being assertive or wanting to be a leader is an aspect of **extraversion**. A, I'm spelling **OCEAN** here, A is for **agreeableness**. **Agreeableness** is a combination of compassion, deep caring and compassion, but also cooperativeness, niceness, getting along. People who are agreeable tend to get along, they tend to be cooperative, and they also tend to be compassionate.
- 2.37 When I'm describing these, you can see how you go, "Oh, I can imagine somebody who's really compassionate, but also doesn't get along with everybody because they're kind of a rule-breaker." My answer is, "Yes, you can." Yes, you can have combinations of these **Big Five** traits. These are very big buckets, and often those things are interesting. Then finally, we end up,

OCEAN, with the N for **neuroticism**. **Neuroticism** is a trait that captures sadness, anxiety or fearfulness, and vulnerability, or being overwhelmed. When you think about **vulnerable narcissism**, that's **neuroticism**. A more neurotic personality is one that's anxious, a little feel sad, and feels overwhelmed by events. One way I like to think about it, about **neuroticism**, is threat detection. People who are neurotic are really good at detecting threats in the environment. Sometimes they're dialed up a little too high, so they're detecting too many threats. That's when you have an anxiety issue. Sometimes people are dialed too low. If your **neuroticism** is too low, you can get into issues as well.

- 2.38 I should say that, so those are the **Big Five** traits. Each of the **Big Five** traits can have benefits or costs on both sides. So they're not good or bad. They're mostly a trade-off. So people who are really extraverted can talk over people, like I do all the time, not be good listeners. People who are conscientious can become stuck in organization, become too organized and not be able to function. People who are open can just get real weird, been there. People who are too agreeable can be doormats, get run over. We usually think of **neuroticism** as bad, but people who are really low in **neuroticism** can be at risk because they don't detect threats.
- 2.39 I got this buddy who just, like, I just see him doing insane things all the time. He just doesn't have any fear. My favorite story, god, I tell so many of these stories, poor guy. But one is, he was running a triathlon and passed out. He was in Florida, I think, and he passed out on the side of the freeway. Somebody found him, picked him up, got him in an ambulance, and then he got mad. He's like, "I can't believe. I was fine. I can't believe the ambulance—" I'm like, "Dude, you were dead on the side of the road. You probably would have died." He's like, "I was fine." Like, the dew would have rehydrated— I'm sorry. **Neuroticism** can be helpful at times. One time, he was swimming out. This is one of these, like Myrtle Beach or something. He's swimming out past the breakers going up and down. I'm with his wife, and she goes, "Is he going to get eaten by a shark?" I'm like, "Yeah, there's a pretty good shot a bull shark would be out there." I said, "I can't get him if it happens. I'm not going to get him. He's too far out." Oh, well.
- 2.40 What I mean is, there's problems on both sides of these traits. They're not good or bad. You have these **Big Five** traits, and these are the big markers in our map of personalities. Imagine as a personality psychology go, "Man, we've got all these traits. How do we make sense of them?" Well, what we do is we put them together in what's called the **nomological network**. That's a fancy word. **Nomological network**. It's like the network of meaningful traits at the population level. I sometimes think of it as a galaxy of stars. You've got these big ones up there. You've got **openness** and conscientious, the **Big Five** that you really see. Then you have lots of specific traits.
- 2.41 In the last 150 years, psychologists have been interested in lots of specific traits for their own areas. People, let's say, in cardiology and heart medicine, were like, "Hey, who gets heart attacks? I notice these really uptight patients. They're always stressed out. They're grabbing their seats when they come in. Maybe we should study those guys." Well, that's what we call type A personality. That's one area of personality. Maybe somebody else is like, "I'm really interested in risk-taking. I want to find out those people who skydive over there. Well, maybe I'll

study sensation-seeking. We'll call that type S." There's a big sensation-seeking. Maybe you're a Jungian and you start doing the Myers-Briggs and you end up with, what is it? Sensation, thinking, feeling, and intuition. You end up with a Jungian version of a scale. You can end up with lots of—that's actually more of a general scale. You can end up with lots of specific measures, including narcissism, **grandiose narcissism** and **vulnerable narcissism**.

- 2.42 The way I look at these is, like I said, it's like a galaxy, and every trait relates to every other trait in this large network. Every single personality trait is going to relate in some way to every other trait. Might be positive, might be negative, might be neutral, but there's going to be some relationship there. How do we think about narcissism in terms of this **nomological network** and these **Big Five** traits? What **grandiose** and **vulnerable narcissism** share, the core feature of narcissism, is low **agreeableness**, what we might call **antagonism**. Often we'll say **antagonism** because that's the opposite of **agreeableness**. We'll say what they share is trait **antagonism** or low **agreeableness**.
- 2.43 With **grandiosity** and vulnerability, both of them share low **agreeableness**. It's a little different flavor. People who are more vulnerable are a little less trusting. They're a little more worried about people out to get them. People who are grandiose, are a little more grandiose, they just think they're better than people, have a higher sense of superiority, a little less compassion, those things. But there's this general sense of, "I matter more than other people. I have a **sense of entitlement**. And yeah, I'm better than people." So that low **agreeableness** is key and core to all forms of narcissism.
- 2.44 Where you get the difference is primarily with **extraversion** and **neuroticism**. So **grandiose narcissism** is that low **agreeableness**, coupled with **extraversion**. So you imagine you get somebody who's mean, self-centered, and arrogant, but they're also energized, assertive, and sociable. I kind of think of that as weaponized **antagonism**. So it's a neat trait. So what you have is somebody who you meet at first and you go, "That person's really extraverted. I like them. They got a lot of positive energy." And then you get to know them and you're like, "But they're kind of a jerk." That's **grandiose narcissism**. It's combining that agentic **extraversion**, that energy, with the **antagonism**.
- 2.45 **Vulnerable narcissism** is the other side. You have that **antagonism**, but rather than having this confidence and **extraversion** with it, you have **neuroticism** and this threat detection. "I'm a big deal. Does everyone notice I'm a big deal? Who's going to say I'm not a big deal? Is someone going to threaten me? Is someone going to bust my ego down?" That sense, "I'm easily overwhelmed. I'm vulnerable." So if people say a bunch of negative stuff to me, it's going to make me feel bad. It's going to put me on my back. That's **vulnerable narcissism**. So **vulnerable narcissism** is this **antagonism** coupled with **neuroticism**. This is why, when you meet people who are vulnerable—or this explains why when you meet people who are vulnerably narcissistic, they're not that likable because they don't have the **extraversion**. They don't have the high **extraversion**. What they have is this insecurity, this **neuroticism**, coupled with a sense of superiority and mistrust.

- 2.46 It's also why people don't see **vulnerable narcissism** very quickly. They see **neuroticism**, and they see somebody neurotic. "Oh, that person must be sad. They must be depressed. Maybe I can help them." And they're like, "Yeah, you can help me by getting out of my way because I'm a winner." What? So it's a very different—you see, so that's the difference between these two things. If you put these together, if you take all this and wrap it together, what you end up with is what we call the **trifurcated model** of narcissism. I made that name up in a Twitter debate once, and I apologize for that because it's an ugly name. **Trifurcated model**. I meant trifurcated instead of bifurcated, but that's not a good word either, meaning it's broken into three parts. I should have called it the triangular model of narcissism. That would have been better. But it was a Twitter debate back in the days when people would debate on Twitter, and it was fun. But it's a very useful way for thinking about it.
- 2.47 What do I mean by a **trifurcated model**? Well, the foundation of narcissism are these three aspects, these three **Big Five** traits. **Extraversion**, especially the more assertive, agentic form of **extraversion**, low **agreeableness** or **antagonism**, and that **neuroticism**, that threat detection. You take those three basic pieces, take those three pieces, and then you can turn them into the two forms of narcissism. You can take the **extraversion** and the low **agreeableness**, and that makes your **grandiosity**, your **grandiose narcissism**. You take the low **agreeableness** and mix it with **neuroticism**, and that makes your **vulnerable narcissism**. That's your two narcissisms. Then what you can do is take grandiose and **vulnerable narcissism** and put them together, and that's what **narcissistic personality disorder** looks like. That's why it's the **trifurcated model**. You've got the three basic structures of narcissism, the **extraversion** or agentic **extraversion**, **antagonism** or low **agreeableness**, and **neuroticism**, and then they can recapitulate three faces of narcissism—grandiose, vulnerable, and **NPD**.
- 2.48 It makes sense. It's a little bit nerdy. But what's cool about these basic personality models is that it allows you to compare narcissism with everything else. You're like, **grandiose narcissism**, **extraversion**, and **antagonism**. How do I turn that into **psychopathy**? Well, you just add some low **conscientiousness**. You add some impulsivity or low **conscientiousness**, meaning somebody who's self-centered, mean, self-centered, extraverted, and also doesn't have a lot of self-control. It's like, "Hey, I'm awesome. I'm going to steal your shoes." That's **psychopathy**. It's an impulsive narcissism. You wanted to switch it up. Let's see. I don't know how else to switch it up. What else?
- 2.49 I should say, you can also get vulnerability and **grandiosity** together. You can find people who report high **grandiose narcissism** and **vulnerable narcissism** at the same time, which is an interesting and a little bit of a—talk, I don't talk because—a little combustible combination because that **neuroticism**, you're always looking for threats, and the **grandiosity**, you're looking for opportunities. So you can get that as well. That model, it's really useful for a lot of things. In terms of our **self-report** measures of narcissism that we've looked at before, they each seem to capture different flavors of the **Big Five**. So when we measure **narcissistic personality disorder**, what we're mostly capturing there is **antagonism**. We're mostly capturing meanness, we're

mostly capturing self-centeredness, the most toxic aspects of narcissism, the socially toxic aspects.

- 2.50 When we measure **grandiose narcissism**, it's pretty much 50/50 **extraversion** and **antagonism**, or **extraversion** and low **agreeableness**. It's a pretty good balance between those two. So you think of Doctor Strange. Why is Doctor Strange likable? Because he's confident, assertive, has a good suit, shakes your hand, and thinks he's a big deal. It's all assertive **extraversion**. What makes Doctor Strange dislikable? He's self-centered, he's arrogant, and cares about nobody but himself. Those are bad things. But you see how it's a combination. It's got good traits and bad traits. **Extraversion**, generally good; **antagonism**, bad. It's complicated. **Vulnerable narcissism** is capturing about 50/50 of that **antagonism** and **neuroticism**. It's like a mean neurotic person.
- 2.51 Something like **self-esteem**, to give you another example, is capturing high **agreeableness**, low **neuroticism**, and high **extraversion**. People with high **self-esteem** will show the similar **extraversion** to people who are grandiose narcissists, but they're not going to show that level of **antagonism**, and they're not going to show the **neuroticism**. So you can see all your—another way I've thought about this, another way I've thought about these **Big Five** and narcissism that I find really useful is like a recipe.
- 2.52 So you go to a lot of these American-Mexican places, like burrito shops, whatever, and you go there, and they've got a bunch of ingredients behind the counter, and you go, "I want a taco." They grab the flour tortillas, and then they throw in a protein, and they throw in cheese. There's your taco. You're like, "I want a burrito." They go, "Oh, we'll get a little bigger flour tortilla and throw this stuff in it, and we'll fold it up." Then you go, "I want a chalupa or a gordita." What do they call it? They're like, "Well, I'll just take that burrito and throw it in the deep fryer and fry that thing for you." Somebody else goes, "I want a tostada." And like, "Well, we'll just fry that tortilla and put the stuff on top like a salad." It's all the same stuff. They're just mixing the proteins and the ingredients up in different ways to make these different ingredients. But underneath it, if you eat a chalupa or burrito or a couple of tacos or a quesadilla, you're getting similar food.
- 2.53 I think that model is really useful for narcissism, to think about it. It's like you're building it out of these ingredients. You want to build a grandiose profile, what you do is you mix up this energy, you mix up this **extraversion** with some meanness, and that's your narcissistic chalupa. I'm really running with this chalupa metaphor. I don't even know if that's a real thing. But it's good on the outside and nasty on the inside or something. I don't know. And with vulnerability, again, it's the same thing. But this is how all the personality traits work. Almost every trait you can make up from the ingredients of the **Big Five**. You can use the **Big Five** and put them in a little different arrangement to make up the trait. And some traits are just subfactors of the **Big Five**. Like I said, oh, there's a trait grit. Well, grit is just some part of **conscientiousness**. It's like, yeah, you get half the black beans, but no, whatever, refried beans, I don't know. I think that thinking about the **Big Five** as ingredients to make up personality traits is super interesting.

- 2.54 In terms of how we think about narcissism and what models we use, dynamics and trait models are both really cool. Usually, the way science works is we spend a lot of time building personality measures. We do a lot of work on what's called personality assessment, where we build these tools. We build our **grandiose narcissism** scale, we build our **vulnerable narcissism** scale, we build our **entitlement** scales. We spend a lot of time on that more quantitative personality side. Then when we want to see how these things work in real life, we go, "Hey, let's go measure narcissism, and then we'll go see how this person works in a relationship," or "Let's measure narcissism with our good scales and see what kind of clothes this person picks out at the store, to see how they're going to do **self-regulation**." When we're thinking about narcissism, we're thinking both about a general model of trait and also about dynamics, and we use both these ways of thinking to understand it. That's the end. Thank you.
- 2.55 I was wondering, in a Maoist totalitarian dystopia, you find—there's a lot of big words. I don't know if I'm using them right—but you'll find that there's a fraction of the vocabulary we have here, and with respect to the West. Do these traits have a scale of how far they're expressed, if you have a lack of the vocabulary to actually acknowledge their existence?
- 2.56 What is it? Maoist socialist utopia.
- 2.57 Like a North Korea, for example.
- 2.58 Yeah. That's a really interesting question. I'm going to back this out for a second. Now, you imagine the way you set up a society. In the West, we have a more individualistic and liberal, in the sense that you kind of do what you want society. China under **Mao** started out as an incredibly constrained society with tight social rules. I remember the first time I went to China, maybe 1984, everybody was wearing the exact same outfit. They were all dressed like **Mao**. They had **Mao** outfits, they had fake Ray-Bans. I bought some. They were re-engineered American Ray-Bans you'd buy, and then they'd fit them to you with an oil lamp and dial them into your head.
- 2.59 So the question is, how does narcissism express itself in a culture that's collectivistic, where everyone's supposed to be the same? And the way you get ego is by saying, "I'm the same as everybody else." It's an awesome question. People have looked at that. There's two answers, two things going on. One is there's a cultural change right now in China, where China has been Westernized for the last 20, 30 years, probably more. And you're seeing the growth of **grandiose narcissism** in China, and what you're seeing that associated with—I'm thinking of specific research here by Chinese academics—where you're seeing that associated with is rural living. I mean, excuse me, urban living, so moving from rural to cities; the one-child policy, so having a lot of single parents; and then the more capitalist hustle economics. I might be missing something, but those are the primary drivers.
- 2.60 So what you see is, on one hand, you see China, in particular, becoming more narcissistic in the classic grandiose way. The other thing you see that's really interesting is people can get esteem via saying they're the most collective people on Earth. So what you see is something that looks

more like **communal narcissism**. "I'm the best team player." "Dude, you're not a team player. You're always looking out for number one." "Shut up. I'm the best team player." So you can get a manifestation of narcissism, which is more communal and more aligned with collectivistic values, but it's still about ego.

- 2.61 Thank you. How do narcissists engage with other narcissists? Do they try to take each other out? Do they ever team up and stroke each other's egos? What does that situation look like?
- 2.62 That's another really interesting question. So when I've looked at this a little bit with dating, you see a little bit of homophily, a little bit like narcissist attracted to narcissist, with **grandiosity**, at least. I think that's, well, if I'm a little bit self-centered, materialistic, competitive, and shallow, and you are, I kind of like you. So I do think there's a little bit of "like goes with like" with narcissism. At the same time, if you end up with a group of people who are all—this is like three alpha guys together. They're going to just go to war with each other. If you end up with a team with too much narcissism, it ends up destroying each other.
- 2.63 The example I always thought of with this—OK, this is a tangent, but we got time. There is a study done on chicken coops and chicken raising in the journal Poultry Science. People said, "We want to make the most productive chicken house as we can. What we're going to do is go to every chicken house and we're going to get the most productive chicken, and we're going to put those chickens together into a dream team of chickens. And that chicken house is going to make the best eggs on Earth." So they did that. They bring all the high-producing chickens together. And what happens? They underproduce. It turns out that the high-producing chickens were high-producing not because they were hard-working, nice chickens, but because they were exploiting the other chickens. They were taking their food, they were taking resources. They were bad chickens. When you put them all together, they all ball-hog, they're not working together, they don't work too well.
- 2.64 It's like the dream team in the Olympics in the old days. You get all these NBA stars, but they can't work together as a team. They don't have the right supporting people or everything else. So I think the idea of bringing a group of narcissists together towards a goal is going to be a disaster. Another classic example of this is the movie *The Dirty Dozen*, which is actually one of the scales of the **Dark Triad**; it's called the **Dirty Dozen** scale. It was an old World War II movie, and the theme of this movie was they got a bunch of people out of prison, put them into a group of military people to go kill the Nazis. It was like Telly Savalas and a bunch of tough-guy actors. They got together and they went to kill the Nazis. I think they ended up fighting each other, and half of them went to steal some gold, and half of them killed Nazis. It was a disaster. I think this idea of bringing the team of narcissists together doesn't work. I think it's better, one in a group is probably the best.
- 2.65 You said 10 to 20ish percent of that narcissistic trait is from parenting. Is that just the narcissistic trait or personality traits in general? And if you could talk a little bit more about how a narcissistic parent affecting their children.

- 2.66 Yeah. Those numbers with narcissism are pretty consistent with what you get with all personality, most major personality variables. Narcissism, descriptively, maybe it's a little higher, but I haven't done a big test to see. So it's definitely genetic. In terms of parenting, there's the issue of turning your kids into narcissists, which I mentioned is, maybe either abuse will screw them up, make them a lot more vulnerable, or just putting kids on a pedestal, telling them they're a big deal, like **situationally acquired narcissism**, telling your kid they're a superstar their whole life. That maybe does something.
- 2.67 The other question that you bring up is, what does it mean to be a narcissistic parent? That can be a real problem. We don't have a ton of data on this, but narcissistic parents, what they'll often end up doing is using their children as props or tools to reinforce or signal their own narcissism. Imagine I'm a narcissistic dad. I haven't done much that anyone can be proud of, but my girls are really successful. So I can go like, "Hey, check out my daughter. She's a real legend. Oh, she plays sports. Oh, she goes to this great school." So I use my kids to self-regulate my ego. When I'm doing that with my kids when they're young, part of them thinks that's good because they go, "Dad loves me. He always talks about me, always talks about my success." But then what they realize is, "When I fail, dad doesn't love me anymore, that his love is contingent on my own performance."
- 2.68 And so when you're a child and realize that your parents' love for you is contingent, it can be really troubling. It's a very sad thing to go through. I mean, just not something you want to, because you realize you've been a prop. I say dad, it could be mom just as easily. You were a prop in mom's little psychodrama, so everyone thought she was a big deal, and that was your whole life. It can be a heavy thing to wake up to, when you have your own kids and you start loving your kids. You go, "Wait, this isn't what it's like."
- 2.69 So if narcissism is generally bad and damaging, why are we so drawn to narcissists as a society, like politicians and celebrities?
- 2.70 Yeah, I think it's a perfect question. I tell you, I think the easiest way to think about this is with the **Big Five** traits. It's what do you like in people who are narcissistic? You like the **extraversion**, you like the confidence, you like the charisma, you like the charm. People who go, "I know what I'm doing." No one knows. The world's going insane right now. It's going just bonkers, off the rails. I'm a smart guy. I can't figure out anything. But somebody walks in the room and they're like, "I got this figured out." You're like, "Thank god somebody does. I'm going to follow this person." And if they seem confident and they seem nice. When you meet people who are narcissistic, they typically —well, if they care about your opinion at all, they're typically not going to tell you they're a jerk. They're going to be nice to you. They might listen to you. It's very hard to see the negative stuff until a little later. If you're waiting tables for somebody narcissistic, you might see it, but if you're on a date with them, you're probably not going to see it right away. Often, those more negative sides are hidden until later, and the **extraversion** drives it.

- 2.71 OK, so this is a follow-up question for the question he had for you. Do you think that if you're a narcissistic parent and your kid see, like, if your kid underperforms, do you think that that can create a narcissistic child, like trying to overcompensate for the insecurities they felt?
- 2.72 So this is the dynamic you're describing. I'm a narcissistic parent. I have a child who doesn't seem to offer much. So I ignore my child, and I'm a jerk to that child because they're not my golden child. OK, so I've got my child, I'm not paying attention. My child realizes that and goes, "What I need to do is I need to shine so that dad can get some esteem from me or at least pay attention to me." So as a child, I'm overcompensating, or maybe I'm just compensating, for my lack of love by saying, "I'm the best. Look at me. Look how successful I am." And I run my life to try to get my dad's narcissistic attention to get it away from his own ego.
- 2.73 Doesn't that sound like a sad way to go through life? Yeah. Does that happen? I'll tell you, one, I talk to people who it's happened to. So I will say, yes, I've heard that story before, and it's a sad story because it's a compensatory story. And two, I will say there's not a lot of research on this because we just don't have the masses of people to collect this stuff. So I can't talk about it with scientific certainty. I can talk about it as it makes sense. You do see a path where people who are wounded or feel some trauma or feel some emptiness, they go, "I got to be a big deal because that's how I'm going to get out of it." They spend a lot of time creating a **false self**, creating an image or an avatar of themselves that's really popular, high-end status, etc. A lot of times that works. You end up with people that can build a life that's really high-end status, but then deep down, they still feel a little insecure because they never had that love. Then they do the work and make it all work out, and you do some psychotherapy and stuff. Yeah, good question.

3. Clinical Narcissism

AT A GLANCE

Covers the clinical form, narcissistic personality disorder. Defines mental disorders and psychopathology as extreme, inflexible, culturally inappropriate patterns causing impairment, then surveys the three clusters of personality disorders: cluster A (paranoid, schizoid, schizotypal), cluster B (antisocial, borderline, histrionic, narcissistic), and cluster C (avoidant, dependent, obsessive-compulsive), plus PDNOS. Describes NPD as extreme, pervasive, inflexible narcissism with cognitive, impulsive, relational, and emotional impairments, walks through the DSM's nine criteria, discusses differential diagnosis (mania, drugs, situational fame), and contrasts Kernberg's rage-based and Kohut's emptiness-based psychodynamic models with the modern trait view, specifiers, and the PID-5.

- 3.1** What I want to talk about in this lecture is the clinical or psychiatric form of narcissism, the **personality disorder** known as **narcissistic personality disorder**. This is the most extreme form of narcissism that you run into. What should I say? It's the extreme form, and it's what people often think they're talking about when they talk about narcissism. Somebody goes, "Oh, my boyfriend was a narcissist," and people go, "Oh, that means they had a clinical form of the **personality disorder** of **NPD**, or **narcissistic personality disorder**." That's often not the case. Often when you say, "My boyfriend was a narcissist," you meant he was a jerk and a little bit self-centered. You didn't mean he had a full clinical or diagnostic disorder he should be in treatment with for years. You just meant he was a bad guy. We use these terms a little bit interchangeably, but they're very different.
- 3.2** What I wanted to talk about today, in this session, is the **mental disorder** part of narcissism. To do that, I have to talk a little bit first about what a **mental disorder** is, or **psychopathology**. Then I need to talk a little bit about the **personality disorders**. There's a whole family of these **personality disorders** I'll talk about. Starting with this is, what is a **mental disorder**? **Mental disorder** is a pattern of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors—I always like how we say that, thoughts, feelings, and behaviors—a pattern of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors that cause significant problems or impairment in life. You have something going on that's mental. It's your thoughts, your feelings, your behaviors, and it's causing you significant problems.
- 3.3** One of the big tricks in what a **mental disorder** is, or a mental illness is, is deciding what is clinically significant impairment. Somebody's a jerk—you're like, "Yeah, that's a problem, but that's not a mental problem," versus somebody who's such a jerk that they lose their marriage, they lose their job, their kids don't talk to them. You go, "That's a **mental disorder**." There's a line in there, but it's not a bright line, and it's not one of those "God didn't just make that line." A bunch of psychiatrists and psychologists said, "We're going to decide where that line is," and it's a little bit fuzzy. That's the idea with mental illness.
- 3.4** Another term we use is **psychopathology**. A lot of times we're talking about mental disorders, we're talking about **psychopathology**, pathology of the psyche, pathology of the soul. When we

say **psychopathology**, that's like another term for a **mental disorder**. When we say somebody's a psychopath, that's actually a specific term for a personality style or **personality disorder**. The idea of a **mental disorder** is that it's beyond what's normal. So, a lot of times we feel problems. We feel our ego gets inflated. We feel anxious. We feel depressed. We feel fearful. We feel weird. We have strange ideas. Sometimes I hear voices that aren't there. Lots of weird things happen to us. Those can be normal.

- 3.5 They also can be culturally appropriate. You can even have certain cultures where you talk to the dead. You can go and talk to the dead, and everybody's like, "That's cool. That's what we do here. It's not mentally—everyone talks to the dead here. It's fine." For something to be a **mental disorder**, it has to be caused by some impairment, and it has to be beyond what is normal, and it has to be what's not culturally really acceptable. So something outside of cultural disorders.
- 3.6 Most mental disorders that we talk about—there's exceptions here, but there's a lot of mental disorders. But most of these things exist on a continuum or on a spectrum. So it's not like people are just normal, happy people, and then you've got over here the mentally ill people. It's like the normal dudes, and then there's these poor, like the island of misfit toys. It's like everyone's crazy, and it's just how crazy and if you're over an edge or not. Something like a disorder, like a phobia. You can say, like public speaking. Most people don't like public speaking. It's not fun. Some people, it can be, "Hey, I just don't like it, but I get myself psyched up. I go rah-rah, I get up on stage. I do some public speaking." It works. It's not a disorder. Other people go, "I don't really like public speaking, but I don't need to do it. So I don't really do it too much." It's not a disorder.
- 3.7 But you have some people that are performers. It's their job. They get such bad stage fright, they can literally not go on stage, and they get their career derailed. So thinking of—who's that great singer that was in Funny Girl? Anyway. There's famous musicians and things that can't perform because of their stage fright. It becomes a clinical disorder. The idea is that something can be normal, but it can become so impairing that you can't do your job. You can't sing anymore, and so you got to go to a psychiatrist, and the psychiatrist says, "We're going to teach you how to sing again."
- 3.8 So that happens, and that's the case for most mental disorders, something like depression. "Oh, I'm depressed." Well, no one's saying, like, "Well, dude, let's get you on an SSRI. Start doing some electroconvulsive therapy." They're like, "Yeah, what's going on? What's making you depressed?" "I'm sad about something." "Oh, let's talk about it." Then you feel better. That's a big difference from major depressive disorder. "How are you feeling?" "I'm depressed." "What do you mean?" "Well, I haven't been able to get out of my bed for two weeks. I'm not eating. I'm having suicidal thoughts. I can't think well. I'm losing my relationships." "Well, that sounds bad. Let's get you treatment now." There's a difference between being depressed and major depressive disorder. You get this. There's these continua here.
- 3.9 Personality traits and **personality disorders** work the same way. You can have normal personality, like normal narcissism. Guy's a little cocky. A little cocky, guy who seems like a

fighter pilot, but within normal reason. You can go from that to something more and more extreme that becomes a disorder. For personality to become a disorder, this is what goes on. It becomes extreme, it becomes inflexible, and it becomes impairing. So you take normal personality and you jack it up to some extremity. You just make it extreme. On top of that, you make it inflexible, so it can't change across situations. That's when you get into trouble, and that's going to wreck things, and then that's the impairment.

- 3.10** So here's what happens with something like narcissism. Your narcissism becomes extreme. I'm not a big deal. I'm a super big deal. Like, dude, I'm a real big deal. I feel like a big deal all the time. When I'm in front of—when I'm on TV, I act like a big deal, and that's great. Everyone loves you when you're a big deal on TV. But when I go home with my kids, I act like a big deal, and my kids hate me. My wife hates me even more, and I act like even a bigger deal around my wife. You should see me at the taco place. I act like the king of tacos, "el rey del tacos," and I'm a big deal everywhere.
- 3.11** That inflexibility leads to problems because most of what we do with personalities, we turn it on and turn it off. Some places it's adaptive, and some it's not. So like **extraversion**, like I said, you can be extraverted, but if you're at a funeral, you should dial it back. If you're always extraverted, you're like, "Dude, that's a disorder." So what happens with personality is it gets extreme, it gets inflexible, and it starts wrecking your life because it's causing these problems.
- 3.12** Impairment in **personality disorders**, or really any disorders, can happen in different ways. So you can have cognitive impairment; your thoughts get impaired. You can have emotional impairment, just emotional problems, relational impairment, or some impulsivity. The classic example of cognitive impairment, I can do this with narcissism, but cognitive impairment would be any sort of thinking disturbance, might be weird thoughts, might be overconfident thoughts, might be underconfident thoughts. Emotional impairment could be too much negative affectivity. Affectivity, that's a fancy way. It's too many negative feelings. Relational impairment, I'll talk about with narcissism, but they could just damage your relationships. Then things like impulsivity would be more like binge-drinking, alcoholism, food disorders, that impulsive behavior. That's a classic impairment.
- 3.13** With **personality disorders**, it's also, it can't be cultural. As long as it's got to be something outside your culture. And in terms of these **personality disorders**, you're looking at about one in 10 people get diagnosed with **personality disorders**. So that's a pretty big number, like 10% of people are diagnosed as a significant personality impairment. The other things that are neat about **personality disorders** compared to the classic **personality disorders** is they have to be going on a long time. So to be diagnosed as a **personality disorder**, it has to have started when you were an adolescent.
- 3.14** If I'm just a really chill person, and one day I wake up, I'm 55 years old, and I'm just super narcissistic, and I go to a doctor and go, "What's up?" I go, "I don't know. I'm a legend. I got to get a new wife. She's just not good enough. I don't know what to do," no one's going to say, "You've got **NPD**." They're going to say, "Did somebody put something in your soup? Did you

have a brain aneurysm? Did you get a bacterial infection?" Did something, like, something must have happened. Because that's not your personality. Your personality, you've had—it's how you're wired. The idea with **personality disorders** is you should see these throughout the life course, especially since adolescence. With little kids, you can predict adult narcissism from childhood behavior, but it's a pretty thin correlation. You see real impulsive kids. Sometimes they end up being more narcissistic. But typically, you'll see this in adolescents, and they'll get worse and worse. It doesn't just appear.

- 3.15 Another thing with **personality disorders** is they can't be due to another disorder. So maybe it can't be that you have, I don't know, let's say you've got depression or let's say you've got an anxiety disorder. And it's so bad, it starts like, "I'm really scared of germs, and I'm really scared of this, and I'm also scared of negative ego threats." I don't know, that sounds pretty weak, but it can't be a manifestation of an underlying disorder. It has to be a **personality disorder**. A classic one for narcissism might be something like bipolar. People who have bipolar disorder, which is a combination of depression and expansive positive mania, or expansive positive mood, sometimes people in that manic phase can look narcissistic. But that wouldn't be **NPD**; that would be bipolar. That's probably the problem.
- 3.16 The behaviors can't be due to something physical. If you're doing a whole bunch of methamphetamine, you're doing a whole bunch of cocaine, you become paranoid and delusional and self-focused all the time—that's not a **personality disorder**. That's a drug problem. This is the challenge with diagnosis. It's **differential diagnosis**. It's where is this coming from? Again, with a **personality disorder**, what you want to see is, you want to see that's part of the person's personality. The old school, we used to call these character disorders. You want to see it's part of the person's character. Then it's—and it's been that way for a while.
- 3.17 So what are the **personality disorders**? Conceivably, conceptually, you could take any personality trait and make it extreme and inflexible and it causes impairment. It could be a disorder. You could have lots and lots of **personality disorders**, conceptually. But the way medical science and psychiatry have worked is, historically, we've adopted certain **personality disorders** into the lexicon. There's certain ones that psychiatrists or psychologists will use that are in the Diagnostic and Statistics Manual. They're written up in the book. They're in the handbook. Then there's others that are out there that aren't really written up.
- 3.18 So one weird example is **psychopathy**, or psychopathic **personality disorder**, which everyone loves **psychopathy**. People love psychopaths. There's like a million TV shows on—I should have studied psychopaths. I just don't like them, or else I'd be a legend because people love psychopaths. That's not in the **DSM**. You open up the **DSM**, go, "I'm going to look up psychopathic **personality disorder**." It's not there. Weird. Why isn't it there? Well, there's **antisocial personality disorder**, there's **narcissistic personality disorder**, and those kind of cover up, they cover the same space. So politically, they just didn't put **psychopathy** in it. So there's a real political aspect to this. I don't mean like, Democrat, Republican politics or parliamentary. It's just a bunch of people fighting over what goes in something or not.

- 3.19 So the current description of **personality disorders** has three clusters. They call them the clusters of **personality disorders**. They're basically the groups that are a little different. **Cluster A**, **cluster B**, and **cluster C**. Not too clever. **Cluster A** is known as the odd and eccentric cluster. This is the weirder personality traits. **Cluster B** is the more dramatic emotional personality traits, the reality TV show ones. I always say reality, because reality television used to be, you just got a bunch of people with **cluster B** disorders and had them drink and then film it. Then mess with them, too. They would film it and mess with people. I mean, it was bad. Then the **cluster C** disorders, which are more anxious and fearful disorders. These are more about fear. These are the three clusters of disorders, the three groups.
- 3.20 The way the clinical students used to remember this—I actually was a clinical psychology student a long time ago. I'm not a clinician. I was very clear about that—but the way you'd remember these was "mad, bad, and sad," or "weird, wild, and worried." I probably can't say any of those things anymore. That was probably illegal. But the way I think of it, **cluster A**, odd, eccentric, is mad or weird. **Cluster B**, the dramatic emotional is bad or wild. I like wild. It's the bad, wild. Then **cluster C**, the anxious, fearful, is sad or worried. Mad, bad, sad. Weird, wild, worried. Those are the big clusters within them.
- 3.21 So within each of those clusters, you have the specific disorders. The **cluster A** disorders, the more weird disorders, include **paranoid personality disorder**. And paranoid is a word we're used to. Paranoid is like, you're —I use the word delusion. What does that even mean? A delusion is a belief, like a somewhat complex belief system that's probably not true. Somebody who's paranoid has a feeling that something out there is trying to get them. There's something out there that's a force that's trying to get them. That might be a complicated delusion they have. If it's really complicated, it might be schizophrenic. But I mean, just as a **personality disorder**, I generally see the world is out to get me. I'm generally distrustful of the world, and there's a plot behind it. There's sort of some machinations in the background that are trying to make me paranoid.
- 3.22 Paranoia is interesting because it's a **cluster A** disorder, but when you look at a lot of the data, you see a lot of paranoia that goes with narcissism, too. Sometimes you see this paranoid narcissistic type. Even though it's **cluster A**, it does have some **cluster B** features. Another **cluster A** is **schizoid personality disorder**. This is one that's not as interesting because **schizoid**—schism means a split, like a schism. So the word **schizoid** is like there's a split between the emotion and behavior, and people are really emotionally isolated and loners. So **schizoid** personality is just really unconnected personality. Not a lot of joy, not a lot of—they say anhedonia—not a lot of feelings from things, not a lot of social connections with people, except for maybe first-degree relatives, like brothers or parents. So it's more of a disconnected disorder.
- 3.23 And then the final of the **cluster A** is **schizotypal**. **Schizotypal personality disorder** is kind of cool. It's got some of this social isolation piece to it, but it also has a lot of the weird thoughts, a lot of the odd and unusual thinking like schizophrenia does. People who are more **schizotypal**—you see signs, you see, "Oh, I saw a sign on the freeway. That was a secret message that meant I was going to have a good day." Whatever. It's all the weird stuff I do. It's like astrology and signs and

synchronicities and all those things. I'd basically be **schizotypal** if it weren't culturally appropriate, and I just declare myself culturally appropriate. But it's that weirdness. **Schizotypal** is kind of like baby schizophrenia. Sometimes people think of it that way. It's not quite the same, but it's a similar idea. That's **cluster A**, the more weird ones.

- 3.24 **Cluster B** is where narcissism is, and this is the dramatic, emotional, like I said, reality TV show **personality disorders**. The **cluster B** disorders are **antisocial personality disorder**, which is a lot of **antagonism**, a lot of that meanness and callousness, and also impulsivity. With **antisocial** disorder, what you get are people that are breaking social rules. They're stealing stuff. They're taking advantage of people. One of the key descriptors of **antisocial** is being dishonorably discharged from the military. You've got to work on that. You just don't follow rules, and they throw you out of the military. **Antisocial** is, well, it's about being **antisocial**. It's not being social. I'd say, what's the difference between that and **psychopathy**? **Psychopathy**, when people describe classic **psychopathy**, it's got more narcissism in it. It's got more glib, superficial charm, more self-centeredness, those kind of things. So **antisocial**, narcissism, **psychopathy**, they're all the same cluster.
- 3.25 The second big one you have in **cluster B** is **borderline personality disorder**. **Borderline** is the most studied **personality disorder**. We have the most research on it. It's probably the most diagnosed. It has a lot of destructive features that go with it, and it's very complicated. So the term **borderline** —these terms are great because they're all historic— **borderline** refers to the **borderline** between neurosis and psychosis. What the heck does that mean? What it means is, I'm a psychoanalyst, and it's 1950, and I'm smoking my pipe. Maybe it's 1962. And I'm in my office smoking my pipe, and my patient's on the couch, and my patient seems neurotic, meaning anxious and depressed, like we said, but they're a little more than that. They're a little more than neurotic. They also have some real weird, almost delusional thoughts. Maybe some of this is a little intense. They're not over the line. They're not schizophrenic. They're not crazy, but they're right on the **borderline**. We're going to call them **borderline**.
- 3.26 That's where that term comes from. It's a terrible term. What **borderline** and the description of **borderline**, which I won't go into because that would be another course, but it's very complicated. There's lots of different manifestations you can get. You can get one person who's **borderline** who has very split-object relations, meaning, an object in psychological terms is a mental representation of a relationship. My object is a mental representation of my mom. I have a mom object or a relational object. What you see with **borderline** is they can really love people and then hate people. Same person, I love you, and then the next time you see, I hate you. You can have these changes and things.
- 3.27 You get a lot of problems with affect or emotional regulation, especially fear, anxiety, a lot of fearfulness that goes with it. Sometimes you get extreme anxiety that manifests as depersonalization and derealization. These are feelings like, you get so anxious, you're like, I don't really feel like I'm a person. I don't feel things are real. I don't feel like a person. Sometimes when people don't feel real, they'll do things like cause themselves pain. What you'll see with **borderline** are things like cutting behaviors.

- 3.28 I used to work on a unit with this group of young girls, pre-adolescent girls, and they would do a lot of cutting. They'd take a pen apart or something and just cut on their arms, like lines of blood. A lot of that was—some of that was social, and it was just to feel real. It's just weird, but it's a way of coping with anxiety. So you see some of that; you see suicidality. I've talked to people who are real experts in it, and people will say, maybe the core of **borderline** is emotional regulation. It's hard to regulate anxiety. So it's more like **vulnerable narcissism** with a lot of anxiety than grandiose. So that's **borderline personality disorder**.
- 3.29 Two more cluster Bs. The last one before narcissism is **histrionism**, or **histrionic personality disorder**, HPD. **Histrionism** is cool. When they change up these **personality disorders**, I think there's some interest in getting rid of it. People don't really like **histrionic personality disorder** because it doesn't seem that bad. But what it is, is **histrionism** is very high **extraversion**, self-centeredness, attention-seeking, sometimes overt displays of sexuality, or overt displays of, kind of, well, like it's warm sexuality. Sometimes it's called being a diva. A super diva syndrome is **histrionism** or **histrionic personality disorder**. It's associated with narcissism. So often, I don't know if often, but sometimes what will happen is, you'll get a diagnosis. Well, it could be narcissistic or it could be **histrionic**. Say, oh, this person's **histrionic** because they're really attention-seeking. What you don't see with **histrionic** as much is meanness. It's more just, "I'm a diva. I want attention. Look at me. I'm a little flighty, but I'm not necessarily a mean person."
- 3.30 I haven't met a lot of **histrionic** people. I remember one woman I ran into in Belize, of all places, I was talking to for a while. I was like, "Wow, you're really **histrionic**. This is cool," where you could really see it be a disorder. But if you're a little bit **histrionic**, if you're a little bit extraverted and attention-seeking and like a diva, that works in our culture. People are drawn to that. That's why divas are like that. We like divas. So that's the **histrionism**. And then the final **cluster B** disorder is narcissism. **Narcissistic personality disorder**. So it's a classic **cluster B**. I will go into that in a second because I'm going to go through the whole definition of narcissism, but generally, it's what we said. It's **grandiosity**, **need for admiration**, and a lack of emotional **empathy**.
- 3.31 Then the final group, so there's **cluster A**, **cluster B**, and **cluster C**, which are the more anxious and fearful **personality disorders**, maybe sad or worried. These are **avoidant personality disorder**. And avoidant's interesting because **avoidant** is a disorder where you want relationships, but you're too nervous to have them or you're too fearful to have them. So it's not like **schizoid**. It's like, "I'm a loner. I'm socially isolated. I don't really want people around." **Avoidant** is more like, "I kind of want relationships, but I'm nervous. So I avoid a lot of life, and I end up being socially isolated because of my own fear." So it's a little different flavor of social isolation.
- 3.32 There's the other **cluster C**, is **dependent personality disorder**. This is really interesting because **dependent personality disorder** is a disorder where you depend fully on other people to regulate your life. Remember, I said a lot of things are about **self-regulation**. Dependency is like, "I can't make decisions on my own. I need a strong figure to make decisions for me." My favorite—I love how I say these are my favorite stories. These are my favorite stories of running into

mental illness. This was my favorite job, I think. I was a bellhop at the Sun Valley Lodge, Sun Valley Resort, up in Idaho. I was checking out this former Hollywood actress, Tippi Hedren, or something. She was in *The Birds*, the old Hitchcock movie, *The Birds*, where the birds attack people. A great movie.

- 3.33 She was the actress in there, and I was checking her out of her room. I go up to get her because I get the call, and I go in her room, and the clothes are everywhere. She's in a panic. She's just looking at me like, "I can't get it together, man." I looked at—I should say this since I'm talking about myself. I started my master's program in clinical psychology. After a year, I just said, "Screw it, I'm going to Idaho. I'm going snowboarding." I went up to Idaho for a year just to get out of academia for a while, which was good. Then I got a little bored and went back, which is probably good, too.
- 3.34 What I did, I said, "Hey, we got this. No problem. Just go grab a bunch of towels from the bathroom." She went and got some towels. I said, "Now lay the towels out on the bed." She laid the towels on the bed. I said, "Perfect. Now take all your clothes and put them in the middle of the towels." She put all her clothes in the towels. I said, "Now, tie the corners up." She went and tied the corners of the towels up, like a little knapsack, like a hobo. I got them all together, put them on the big luggage cart, went out to the car. And up rolls this —dude, this guy was straight out of bad news Hollywood. Just the guy in the Cadillac convertible with the dyed hair down to here. I don't know. I shouldn't hate on my fellow Californians with the long hair. My hair never—and he pulls up with the Cadillac. She jumps in. She's totally dependent on this guy. I could just tell. He wasn't there, so she couldn't check out. He was out getting the car, and that's why I had to deal with her. Once she got in the car, he just took off, and they were done.
- 3.35 Sorry, that was a long story, but that's dependency. And dependency is interesting. Again, this is me talking to clinicians about it. They say it's a pretty good predictor of depression, that being dependent can work if you have somebody reliable to rely on. But often people who are dependent, they get depressed because they're not really in control of their own life and they can't really regulate things. So that's dependency. And then the final—god, we've done a lot of personality disorders here, but this is interesting. I like the PDs. The final cluster C is obsessive-compulsive personality disorder. And this one is—this one is a little unusual because we think about obsessive-compulsive disorder. So there's obsessive-compulsive disorder. "Hey, you're OCD." And then there's obsessive-compulsive personality disorder. "Hey, you're OCPD." Which is which?
- 3.36 Well, obsessive-compulsive disorder, the clinical disorder, is when you have obsessive thoughts and then compulsive behaviors that go with them. So, "Oh my god, somebody's going to break into my house. I'd better check the locks." Then you go check the locks. Then you walk up to your bedroom, you're like, "Oh my god, I didn't know, I'm not sure if I checked the locks. I'm going to go check the locks again." I'm so obsessed. It's like OCD. I talked to, I talked to one clinician at Emory about it, and she goes, "Do you spend 30 minutes a day doing it?" I'm like, "No, that would be crazy. I'm only, like, 10 minutes. She goes, "Oh, you're fine." It's a continuum. That's what I mean. Everything's a continuum. I'm like, kind of bad, but not. She's

like, "No, 30 minutes, you'd be in the clinic." Meaning, like, 30 minutes a day testing locks or whatever. That's **OCD**.

- 3.37 OC, **obsessive-compulsive personality disorder** is a personality style or configuration that has an undue or over-the-top emphasis on order and neatness. People who are **OCPD** are what we used to call anal, if you used the old **Freudian** term, or we'd maybe call them, maybe we'd just call them obsessive-compulsive. They're just neat freaks, people that are neat freaks that are overly controlled about stuff. You go, "How come that's a disorder? That seems pretty helpful." It's like, well, it's helpful to have a little bit of that. But if you spend so much time making sure things are ordered, you don't actually act. You spend all your time getting things in order, you get frozen. It's this more neurotic presentation of OC, obsessive-compulsive. It's kind of like bad **conscientiousness**, in a way.
- 3.38 I was talking to my psychiatrist. I get a lot of help in my life. I remember I first met him and I was like, well, what would you—because the classic diagnosis for people is, you give people an Axis 1 diagnosis. "Oh, you've got an anxiety disorder." Then you give them an Axis 2, which would be a **personality disorder**, too. I said, "Dude, what **personality disorder** would I have? Just give me one." He goes, "Well, I'd probably make you **OCPD**." I'm like, "Come on. Can't I be a psychopath?" "No. No, you're just a neurotic loser who spends too much time worried about his locks on his doors." I'm like, "Now that's true." Yeah, I'm glad I picked the right psychiatrist, but I really wanted to be something else. I really wanted to be **cluster B**. I thought that would be much more exciting. But no, I was **cluster C**, just neurotic. It's not uncommon for people who work all the time. They get **cluster C**. Anyway, those are the three clusters.
- 3.39 The other thing I should mention here, I'm not going to do all the politics here, but there's a lot of people that are diagnosed as **PDNOS**, which is a very fancy way of saying "**personality disorder** not otherwise specified." You go to a clinician, they talk to you for a while, and they go, "Man, that Keith's got a **personality disorder**. I don't know what kind it is. His personality is bad." It's like when personality is bad, but we don't know what it is. What that is, is you got something going on with your character. There's something there; we sense it. There's something stuck there, but we're not going to put a label on it. Maybe you've got narcissistic features and some **borderline** features, so it's hard to label you with both. Maybe it's, we're not really sure exactly. You don't really fit any of the categories perfectly, but we know you're having problems interacting with people. I can sense that. And so you get this **PDNOS**.
- 3.40 There's been a huge amount of debate about how to make sense out of **personality disorders**. And I'll just say this. The reason is because our map of normal personality looks like the **Big Five**, and our map of disordered personality looks like the three clusters. So you got the three cluster map and the **Big Five** map, and ideally, you'd have one map for normal and not normal, and instead, we have two maps. What's going on now is we're trying to build an integrated map. That would be for another conversation, but maybe I'll return to that at the end. But that's the big debate in psychology and psychiatry right now, is how to build an integrated map of normal and disordered personality.

- 3.41 Now that I covered personality disorders, let me hit NPD, or narcissistic personality disorder. Narcissistic personality disorder, as I mentioned, is a combination of both grandiose and vulnerable traits. I'll go through the specifics. When you look at it, this is my guess, is you're looking at about two-thirds grandiose. The description of NPD, when most people are thinking about it, is a little more grandiose than vulnerable. That's typically, I think, how it looks if you look at the data. I'll tell you, it's hard to do science on narcissistic personality disorder because if you need a sample of people with personality disorders of 250 people, it's very hard to say, "Hey, where's 250 people with narcissistic personality and they want to be in my study?" Just hard to find them.
- 3.42 The very few studies we have come out of hospitals in places like Italy, where they have these very large populations. It's just hard to find, for a lot of reasons. It's, I think, a little more grandiose than vulnerable, but it has features of both. Narcissism in NPD becomes, as I said, extreme, pervasive, inflexible. Imagine you're really narcissistic. You're not just kind of narcissistic, you're pretty narcissistic. But it's also stuck across situations. So again, I go to work and I'm teaching my class and I'm like, "Hey, guys, I'm a legend. I'm a PhD." Everyone's like, "Whoo," and they're cheering, and everyone goes, "That's healthy." And then I go home and I'm like, "Hey, honey, how are you doing? I have a PhD. Did I tell you about my last paper, sweetheart?" She goes, "I don't care. You're a loser." My marriage is shot, right? That pervasiveness is a problem, and that flexibility.
- 3.43 Is there a time and place to be narcissistic? When you're at a cocktail party, it's OK to be a little narcissistic. When you're in a job interview, it's OK to be a little narcissistic. When you're performing. But there's other times you want to turn it off, like if you're talking to a friend who's suffering, and your friend is telling you about what a hard problem they had, Sorry. I just thought of a hilarious story that was really awful. I'll tell it anyway. I just won't use names. I had a buddy in graduate school way back in the day who's an eminent psychologist, and he was describing his therapy. He goes, "Yeah, I listen to people and they're talking about their feelings, and I just go, 'How do you like my tie?'" I thought that was the most narcissistic. Can you imagine? You're just listening to people like, "Oh, and then my husband, and then this," and you're like, "How do you like my tie?"
- 3.44 That's what I mean about this inflexible—your narcissism is just inflexible. If you were just able to just listen for a minute, you would be OK, but you can't even make it through a minute. That's when it's a disorder. You have this narcissism that's extreme, pervasive, inflexible, and then it causes problems, like I mentioned. What are the problems you see? Well, you see cognitive problems with narcissism. You see cognitive distortions. In what way? "I'm really smart, and I can make decisions that are really good, even when I can't." Then the second, which I think is probably a more relevant version of that, is, "I don't learn from negative feedback."
- 3.45 Imagine I'm at work. I started my new company. I do wraps for boats because I'm in Florida, and if I had a boat, I want to put a wrap on it. It's got cool stuff. I don't know why I'm thinking about that. The guy on the plane was telling me about boat wraps. I didn't even know they were a thing, but now I'm way into it. I'm going to start a boat wrap company. I'm like, "I know what I'm

doing. I'm going to do this wrap." They all like red and black because that's Georgia Bulldog colors. That's mean. Everyone wants red and black. People are like, "Dude, this is Florida. We like pink and blue. Didn't you watch Miami Vice?" You're like, "Shut up. I know what I'm doing. You guys are idiots." Well, I don't take that negative feedback, and I don't sell any boat wraps in Florida. This example was god-awful. But I don't sell any boat wraps at all because my own ego gets in the way. That's a bad—well, it's not that bad an example. It's OK.

- 3.46 Imagine I'm working in an investment bank and I'm making a huge trade, a fat finger trade. I'm like, "Man, I got to make some money this Christmas season. No one's watching. I'm going to bet it all on this," and I bankrupt Baring's Bank or something. That's when you start getting real bad stuff. You start making high-risk decisions. You don't learn from your mistakes. Your ego gets in the way. That's a cognitive problem with narcissism. What about impulse control problems? Impulse control isn't classically narcissistic. That isn't the first thing you think about, but you do see some. You see addiction. You see, traditionally—I like it, traditional narcissists would be addicted to cocaine, especially in the 1970s when that was a thing. You see addiction to stimulants. Why would you take cocaine if you're narcissistic? Well, that jacks up your dopamine, makes you feel good, makes you feel energized, makes you talkative. You might see cocaine addiction.
- 3.47 You might see an alcohol addiction. But I drink whatever I drink, and then I feel good. So I'm using impulsive drug use to regulate my behavior. So it could be something like that. It could be sexual impulsivity that you might see, the sex addiction to the extent that is, or maybe gambling that goes with narcissism a little bit. So you could see some of those. The biggest issue with narcissism and **narcissistic personality disorder**, though, is relational problems. Narcissism is a disaster for relationships. This is where it can get weird conceptually. Most mental disorders, most **personality disorders**, people feel bad. If I'm depressed, I feel bad. If I'm anxious, I feel bad. I feel nervous. If I've got some social issue, I feel disconnected. I feel socially isolated. I feel bad.
- 3.48 So typically, people will feel bad about a disorder, and they will go to a doctor. "Hey, doctor, I feel bad. I'm sad all the time. My energy is not there. I'm lacking joy and vitality in life. I'm fearful and anxious all the time. It's becoming debilitating. Fix me," right? That's your classic disorder. Narcissism is a little different. Narcissism is, "Yeah, I'm freaking awesome. I'm crushing it, but my boss doesn't see it, and my wife is the most self-centered. She just doesn't respect me at all. She is so lucky to have me. I can't believe it. I'm not going to see a doctor because I'm not the problem. I'm going to try to fire—I'm going to try to get my boss fired, and I'm going to try to get rid of my wife, because they're the problem."
- 3.49 So what happens with narcissism is often you don't feel bad, you feel good; and to the extent there's problems in your life, it's everyone else's fault but your own. So here's what happens. One is, you destroy your marriage and you wreck your wife, you wreck your kids, you wreck your coworkers. You just do a lot of damage. Then secondly, you don't go into therapy because there's nothing wrong with you. That's these relational problems. The other addictions do this as well. You meet somebody with an alcohol addiction. They're like, "Yeah, I'm pretty good. I drink, but my wife is a problem. My work's a problem. They're just too hard on me."

- 3.50 So you see other disorders like this, but this is what makes narcissism a bit of a conundrum. When we talk about therapy, this is what makes therapy so hard. It's because somebody narcissistic doesn't want to go into therapy. "What are you going to tell me? I'm not a 10, I'm an 8? I don't want it. That's not what I want out of therapy." But if I'm depressed and think I'm a 4, and you're going to tell me I'm an 8, I want to go. The relational problems, I think, are the key with narcissism, and I'll talk about that more as we go through the course.
- 3.51 Then finally, there are emotional problems. With narcissism, the two big emotional issues you see, you see that externalizing emotion, anger, rage, that can be a real problem. Just raging out at people. I'm sorry, I'm laughing because I do this all the time. I'm really working on this. But I'll just get so frustrated at the world, I'll drive my car—because I never do this in person—but I'll be driving my car. I go, "The world is falling apart. Everybody's insane," and I just start screaming. What the heck is wrong with me? Sorry, I shouldn't admit it. You guys are looking me with horror. Yeah, I got to admit it, I got problems. But that's that kind of rage, right? You just get enraged.
- 3.52 Now, imagine you're at a restaurant, and the waiter pours the wrong drink for you. You go, "Don't you respect me enough to get me the right drink? Who the heck are you? You shouldn't be here. I'm getting the manager," blah, blah, blah, blah. You just start in a rage cycle, right? That's a problem. That's embarrassing. You don't want to be that person. But that's the emotional problem that you get with narcissism. It's typically rage, with more vulnerability. Sometimes it's internal, so it's that sense of hostility and stewing and, like, "I'm going to show them all, I'm going to get them all." You're just in your head, you're just like, grr. Sorry, I did that with some real intensity, too. I got some issues in that direction. You can have that emotional stuff.
- 3.53 Then, as I mentioned, sometimes you get shame. It's not as common. You have to look for narcissistic shame because it's pretty good at covering up. But sometimes you go, "Yeah, I'm a loser," and you feel this deep shame. Shame is an interesting emotion. I'm throwing out these terms; I should define them. In psychology, we often differentiate between shame and guilt. Guilt is like, "I did something wrong, and I can make amends for it. I feel guilty. I ate your soup out of the refrigerator. I feel guilty about it. I'm sorry. I'll buy you some more soup, and then we're all good." Shame is when I'm a bad person. When I feel shame, it's like, "I'm just—Keith is bad." What do you do? I can't do anything. Keith's a bad person. I can't do anything about shame. So shame is a globalized negative emotion that makes people very unhappy.
- 3.54 And so, the idea of narcissistic shame is it gets deflected very quickly. If you get in that shame thing with narcissism, you'll end up seeing rage. So one of the classic analytic models, you see this **shame-rage spiral** with narcissism. Again, it's hard to find it because most people who say, "If I ruled the world, it would be a better place, and I'm hot," don't feel a lot of shame unless you really push them, and then you see it just for a second or two. That's the overall description of the overview of **NPD**.

- 3.55 What are the actual traits? Well, the way the diagnosis of **personality disorder** works—and this is really ugly science, it's just how we do it, it's ugly assessment—is you give people a list of qualities or a list of descriptors, and you say, "Do you match 5 of 9 of these?" With narcissism, it's literally—I'll read them to you—but literally, it's like, "Hey, do you have 5 of 9 of these traits or these features, and do they cause significant impairment?" Meaning, do I check 5 of 9 of these boxes, and do each of the boxes I check cause you significant impairment in life? That's how you do this. The disorders differ. Sometimes it may be it's 5 of 9, sometimes it's 4 of 7, or whatever, but it's usually some weird combination of traits that you add up. Again, it's just an unfortunate assessment system.
- 3.56 This is the basic description. Narcissism, or **NPD**, "a pervasive pattern of **grandiosity** in fantasy or behavior, **need for admiration**, and **lack of empathy**, beginning by early adulthood and present in a variety of contexts, is indicated by 5 or more of the following." That's your basic overall description of narcissism, which should sound familiar to you at this point. But what's interesting about that is it's got all these key terms. "Pervasive pattern." What that means—pervasive—it's pervading all aspects of your life. "In fantasy or behavior." That's cool because the grandiose people are going to do this in behavior. The vulnerable people are going to do this in fantasy. You can have this narcissistic life that's a fantasy life. **Walter Mitty**.
- 3.57 "**Need for admiration**." That's interesting. That's the **self-regulation** piece. I need a social world that's going to help boost my ego. I can't just do it on my own. I need a social world. I have **need for admiration**. "**Lack of empathy**," that's what I've talked about, lack of social connection with people. And then, beginning in early adulthood. Again, this is part of your character. It's something about your personality. It's not that you just discovered cocaine when you visited Miami in 2016. In 2023, what year are we? I don't even know anymore. That's so bad. I keep pretending it's the '80s. I just, I wake up in the morning—this is like my delusion—I'm like, maybe it's 1985 again, and everything's awesome. I'm like, "Darn it." Just getting so old.
- 3.58 Five of 9. So what are the 5? What are 5 of the 9? What are the 9? Well, first, number one, has a grandiose sense of self-importance. So that means you exaggerate achievements, you exaggerate talents, you expect to be recognized as superior without commensurate—I hate that word. You expect to be recognized as an expert without actually achieving anything. So the **grandiosity**, this self-importance, has to be something that's a little bit inflated, meaning it's not real, and it has to cause you problems. You think you're a big deal, and that causes you problems. How would that cause you problems? Well, maybe other people don't recognize it, so they're always saying you're not as cool as you think, or you're doing dumb stuff, like you're acting like an expert when you don't know what you're talking about.
- 3.59 Two, is preoccupied with fantasies of unlimited success, power, brilliance, beauty, or ideal love. So this is a more fantasy aspect of narcissism. And what's interesting about this is you have these classic fantasies. I want to fantasize about power. I want to fantasize about success, but also ideal love. So sometimes what you hear in the clinical descriptions of narcissism is the fantasy, is I'm going to find the perfect partner, and I'm going to have the perfect marriage or the perfect relationship, and that's going to be my manifestation of narcissism. Otherwise, it's

going to be classic. I'm going to be a superstar, I'm going to be a celebrity, I'm going to be a footballer, I'm going to be a whatever cool thing you want to be. A professor—that's the pinnacle, I like to tell you guys. It used to be cool. It used to be cool to be a professor. That's two.

- 3.60 Three, believes that he or she is special and unique and can only be understood by or associated with other special or high-status people or institutions. This is where you find people getting ego from their group or their institution. This is the "I went to the Ivy League" flex, or people, they'll put where they worked, or "I worked at this tech company" flex, or it's just a general feeling that I should be with cool people, and other people are beneath me, below the line. There's people I should be with that are above-the-line people, and they're the bad people below the line. I just don't want them in my life because they bring me down and they're dirty and gross, and some of that dirty grossness might rub off on me.
- 3.61 Number four, requires excessive admiration. This one makes sense, but it's also a judgment call. What's excessive admiration? I require a little admiration, just every once in a while. I just want my dog to at least come when I come home. Maybe it would be nice to get an "attaboy" or something. A little admiration would be good, but excessive is the problem. See, this is where it becomes a clinical thing. What is excessive admiration? It's like, I need my back patted all the time, or I always need to be in the limelight, or I always need to have attention. It's weird. You can see the narcissism, and I'll probably say this 40 times in this course, but when you hang out, I'll hang out with a group of high-status guys, and not one guy will say, "I'm an alpha male," or "I'm a big deal." Anybody who's like, "I'm an alpha male," you go, "I know one thing. You're not an alpha male. I don't know anything else about you, except you're not alpha for saying that." So this idea of requiring attention, requiring admiration, is interesting. I think it's hard to define, but I think it's cool. So that's number four.
- 3.62 Number five on our top 9 narcissistic traits is having a **sense of entitlement**, which we talked about a little bit before. So, "an unreasonable expectation of especially favorable treatment or automatic compliance with his or her expectations." So what that means is I, in my mind, feel that I am the Queen, I guess King, of England in my head. Queen Elizabeth, she was there so long. It's hard to remember she's not there. I walk around life like I'm a little king. I'm a little lord, little Lord Keith. When I go to the Starbucks, I'm like, "What would you like?" I'm like, "Lord Keith would like this." They're like, "Sorry, I'm still making this mochaccino." Then I get enraged because no one's paying attention to me. It's unreasonable expectations.
- 3.63 One thing I should say here is, you do have reasonable expectations to be treated well. There is a reasonable amount of **entitlement**. People should expect that people treat them with respect, with courtesy, as a human being who has a soul. It's not that you have to hate yourself. It's just when you go around thinking you're little Lord Fauntleroy, or whoever, that can be a problem. So **sense of entitlement** is number five.
- 3.64 Number six is interpersonally exploitative. I like that word. Interpersonally exploitative. That means you exploit people or take advantage of them. You use people as tools or props, or you

use them in an instrumental way, or you use people as means towards an end. People are just like things if you're narcissistic. I find this really interesting. When we talk about relationships, you'll see this. "I got a great-looking girlfriend." "Would you trade her for a Porsche?" "Sure. Why not?" Because they're the same thing. They do the same thing for me. They're both about ego. I get more ego from a Porsche than a girlfriend. I'll take the Porsche. When you hear that, if you're a human being with a soul, you go, "That's a little dark, man. That seems a little mean." That's because you're not interpersonally exploitative. That's the exploitation piece. It's taking advantage of people, manipulating people.

- 3.65 Seven is a **lack of empathy** and unwillingness to recognize or identify with the feelings and needs of others. As I said before, with narcissism, it isn't that —I think this is something Jennifer Aniston said about Brad Pitt, and if I'm wrong, I probably could be wrong, so don't quote me on it, but it was like, "He lacks an **empathy** chip." I think that was the line. I liked that line. It stuck with me. But that's not classic narcissism. It's not necessarily, you don't—like I said before, you can see people. You can take people's perspective. You're not totally blind to people. It's just you don't care that much. You're just like, "Yeah, I put you on a scale and me on a scale, and I just weigh a little more than you. I just matter a little more." That's more what you're seeing with narcissism. It's not just this totally cold, psychopathic stuff. It's more just, "I matter more."
- 3.66 Eight is often envious of others, or believes that others are envious of him or her. This is an interesting item. It's what we call a classic double-barreled item. Never write items like this if you're a psychologist, because it can mean either thing. Either I'm envious of people or I think people are envious of me. The reason it's written like that, which you're probably starting to get right now, is it's trying to capture vulnerability and **grandiosity**. People who are vulnerable are out there thinking that they're envious of people. "How come you have that? Why do you get all that? I deserve that. I'm better than you. How come you have all those cool things?" People who're grandiose, they're walking around going, "Yeah, everybody wishes they were me." It's both about envy, it's both about status, but one's more like, "I got it, and everybody wants it," and one is more like, "I'm craving, I need to get it." One's deficit, finding status, and one is having it and just showing it.
- 3.67 Finally, the final one shows arrogant, haughty behaviors or attitudes. This is displays of arrogance or haughtiness that are clinically impairing. My favorite, I don't know, it's my favorite example. This was in Sun Valley, or maybe Ketchum. I don't know. I can't remember. At a cocktail party with a very wealthy group. One of the guys at the cocktail party came up to me and introduced himself with a cocktail in hand, and he was wearing an ascot, like **Thurston Howell** on Gilligan's Island. This is way before your time. You know what an ascot is? A rich guy's tie. No one wears them. He was wearing an ascot. I thought, "This guy's awesome. I got to talk to this guy."
- 3.68 So he tells me how he was in the Mountain Division, whatever, in World War II, like the skiing military guys. And I'm thinking, "Dude, you're not old enough to be in the Mountain Division, but that's OK." And then he tells me his kid got into Harvard and Yale, and Yale's overrated. So I was like, "Dude, you're a legend." I'm just making notes. Really nice conversation. I told you, I get

along with narcissists just fine. I just did—the **entitlement** I don't like. He was funny. Then I talked to his wife later that night. I think she'd had a few drinks, and she knew what I did. She goes, "I think my husband might be a little narcissistic." I'm like, "Really? Did the ascot give it away?" But I didn't say that. I was like, aw.

- 3.69 That's haughtiness, that kind of haughty, arrogant, stuck-up. It's a real turn-off. It's a turn-off to some people, but it also works. If I was wearing an ascot right now in a suit, you guys would think like, "God, that guy's got it. He's got something going on." It would work for a while. But then you'd eventually, after you got to know him, you go like, "Yeah, douchebag." I can't believe I just said that on mic. I tried to hide it, and then I realized the mic was right—I was hiding it in the mic right there. They picked it up extra. Anyway, I'm talking so much.
- 3.70 That's the description of **NPD**. Those are the literal descriptors, clinically. Five of 9, cause impairment, you're diagnosed. In real life, you're not going to go to a psychiatrist and go through full diagnosis because they don't have time for that. Who has time to do diagnosis? They're going to talk to you for 10 minutes and come up with something. You'll get diagnosed if you're in a psychiatric hospital or if you pay a lot of money for somebody to do it. We just don't do it as much, or you're in a research study.
- 3.71 A couple of things I want to say. I want to talk a little bit about the **differential diagnosis** piece for a second, which I mentioned with narcissism. Then I'm going to talk about some of the dynamic models, and then we'll be out of time this time, so we're good. One thing I noticed with narcissism is it's important—there's a lot of things that can look like narcissism, a lot of things that can look like **grandiosity**. You see this with celebrities all the time. As a Gen Xer, my idol as a generational hero was **Charlie Sheen**. Just love that guy. He's a maniac, right? Classic Gen Xer. You guys probably don't remember him. He's an actor. His dad was an actor. His brother was an actor.
- 3.72 Charlie got into some trouble at one point. We just didn't—no one knew what was going on with **Charlie Sheen**. What people were saying is, "Gee, he's narcissistic." And somebody else is saying, "Gee, he's manic," because you see a lot of creative actors with mania. See, maybe it's a manic state. Other people are saying, "Oh, it's a delusional disorder. That guy, he's got some schizophrenia, something going on." Other people are saying, "It's drugs, man. That's just cocaine. You do that much cocaine, it starts going to your head." And other people are saying it's situationally acquired. You go to Hollywood, everyone tells you you're a big deal. You become really famous, you become narcissistic. I don't know **Charlie Sheen**. Maybe it's none of those things.
- 3.73 The idea, though, is that you can see these really, what look like very narcissistic figures out there, and you can see them in the media, but you don't really know what's going on unless you have some history, unless you have some background. I always like to caution people about that. I love throwing labels out there as much as the next person because it's fun to talk about public figures, but it's often a very complicated story, especially with mania. I think mania can look like narcissism and the drugs, too.

- 3.74 So, in terms of how to think about—remember I said that this narcissistic personality disorder, it became popular in the '60s and '70s. I talked about Kernberg and Kohut, the two psychodynamic clinical psychologists or psychoanalysts who started looking at this. I thought I'd spend the remaining moments talking a bit about a more psychoanalytic or psychodynamic model of narcissism. It's a little weird; it's a little deeper. So, the traditional psychoanalytical model of narcissism, there's some different versions of it, but they converge on the idea that, in an early stage of development—two years old, three years old, four years old, maybe it's Oedipal; I mean, maybe it's oral phase at two, maybe it's a little later than that—at some point in development, you start to identify not with who you are, but you start to identify with a false or phony self, a narcissistic self, a grandiose self-structure, a fake self-structure, something else. So the person that you think is you isn't really you. It's an avatar or an identity of you, something. This is psychoanalytic.
- 3.75 So when Freud talked about this, he talked about connecting libido, sexual energy, to a representation of yourself that's an idealized representation. I have the idea of Keith, myself, which is Keith does a lot of dumb stuff. Sometimes, Keith doesn't wake up in the morning. Keith does the wrong stuff to his daughters all the time. Keith makes mistakes every time he does stuff. Instead of identifying with that Keith, I identify with the Keith who is perfect, who is attractive, who doesn't make mistakes, who's better than everybody else. At a very early age, I identify with this self. This is this Freudian idea. Then when this idea got filtered through Kernberg and Kohut, you ended up with this very deep, dynamic view of narcissism, and they were a little different.
- 3.76 I'm going to talk about this stuff, but I'm always going to say, I got really into this about 20 years ago and read everything, and I don't know it as well as I could anymore. I'm just admitting that because I don't know who does. We don't have a lot of great psychoanalytic work. There's still some people in New York, but a lot of this is going away. So Kernberg thought about narcissism as being a defense against an inner rage. It's really interesting. At a very early stage—so this idea is, you have an infant who is, what would it be, 18 months old, 2 years old, feels this intense rage against a parent, breastfeeding, and takes that rage and develops a self out of that rage. And how that works, I don't know. This is psychoanalytics.
- 3.77 So, the self develops. And so when you end up with that adult narcissist, and you see this narcissistic self, and you start pushing that self, you start saying, "Hey, maybe you're not this great. Maybe this isn't true. Maybe this isn't really you," what you're going to run into is rage. So Kernberg's idea was, underneath this manifestation of what a legend you are, is this deep-seated childhood rage. When you pop that narcissistic bubble, or pop that narcissistic bloom, what you're going to just see is this childish anger. It makes sense. That's his model. It's a very pathological model of narcissism, and it suggests that the suffering of narcissism is really, really deep in childhood, starting a year or two years old.
- 3.78 So this is one model. I think this model is the closest to vulnerable narcissism, and this model aligns narcissism a lot more with borderline personality. It's more defensive, it's more deep, it's more based on rage, it's more relational. Kohut's model, which came out around the same time,

is a little different. In Kohut's model, narcissism is a really normal aspect of development. You can get narcissism in development by being loved by your mother. So while you're growing up as an infant, Mom's like, "You're the most beautiful baby. Oh, look at my beautiful baby." That's normal narcissism. That's healthy. That's adaptive. What Kohut said is, if you didn't get some of that, what he would call **mirroring**, when you were young—you didn't have people that really emotionally engage with you at a young age—you felt emptiness. There was an emptiness there. Narcissism was built up as a defense against that sense of emptiness.

- 3.79** In his model of narcissism, it's a little more developed. It's a little less pathological. It's a little more like, hey, a normal kid developed. You didn't get the love you needed, so you built up an identity that allowed you to get that love. "I didn't get the love from my mom and dad, but you know what? I became a childhood actor, and I'm loved by millions of Americans, and that's what feels good to me." "I didn't get that love from my parent, but I put myself into academia and wrote books and became popular and gained fans, and now I feel good about myself."
- 3.80** So the Kohut model of narcissism is also a defense, but the defense is more against emptiness; and when you break through it, it's more like an existential crisis. Like, "Who am I? God, I've been doing this stuff; I've been doing this my whole life, and it's all fake. I've been doing this act just to feel something. I didn't need to do it at all. I just feel sad." Sorry. Imagine having this breakthrough in therapy after 18 months on a couch, and you're like, "Oh my god. My parents didn't love me my whole life. I just did it, just to feel that love. I just feel so sad and empty," and you just cry it out, and then you walk out of there, and you feel pretty freaking good. "I'm going to go to Taco Bell, man."
- 3.81** I don't know if any of this stuff is true or not true. I tend to be a little more—I tend to think more like a personality psychologist. But I think when you're talking about **NPD**, and I think when you're talking about going into psychotherapy with somebody who's an expert of this, this is the tradition they're going to come from. I think this is really useful, and I think it's very powerful stuff. It's just hard to study 1-year-old trauma in the lab. That's the classic model. How we think about it now, I'll just finish up with this, is we tend to think of narcissistic personality as an extreme manifestation of normal personality. So I don't see **NPD** as, oh, it's a different path in life. I'd say, yeah, there's some narcissistic people, but dude, your narcissism is a little out of control. So that tends to be how I'd see it more. Again, I'm not a clinician, but I think more it's, like, extreme personality and flexible personality.
- 3.82** We do see people—I've done research on this. People do feel like they're putting on a mask with their narcissism. Their narcissism is a front or cover for some defense. People do report that it's not everybody. It's some people are narcissistic, say, "Yeah, it's a mask." Others are like, "No, it's not a mask." The people who say it's a mask tend to be a little more neurotic, a little more vulnerable. So I think there's some awareness that, "Yeah, I've got this vulnerability. I'm putting on a front a little bit." So you do see that.
- 3.83** The other thing we've talked about in the modern definition of **NPD** is adding **specifiers**. And a **specifier** is like saying, "Hey, it's narcissism, but it's a little specific kind of narcissism." So two

specifiers people have talked about—one is malignant narcissism. So malignant narcissism is an old term that goes, I think it goes back to Erich Fromm, but I could be wrong. But malignant narcissism is a very toxic, destructive, mean, nasty form of—malignant. It's basically malignant. Malice, bad, Latin. So malignant narcissism is maybe a really toxic, antagonistic form. There's also been a discussion, meaning, we discussed it, of having a vulnerable specifier, so maybe NPD with vulnerable features. So you can maybe think about narcissism as a disorder and then specify it.

- 3.84 The other couple other things that are going on in the personality disorder world—one, as I mentioned before, wouldn't it be nice if our normal model of personality and our pathological model were the same? Wouldn't that be easy? What people have done is they've developed a pathological model of the Big Five called the PID-5. It's just pathological Big Five. Same traits, but just with a little pathological spin. You can use that model to detect narcissism. When that model, the traits they use are grandiosity and I think self, maybe it's grandiosity and attention-seeking, I think. Could be wrong.
- 3.85 There's a way you can do it with normal personality now, and that's a big debate that's going on in clinical psychology. If any of you go into clinical and you open your DSM-5 and go, "Why is there an emerging model of personality disorders in that, Keith?" I'm like, "That's the politics I was talking about," which I'm not going into. There's also a lot of discussion now about thinking about relational disorders, thinking about mental disorders as being primarily relational, because they're not so much individual. We think about psychological disorders as individual, but some of them are relational. I think narcissism qualifies as a very relational disorder.
- 3.86 So, to the extent the clinical community and psychiatric community starts mapping out these more relational disorders, I think that's going to be really important for narcissism. I'll finish with this. Clinical diagnosis and assessment is really cool. It's an ongoing field. What I'm telling you now is history. It's good stuff, but I expect this all to change. I hope in 10 years, we've got a much more integrated model that's based on Big Five and normal personality. But this is what we've got right now. So thank you very much.

4. Narcissism in Love

AT A GLANCE

Examines narcissism in romantic relationships. Narcissists seek self-enhancement (trophy partners, status, short-term sex), power through game playing and gaslighting, breadcrumbing and ghosting, and infidelity via attention to alternatives, while refusing the other-serving bias that close relationships require. Self-protection surfaces as violence after rejection, illustrated by school shooters. Explains why narcissists attract: effortful appearance and social confidence in thin slices, yet they bring control, deception, lying, and low accommodation. Presents the chocolate cake model: high initial satisfaction and excitement that decline while emotional intimacy never develops, and the extended agency model of using people as fuel. Closes with questions on leaving, gender, and society.

- 4.1 So in this session, we're talking about relationships. And as I hinted at in the first few sessions, relationships are at the key of a lot of narcissistic behavior. It's where you see a lot of the damage of narcissism, but it's where you see a lot of the action of narcissism. And when we talk about relationships, there's lots of kinds of relationships you can think about. You can think about friendships, you can think about your work buddies, you can think about your parents, you can think about your children, your siblings, your romantic relationships. Narcissism has a similar influence in all these areas. It works in a similar way, whether it be in a marriage or in a parenting relationship or in a friendship.
- 4.2 But the way the research is, most of our research is on romantic relationships, on dating and romance. So when I talk about this, that's going to be where my bias is. Romantic relationships are also really interesting because we tend to be real stupid in them. You're picking a business partner, you think about a lot of things. When you pick a romantic partner, you're not quite as thoughtful sometimes. So it gets interesting. So I'm going to talk about relationships, a little bit of a focus on romantic relationships.
- 4.3 And then what I wanted to hit on today, I want to go around the whole spectrum of the relationship. So I want to talk about what makes narcissists—well, what narcissists want in relationships. Then what makes narcissists attractive, what makes narcissists unattractive, so sort of the two sides. You're going to see this when we talk about relationships or leadership or anything, really; you see the two sides of narcissism. Then I want to talk about some models of relationships, especially the **chocolate cake model**. There's a dynamic process of how narcissism unfolds over time. I want to touch on that a little bit. That's the overview of what we're doing today.
- 4.4 When you ask the question, "What do narcissists want in relationship?", and generally, this is grandiose or vulnerable presentations of narcissism, what you're looking for primarily is **self-enhancement**. It's ego needs, just like everything else. I'm approaching a relationship. My goal is to enhance myself, to gain status, to gain prestige, to gain something for my ego from this relationship. There's other things, too. It's not like I don't care about having someone to go out

to dinner with, or I don't care about whatever. But there's an over-emphasis on ego needs and self-enhancement. You can see this in lots of relationships.

- 4.5 I'll go back to my dissertation. My dissertation was, I think it was called, Narcissism and Romantic Attraction. It was essentially looking at what people who are narcissistic, these are mostly undergrads, were looking for in dating relationships. I set up some partners, and here are some choices. What people are looking for, primarily, is somebody to have a relationship with who has very high status. Somebody who's attractive, has a successful job, is considered to be a high-status individual. That's the primary thing. Things like emotional closeness, things like emotional intimacy, they're not non-important. They're just relatively less important to somebody who's narcissistic.
- 4.6 So you imagine, "Hey, what do you want in a partner? Do you want somebody who's just awesome and looks great and will look great in a picture and give you a lot of status if you're walking down the street with them? Or do you want somebody who really loves you?" "Well, they both sound good, but I want to look good on the street." That's what you see with narcissism a little bit, with self-enhancement. The term we use for this in dating or marriage, sometimes is like a trophy spouse. That's, like, one version of this. What's a trophy spouse? Well, what that means is, "I've gotten really successful. I made a lot of money. I want to show people my status. After I get a nice car, I go get a nice-looking wife to show status." It's a trophy. I mean, it's a romantic partner used for instrumental ends to gain status for the person who's married to that person. Does that make sense? That's a trophy spouse.
- 4.7 What you see, one of these classic manifestations of narcissistic relationships for self-enhancement is picking a trophy spouse, trophy partner, trophy wife, whatever it is. But it can be other things, too. It can be, like, you can brag about your kids. You can be, like, "I'm a loser, but you should hear about my kids. I've got a trophy kid. My kid is the greatest athlete in middle school in the state of Nebraska." That sounds cool, I guess. You can use your kids as props for self-esteem. You could use your spouse as a prop if you wanted, but that gets a little complicated. I mean, the trophy is probably the best way, but sometimes—anyway, I'll get to that in a second.
- 4.8 But you can brag about other things. You can brag about having cool friends. "Oh, yeah, I hang out with so-and-so at Miami Beach. He's got a Lamborghini." Oh, that makes you cool. You could talk about your cool family lineage. "Oh, my great-grandfather had an oil well." That makes you a cool person. But that's the same idea. So you're getting status from relationships. Relationships are instrumental. So I think that's one of the first keys to understanding narcissism in relationships, is this self-enhancement process.
- 4.9 Another way you see this is—and I talked about sex, status and stuff —what you'll see in romantic relationships are short-term relationships that are instrumental, short-term sexual relationships. This is primarily with men, more than women. Men can get status from having a lot of sexual partners. Women, frankly, it's a lot easier, so you don't get as much status. But what you'll see with some narcissists is like, "Yeah, I slept with a lot of people, and therefore I

have status." So it's a way of getting status. And again, this is using other people in a very instrumental way. You're using them as a means to an end. It's not about, I'm looking for emotional closeness. I'm looking for deep connection. I'm just using people.

- 4.10 Another thing you see in this narcissist approach to relationships is power. It's people who are narcissistic when they enter a relationship want power over the other person. Power does a few things. One, if you have power, you have status, so that's good in and of itself. The second thing you do when you have power is you're able to control people and get what you want. You can actually use your power to do what you want with somebody. This all gets really creepy and dark, and I apologize. It's just the nature of how this works.
- 4.11 What do we talk about with power and narcissism? There's several different models of this. One that I looked at—this is back in some of my, maybe right after grad school—was **game playing**. Just this basic idea of playing head games or playing mind games in a relationship as a way of getting power. How do you do that? You do it like the myth of **Narcissus**. "I love you. No, I hate you. Oh, you're good enough for me. No, no one's good enough for me." You keep people a little unstable in terms of—you keep people unstable in terms of their standing in the relationship. You make your partner feel like they don't know where they stand. Are they loved? Are they not loved? Are they connected? Are they not connected?
- 4.12 The reason you do this in order to get power is there's an old principle in sociology called the **principle of least interest**. It's a very powerful principle, which is, whenever you're in a relationship with somebody, the partner who's the least interested has the most power. If you're in a dating relationship, the person who doesn't care has the power, and the person who cares the most has the least power. It's the exact opposite of how it should be, but it's just how it is. So you imagine, when I was dating my wife, who is much more attractive than I am, she had all the relationship power. I was just like an idiot. "You want to do this?" "Of course I do." Puppy. That's just relationship power.
- 4.13 You can see that in all sorts of relationships, and you can see it happening in a very natural way. Somebody's more attractive, or maybe somebody's a little more desperate to have a relationship. But with narcissism, this sense of power or this sense of interest is manipulated, where people are like, "I don't really have interest. I do have interest. I don't have interest." It's that insecurity or instability, building instability into the system.
- 4.14 The more extreme form of this **game playing** or power is something that I hear people have talked about a lot in the last five years or so, and it's this concept of **gaslighting**. **Gaslighting**, there's not a lot of research on this. There's one philosophical paper. There might be, I haven't seen, I mean, not like I read everything. I try, but I can't even hold it in my head anymore. People have started to look at this, but we don't have a real research on this. It's more of a conceptual idea. But this term **gaslighting**, which is also a very weird term. Like, what the heck does that mean? Well, it turns out there was an old play back in the UK, back in the day, I'll say, that they turned into a movie, and then they had a British movie, and I think they made an American movie.

- 4.15 The plot of this movie was, you had a husband who was a bad guy, trying to manipulate his wife. And the way he decided to do this was make her feel she's going crazy. So he manipulated his wife by making her think she's going crazy. How did he do that? He destabilized her connection with reality. She didn't feel she had connection with reality. He did this in specific ways. He would go to the house and he'd adjust the gas lights. He'd say, "I turned down all the lights." Back in the day, you had, instead of electric lights, you had lighting based on natural gas. I think it was natural gas. What do I know, geology? But you had gas lights in the house, and he'd turned the lights down, and then he'd turn them up. She'd say, "Is something going on with the lights?" And he'd go, "No. Are you going crazy? There's nothing going on with the lights."
- 4.16 Or he'd go up to the attic and he'd make a bunch of noise in the attic. She'd say, "Oh, I heard all this noise in the attic." He'd say, "What are you talking about? There's no noise in the attic. You must be going crazy." **Gaslighting** is a way of undermining somebody's sense of reality, their sense of stability, their sense of connection to reality, their ability to reality-test, whatever you want to describe it. Once people are cut off like that, you can do anything to them because they don't trust themselves. When people don't trust themselves. I'm giving you—this is evil stuff. This is how you really manipulate people. You do this in **cults**, you do this in a lot of places. But keeping somebody cut off and destabilized and unable to test reality is a way of maintaining power over people. So that's **gaslighting**.
- 4.17 I joke about everything, like everything. I can tell you, I've been in some really bad situations, and I always am making jokes about it. That's just how I handle stuff. It's my coping. So I joke about narcissism and relationships like, ha ha, because I joke about everything. I just want to be real clear, because I've talked to so many people who have been in these relationships with really toxic, manipulative, controlling, narcissistic, and often psychopathic individuals. This can be horrifying. This can be really horrifying. It can be debilitating. You can lose total confidence in yourself. It's very, very hard for people. I'm joking a lot because that's just how I am, but I just want to make it clear that this can be, it can be really bad.
- 4.18 Whatever you do, if you're in a situation like this, get support from somebody. I'll talk about this again, but get allies. Get somebody you trust that can always reinforce your sense of what's real. Because when people take away your sense of reality, you're in trouble. That's what they do. You'll see this a lot with—a tangent in here. I shouldn't do that. But as a model I've used for narcissists sometimes, I've thought of billfish. There's a species of fish that are called billfish. We think of them as swordfish, marlin fish, which are named after the marlinspike, sailfish, spearfish. They have these big swords on their noses. What they do, how they hunt, is they see a bunch of normal fish swimming around, and they go into them, and they just swish their sword around a bunch and destabilize everything. Once the fish are destabilized, they can just go eat what they want. It's just a method of predation.
- 4.19 That's what you're seeing with narcissism. They're going in, they're destabilizing people, so they don't know what's up or down, and then they can prey on people. Does that make sense? It's like, this is really nasty stuff, but that's what you're doing conceptually. Destabilization and then prey. This guy starts smiling. Jokes. Well, this is funny. The next thing is funny because it's really

evil. I heard it from all my students. I talked to my students about this. I'm not on the dating market, and I thank god for that every single day because I've heard about the apps and all the maniacs out there. And so when I ask people, "What's going on? What are you seeing with these online things in terms of this game plan and this manipulation?", beyond **gaslighting**, there's two things that come up.

- 4.20 One, and I'm going to say there isn't research on this yet. Maybe there's a little bit, but like an undergrad study, but it's just happening too fast. Research is always slow. One term I hear is **breadcrumbing**, where people online—you'll meet somebody online and they'll give you, like, "Hey, I like you," and then they kind of not do anything, then they give you a little more, then they don't give you something. "Oh, let's do this. Oh, let's not." So it's feeding you. It's just this really kind of a sick way of slowly manipulating somebody into having what they think is a relationship, but isn't really a relationship. It's just feeding it out. It's like feeding out your relationship a little bit at a time.
- 4.21 Then the other term I've heard is **ghosting**, which is basically having a relationship with somebody that seems real. I've got a relationship with somebody. It seems like there's some mutual care or mutual respect, and then the person just vanishes or ghosts on them. You imagine how destabilizing that is. Like, "Oh, I met this person. They seem really cool. We have this connection. I'm a good person. They're a good person. Maybe this will turn into something," and the next thing you know, they're just gone. Like, what? Not like, "I got to go. I had to move to Chile. I got a call." It's not like that. They don't even lie. It's not like in the old days, every kid had a girlfriend in Norway or Canada or something. It was before the internet, you could never check. But these guys just don't even lie. They just vanish. With social media, there's some new ways people are using to manipulate people in these relational spaces that we haven't really studied yet, but it's pretty manipulative.
- 4.22 Then the final thing that narcissists want—there's more, but the final thing I'll talk about right now is, they kind of want to have their cake and eat it, too. It's basically infidelity. There's been pretty good amount of research **on narcissism** and infidelity in relationships. What you see, we see it from a couple different sides. When people are narcissistic, especially more grandiose in relationships, they have what's called higher **attention to alternatives**, meaning they tend to pay more attention to alternative partners than other people do. Generally, how it works in a relationship, if you're in a committed relationship with somebody, romantic relationship, there's a psychological mechanism that kicks on. We talk about this as a relationship maintenance mechanism, where you tend to derogate or put down other potential partners.
- 4.23 I'm happily married. I meet somebody who's really attractive. They don't seem as attractive to me because I'm happily married. That's just the magic of these relationship protection mechanisms, just how it works. It keeps you happy in your relationship. With narcissism, what you see is, you don't really see that. What you see is this **attention to alternatives**. "Hey, I've got this great relationship, but she seems really interested in me, or he seems really interested in me. That's cool." Then you get more infidelity because of it. I think part of it is just ego. It's people like having people who like them. Even if you're in a relationship, if you find someone

else who's attracted to you, that means you're attractive, so there's an ego boost to it. That's part of it.

- 4.24 Part of it is also just, I think, reward-seeking. I think people that are really grandiose with a lot of **extraversion**, a lot of dopamine, are reward-seeking. Like, "Oh, this sounds like a fun opportunity." What you'll end up seeing is you'll see relationships where they have a narcissistic partner. They're cheating on the side. They're just being unfaithful, but they're not seeing that as a real issue for the relationship because they're like, "Well, it's not changing how much I like my wife. This is just on the side. Who cares? It makes me happy, so it's a win-win." Really? It's a win-win for me. Anyway, that's the strategy. It makes sense if you're narcissistic, but if you're not, you're like, "Well, that seems mean to do to your partner."
- 4.25 There's some more, kind of this basic relationship psychology I wanted to talk about as well with **self-enhancement** and narcissism. There's a very basic and powerful tension between enhancing the self and enhancing other people. If I'm standing up here with some stranger I've never met, and they're like, "Who's better looking?" I'm like, "Me," because they're a stranger. I don't care. But if I'm up here with my wife, or if I'm up here with somebody I love, or somebody else I love, say, "Who's better looking?" I'm like, "My wife." I don't need to do that. I'm working with somebody on a project. I'm working with my kids on a project. We do really well. Who did a great job? "Oh, it's all me." I don't say that. I go, "My kids, they really worked hard. I'm really proud of them. Yeah, I helped out a little bit."
- 4.26 What happens when we're in close relationships is we tend to take some of that **self-serving bias** and we put it onto other people and make it more of an **other-serving bias**. It's a really natural thing. You see this with close teams. You're working with somebody on a project and, if you and your friend are working and you fail, you're not like, "My friend did it. He's an idiot." You're like, he's your friend. You go, "Yeah, I screwed this up for us." And your friend goes, "I screwed it up." And then you hug it out, and it's good, right? You're narcissistic, you don't do that. You fail as a team, you blame other people. You fail with your partner, you blame other people.
- 4.27 So narcissism, that natural process of giving up our ego so we can connect to people, trading—we're kind of trading narcissism for love, in a lot of life, giving up ego to have something better. This is what being married, having kids, is about. You're giving up something, you're sacrificing something, but you get something better. It's an exchange. You don't see that with narcissism so much.
- 4.28 Another place you see this same phenomenon, there's a classic, what we call a **self-enhancement** finding, called the **better-than-average effect**. You'll hear people talk about this in lots of places. But it's essentially, if you have to rate yourself as better than average, I think I even talked about it already this time. But you rate yourself better than average on things, we tend to think we're a little better than the average person. If it comes to looks, yeah, we're a 7. If it comes to being a people person, yeah, we're probably a 7 out of 10. When it comes to being a good driver, we're probably a 7 out of 10. We're not average, just a little above average. That's kind of how we feel.

- 4.29 That changes a little bit in relationships, though. When it says, "Are you better than your partner?", we tend to balance it out. We tend to go, "Yeah, we're about the same on these things." Am I a better driver than my partner? "Well, we're both pretty good drivers." You tend to balance that off. And we tend to enhance our partners a little bit. Our partners are pretty good-looking. Our partners are better than average. We do a little bit of that. What happens with people who are narcissistic is they get in a bind. They want their partners to be attractive, but they also want to be better than their partners. Typically, what you'll see with narcissistic reports is they're still saying, even though they'll say their partner is good, because they get value from their partner, they're still going to report being better than their partner on most things, especially things that have to do with status, being smart, successful, creative, etc. That just adds a lot of tension to a romantic or any sort of close relationships, to say, "I'm better than you." Who does that? It wrecks the relationship. That's a part of it.
- 4.30 The other thing that makes this really complicated is, if you're narcissistic, you want to be the best, but you also want to be surrounded by the best. It's a tension. Personally, I'll tell you two stories. Personally, for me, you never know how smart you are until—I remember being an academic, I'm sitting around at dinner with a bunch of people. I look at the room and I go, "I'm the dumbest person at this table. I finally made it." That's when I knew I made it because I looked around and I'm like, "You're smarter than me. You're smart. Oh, my God. Look at this table. I'm an idiot. Yes." Often in life, you get to the highest level you can, and you're the dumbest person in the room. That's your goal. I guess if you're a Miami person, it's all about looking hot. You go to a club and you're the ugliest person in the club. You're like, "I made it. They let me in the door. I must be doing something right. I'll probably keep my shirt on, at least till midnight."
- 4.31 It's cool to be with cool people. With people who are narcissistic, that's a conflict because you're always like, I want to be with cool people, but there's some tension. I was going to tell one story, and I've got to make this story so vague that I hope it works. I was talking to a group of people in the media industry, I will say, and they were talking about someone that they had some challenges with who was very narcissistic. They were just asking my opinion. I was going around talking to these guys, and one of the guys said, "Well, he's never been mean to me." He's done all this stuff. He's never done anything to—this other guy, he's like, "Yeah, I've never done anything to him." I'm talking for a while and I go, "Wait a second," to the guy that the narcissist had never said anything to. I said, "Are you alpha?" I talk like I'm a Californian from the—I'm like, "Dude, are you alpha?" He doesn't say anything. All his buddies are like, "Oh, my god. Oh, yeah. He did this and he did this, and he's such a big —" He's like a huge deal in this world of nerds or something.
- 4.32 And that's what was going on. So what was going on is the narcissist, when he saw somebody that had true status, was sucking up to him. He was basically ingratiating himself to this one person with status, but everyone else who also had status but wasn't quite as good would be put down. So what you'll see with narcissism is, when they're around people with very high status, you'll see a lot of that ingratiation. This is the fancy term for sucking up, ingratiation.

There's some, there's a bit of a dance here with ego. "I want to be the best, but if I'm hanging out with somebody who's really better than me, I want to be hanging out with them, so I'll suck up with them as long as I need to until I'm better than them." That's this tension with **self-enhancement**, and other enhancement.

- 4.33 That's the **self-enhancement** piece of narcissism, like what I can get, what I can get in terms of my ego needs. The other piece you see with narcissism is **self-protection**. We've talked about this before, is **self-regulation**, and this is really powerful in relationships. The general pattern you see is, if somebody is narcissistic, has their ego threatened, and I talked about that a little bit. "You're not as good as you think. You're not as attractive as you think." Social rejection. "I'm not going to be in a relationship with you anymore. I'm out of here. You're not good enough." Frustration or restriction of freedom. That's another one that triggers some of this aggression. "You can't do that. You're not allowed to do this. I'm in charge. You can't do what you want to do." Those are triggers. Any of those things are triggers of **self-protection**.
- 4.34 So, "Keith, you're an idiot." "No, I'm not." "Keith, I'm leaving you." "No, you're not." "If I can't, if you can't, if I can't have you, no one can have you." "Keith, you can't do this." "The hell I can't. I'm doing it right now." That's that kind of defensive structure, and this can be really bad. This can happen at all sorts of levels. I'm so stuck in the '80s. When I was a kid, I grew up in LA and then moved down to Orange County. We used to—good friends that were in Brentwood, LA area near where **O.J. Simpson**, the football player, used to live. He was such a huge celeb, like we all loved **O.J.** growing up. We'd go to Southern Cal games. We'd run by his house. It was just a big deal.
- 4.35 **O.J.** ended up maybe murdering his ex. I guess in one trial, he was found guilty, in one trial, not. I'm not going to say what he did, but you can probably guess. The story was that **O.J.** had very high status, a little bit of an ego. His spouse wanted to leave him, and he murdered her because he didn't want anyone else to have her. That's like your classic narcissistic, violent control behavior. Again, I don't know exactly what happened. That's just the story. There was another case in South Africa with an athlete, I think his name was **Pistorius**, but I'm not 100% sure, who was a track athlete. Another had reported it was very narcissistic. Murdered, I think, his girlfriend. I just read in the papers recently, he might have got out. That kind of couple violence is, I won't say very common, but I say that model is not uncommon. It's a narcissistic person who feels they have control or power over another person. When that person tries to leave, they're like, "No, that's not happening." You get somebody get killed because someone—anyway, just ego.
- 4.36 The other examples of this kind of thing are the old-school school shootings. This is when I was a postdoc at Case Western with **Roy Baumeister**. **Jean Twenge** and I were in this basement office. I was on one side, she was on the other. We had the school shooting at Columbine that you guys probably remember. This was a huge deal at the time. People were just so confused by this. It was just, lots of it happened many times after that. I remember **Jean** and I were reading about this, and Jean's reading these quotes from **Dylan**, that one of the shooters, saying things like,

"Somebody's going to make my movie one day, maybe Spielberg, and I could make anybody believe anything I want, like a mountain's growing out of my back." I'm probably mixing this up.

- 4.37 But she looks at me and Jean's like, "These are all items straight out of the narcissistic personality inventory." I thought, "You are just right." It's manipulative, self-centeredness. We started looking at some of the school shootings; we did some lab research with social rejection. I think that's a reasonable model for what's going on in some of these cases. Some of these cases are different. Some of them are just weird. They're just harder for me to figure out. But some of these cases are classic social rejection and reestablishment of dominance. "You're isolated. You can't be cool in the school." "Who are you to isolate me? I'm going to reestablish my power and dominance by going and shooting a bunch of people. Then have someone write about it, and maybe I'll write a manifesto."
- 4.38 Oh, god. I just remembered manifestos. I've read so many. Often the school shooters will write manifestos before they do that. My general rule in life is if you're writing a manifesto, seek help. I told this to people in one medical school. A guy's like, "I'm literally writing one now." I'm like, "Dude, you're OK. It's on raising kids. I think you'll be OK." But I'm like, "If you're ever in that mental state where, like, 'You know what? I need to write a manifesto because the whole world needs to understand my viewpoint. Then I'm going to shoot a bunch of people,' I'm like, you're not on the right track. I promise. That's the wrong track."
- 4.39 If you ever spend time reading these school shooter manifestos, as I have, there's a tremendous amount of ego. It's a tremendous amount of control. It's often people that are essentially what I would call losers. We're not allowed to say that anymore. So they're people who aren't really high in status, that are trying to—and instead of just saying, "Yeah, I don't have high status, but that's cool. I can have some friends and go have fun. Who cares? Big deal," they go, "I'm going to have to establish status, and I don't feel I can do it through the normal channel of getting a job and getting my hair cut and buying a car. So what I'm going to do is shoot people and I'm going to write about it and film it."
- 4.40 You do get status from that, and you do get fame from that. We have an entire industry that elevates people into fame for doing crime, so it's not like they're wrong about that. But it's, yeah, it's just not a cool way, it's just not a cool way to deal with rejection. That was a bit of a ramble, I'm sorry, but it's just, I spent a lot of years thinking about that stuff. So that's the self-protection piece with narcissism. We've talked so much about what narcissists want in relationships. None of it sounds really good. If I went and talked to a group of people, I'm like, "Hey, learning that, how many are looking for narcissism as the number one trait in their new girlfriend or boyfriend?", the answer would be no. It doesn't sound super appealing to me. I like that Doctor Strange stuff, but other than that—if he's a surgeon, maybe. But otherwise, no way. That's it. Only a brain surgeon.
- 4.41 So the question is, what makes narcissists attractive? Because they sure don't sound attractive when I talk about it, but they are. So that's the conundrum. Well, one thing you find with people who are more narcissistic is they're better-looking. They look better. They're more attractive,

like physically attractive. Narcissists look good. There's a couple different theories about that. One idea some of the evolutionary people had is, well, maybe they're just better-looking people. Maybe somebody evolved to be better-looking. You have got a little better starting place, and you can take advantage of people more. Really interesting idea.

- 4.42 So researchers did this great study, and it's one of my two buddies. I can't remember which one, so I apologize. What they did was, they took pictures of participants in two conditions. First, "Hey, come into the lab, dress like you normally wear. I'll get a picture of your face. Now take off your makeup, take off those cool glasses, take off the jewelry, and we'll get another picture of your face." I think they even had guys shave their beards and stuff. That's what it said. It's just hard for me to imagine that the ethics had them do it, and guys would do it, but who knows? Then they compared the pictures and had the pictures rated on attractiveness, and then compared the adorned versus unadorned facial pictures. When they did that, what they found was that, in the condition where people were just their normal self, the normal adorned self, people who were narcissistic were seen as more attractive. In the unadorned condition, there wasn't a difference.
- 4.43 One of the suggestions there, it's just one study, is that it's not that narcissists are better-looking, it's just they try harder. They just put more effort into looks. Makes sense if that's something you care about, **self-enhancement** matters. We see this in a lot of data. One thing is just putting more effort into looks. When you look at this in terms of, let's say, a dating app or whatever, narcissists will spend more time selecting good-looking photos to put in the app. So not only do they look better, but when they get to select how they look, they'll put more effort into it.
- 4.44 My joke with my students was whenever they look at guys on dating apps, guys always have pictures holding fish. That's the joke, right? Every guy is like, guys are holding fish. I asked my class, "Why are men holding fish?" "I don't know. Why are guys holding fish?" I said, "Because that's the only time a guy wants a picture of himself." What guy is going around, like, "Take a picture of me." What kind of freak is that? You're a guy. No one cares. You catch a good trout, you shoot a buck, you want a picture. But other than that, you don't. So the guys who are out there in Dubai, doing shots like this, this shot, like the—what is that? The Bigfoot shot. Those guys are narcissistic. I mean, that's just, the normal guys aren't having their buddies take glamour shots by the pickup. That was such a weird phenomenon, but I noticed this because I went through my pictures of myself, and every picture was holding a fish, like every single one.
- 4.45 Then what I started doing after I learned to take **selfies**, because I had to train. I've started taking **selfies** now. Whenever I'm happy, I'll take a **selfie** just to remember it. Then when I'm depressed, "I remember I was happy here." OK, I'll just—anyway, so in narcissism, you just see this greater selection of photos. You look better in photos. But then there's also the personality piece, which is key. What's attractive when you first meet somebody is social confidence and energy. People like confident people. They just do. So you meet somebody, "Hey, Keith Campbell. Good to meet you." You go, "I like that Keith Campbell. He seems like a solid guy. He

shook my hand." You meet somebody like, "Hey, good to meet you." You're like, "That person seems a little weird, a little nervous. I don't know. Maybe they're OK."

- 4.46 We like confidence. We like energy, especially when you meet people. So what they've done in research to nail this out is they've done what's called **thin slices** research. You have somebody just video themselves for 30 seconds or a minute. You can do it with 30 seconds, just talking about themselves. And then have people rate them. How much you, how attractive is this person? How much would you like this person? People who are narcissists—**grandiose narcissism** is judged as more attractive in **thin slices**. So after 30 seconds, you like people who are narcissistic. If I meet somebody and I just like them right away, I'm like, "50, 50." I'm like, "50, 50." I end up with —because I'm very extraverted and I love energy and I love **extraversion**. When I get around really energetic people, I enjoy it. They're just mega ego monsters. I'm like, "But at least they're energetic about it. At least they got some ambition." "I'm going to take over the world." I'm like, "Good for you." The key is, it's attractive at first. It's not over the long term, and I'll get to that.
- 4.47 The other thing is, you see this with **grandiose narcissism**. You don't see this with **vulnerable narcissism**. People who are vulnerable aren't really that attractive at first. They seem more neurotic. This is just anecdotal, but when I hear stories of people—"I ended up with this really vulnerable narcissist relationship" —often they got into it, it was almost a caregiving vibe. Like, "Oh, the person seemed a little sad. They seemed a little neurotic. I was taking care of them. I thought I was helping them. Then it turned out they were an ego maniac under it." So it can be a little different with vulnerability.
- 4.48 Narcissists, especially grandiose, can be very attractive, especially initially, especially in their appearance and everything else. Why are they not attractive? What makes relationships with narcissists bad? Well, you find with narcissism a lot of relationship problems. One of those is something like common couple violence. So you see violent behavior and controlling behavior. They have measures of just control tactics. So not just physical abuse, but any sort of efforts to control. I talked about **gaslighting** and **game playing**, but any sort of control efforts. Controlling checkbooks, controlling money, controlling who you can have access to, what friends you can see—all those things are going to be more likely to be seen in narcissistic relationships.
- 4.49 And as I said before, I will say again, this can be very, very bad. This can be really intense efforts to control and manipulate and harm people at the extreme. That's really bad. You see infidelity, as already talked about. You see that **attention to alternatives**. You see **mate poaching**. That's what **mate poaching** is another—there's another evolutionary psych idea. Evolutionary psychologists always have these cool terms, but **mate poaching** is an interesting one where you go out and just steal mates from somebody else. It's not just dating. It's like somebody's already in a relationship that's committed, and you go, you used to call that a homewrecker. They'll just take somebody out of it. More likely, they take somebody out of an existing relationship.
- 4.50 So you date somebody who's narcissistic, and then they're hitting on your friend who's married with your best friend, and all of a sudden, you got a bunch of neighborhood drama because

you're—god, I don't want neighborhood drama. You get that. You get a lot of lying with narcissism and a lot of deception. There's been several recent studies where they've looked at key variables that predict dishonesty. Narcissism and **psychopathy** are right up at the top. There's a couple others that are a little higher. They're more game theory-type variables. But narcissism is one of the bigger predictors of deception.

- 4.51 When we talk about lying in relationships, I always like to remind people that people lie all the time, but they're white lies. "How do I look?" "You look great." "How's it going to go tonight?" "Oh, you're going to do awesome out there." Whenever I come out to speak somewhere, people are like, "You've got this, man." I'm like, "No, I don't." But that's how people talk. Now, whether I got it or not, no one's going to be like, I'm not walking out to speak here, and they're like, "Dude, you don't got this. I got to be honest, I got a real bad feeling about you going on that stage right now. Come and pray with me." It never happens. You just pump people up. That's cool.
- 4.52 That's not narcissism. Narcissism isn't pumping up people, telling them they look good. Narcissism is more, "I'm lying to manipulate you to get something I want, either to tell you something about me that's not true, so you think I'm better. I want to manipulate you to have you do something that will just get my ends met." Instrumental. You get a lot of lying and deception. You get the **gaslighting** and **game playing** I already talked about. A final thing I'll mention—this is a little more in the weeds of relationship processes—but what you get, what you don't find with people who are narcissistic is a willingness to sacrifice or accommodate when conflict comes up in the relationship, or a lower willingness to accommodate or sacrifice when conflict comes up.
- 4.53 So if you're in an ongoing relationship with somebody, what will invariably happen is you will have conflict. The way conflict often happens is somebody does something destructive to the relationship, and the other person has a choice to either make it worse or make it better. We call this **accommodation**. I come home, I fly back from this trip. My wife's been running the house for four days. I come home, and I'm like, "There's no food in the fridge." Guys, I'm not going to do that. But if I did that, she'd have a choice. She could say, "Well, there are the car keys. There's a credit card. Why don't you get the heck out of here? Go fill up the fridge." She could say that in a less-nice way, too. Or she could say, "It sounds like you're really tired from your flight. You must feel bad. Let me get you some potato chips and help you relax. We'll get that fridge filled up tomorrow." And man, that would wreck me. If she did that, I'd be like, "Oh, I feel so terrible. I'm the worst." But that would be more accommodating.
- 4.54 People who are narcissistic are more likely to show conflict in that situation. "Oh, screw you. Go fill up the fridge. You do this. I'm out of here." You're just not seeing the sacrifice. You're not seeing the **accommodation**. And again, how these things work is, if you start fighting with somebody, if I come home, "Why isn't the fridge filled?" My wife's like, "Well, you got a car. You go fill the fridge." "Well, you've been here four days while I've been making money. You should go fill the fridge." "Well, I never liked you in the first place. I should have married your brother. He's the good-looking one." "Well, I never liked you either. Your mom, my goodness, she's the

one who forced me to marry you. She tried to pay me off." Then, I'm sorry, I just going real weird there. I see my mother-in-law paying me off to marry my wife. That would be awesome. It didn't happen.

- 4.55 But that's how it spirals into nonsense. Really, with relationships, you don't want them spiraling out of control. Narcissism makes it more likely to spiral out of control. Nice people just don't do that as much. You put that together. Narcissism is interesting. It has these positive things that people like, like being good-looking and extraverted. It has these negative things, like **ghosting** and **gaslighting** and **bread crumbing**, and they all sound scary and weird. So I like narcissism, but I don't like narcissism. This is weird. What happens? Well, when you put that together, that initial attraction with long-term problems, into a model, what you end up with is a bit of a dynamic of narcissistic relationships. It makes it interesting.
- 4.56 I call this the **chocolate cake model** of relationships because I like putting—generally, I like putting very silly names for my models, so no one thinks they're real science, like mathematical models, which no one does. And it also gets the point across. So let me preface it with this. In our culture, I say our culture, US culture is Western, but this is actually becoming the global culture, is we pick our romantic partners based on attraction and passion. That's generally the model. I find somebody, I go, "Oh, I feel attracted to you. I feel **passionate love** towards you. That's who I want." That is like our ideal model of a relationship. You find somebody you fall in love with, you have a passionate romantic love.
- 4.57 And then after six months or whatever the appropriate time is, you start to get to know the person. You start to have more of a caring relationship. Instead of idealizing the person by saying they're the most beautiful woman you've ever met, you go, "Well, they're pretty beautiful, but I really love them because I know so much about them. We have this really deep emotional connection. We care about each other." So you go from **passionate love** to what we might call **companionate love**. I don't mean to make everyone depressed here or anything like, oh god, but that's just the nature of how we pick. So when we're picking people, we're picking for passion. And when we're trying to find a long-term stable relationship, we want somebody who's going to be caring and emotionally warm and considerate and hard-working and disciplined and all those things. So there's a bit of a time issue with how we select relationships.
- 4.58 Back to my **chocolate cake model**. Imagine somebody says, "Hey, I've got two choices for you for lunch. We either have this beautiful chocolate cake I just had made out of the oven with a warm chocolatey center, or you can have this lovely salad with some chicken on it." What would you rather have? You go, "Let's just see. I think I'll have that lovely chocolate cake." You eat the chocolate cake, and you take that first bite, and you're like, "Oh my god, this chocolate cake is so good." You're eating the cake and you get that sugar rush from chocolate. You get this energy and you're like, "I love chocolate. It feels so good. Chocolate cake's the best." Then you're done with the cake, go back to work. 20 minutes later, you're at your desk, you're like, "I'm a loser. I hate myself. I'm so tired right now. I need a cup of coffee. Why did I eat the cake? I always eat chocolate cake. I'm a terrible person. Why doesn't anybody help me?" That's what happens when you eat chocolate cake.

- 4.59 You eat the salad. You're like, "I ate the salad. That was OK. I feel pretty good." 20 minutes later, you're like, "Yeah, I feel pretty good about myself. I'm a healthy person. I have a good job. I like who I am. I'm going to go get and seize the day." You don't start off real great with the salad, but 20 minutes later, you're feeling good about yourself. That's the **chocolate cake model**. It's the pattern of narcissistic relationships varies along the time course of the relationship.
- 4.60 So, in an initial part of the relationship with somebody narcissistic, you have this initial attraction. It's very satisfying. You imagine you date Mr. Wrong or whatever, but you're like, "This is great. It's really fun. It's exciting." You tell your friends, "I'm dating this guy, and I think he's in finance. He's really rich." Sorry, no finance joke there. My daughter's studying finance right now. You get real excited about it. "We went out. It was really exciting. I think it's great." Then what happens is, after a few months, you're like, "OK, now where's the emotional intimacy?" We've gone out a few times. It's been fun. "Hey, maybe I should meet your parents. Maybe we should go to my family. You want to meet my niece? You want to do something?" "I don't really have time for any of that." You don't get intimacy, and what you start seeing is that negative stuff.
- 4.61 "Wait, I think this person's cheating on me. They seem to have pictures of other women on their cell phone. That's a little weird. They're lying to me about stuff. They're controlling me. They're trying to tell me how to act. They're dressing me." This is one of my favorites. "They're picking out my clothes so I look good, because they want me to look good for them." You see all this bad stuff happen, and then you go, "What did I do wrong? How did I screw this perfectly good relationship up? This person was so attractive, and now they're a jerk. Maybe I need to be a better person." This is where you start getting messed up. You get the head games because you're talking to the person like, "I haven't done anything. I'm fine. You're the crazy one." So you start getting self-blame, start getting that inner turbulence. Then the relationship falls apart. Either the person bails or you go, "Finally, I've had enough," or something bad happens.
- 4.62 Then after all the relationship is done, you spend the next two years thinking about it because you're like, "What did I do wrong? Why was I so stupid? I fell for that narcissistic character." Well, I'll tell you why, because he was hot and he was pretty charming. That's why. It's not a mystery. But when you look at how horrible somebody is, you go, "How was I ever in that relationship?" Well, in psychology, we call it the **foot in the door**. They got in, they started getting in and creeping in and getting more and more power over time, and you wanted to make the relationship work, and pretty soon you found yourself in a very toxic place.
- 4.63 So that's the idea of this **chocolate cake model**, is that narcissistic relationships aren't unattractive. The problem is they're very attractive, but only initially. And so if you find yourself like, "Why am I getting into these relationships?", I'd say, "Why do I keep eating chocolate cake?" "I don't know. Because it's really freaking tasty. I know what the consequences are. I might have some tonight for dessert. It might be really good." That's the challenge. To try to get a handle on this, I wanted to just talk through a little bit of data. These are some just old **self-report** data we got from people that were in relationships, past relationships with people who are narcissistic and people who are less narcissistic, just to compare some of these things.

- 4.64 Imagine you ask people, "What attracted you to this partner?" What people will say is, "What attracted me to the narcissistic partner was they seemed ambitious and they seemed high in status. They were charming." So they were charming, likable, at that very initial state. Sexual attraction, so these people are good-looking and attractive, and they have social confidence. Those are what people list as the big attractors, are these things. Ambition, sexual attraction, confidence. What they'd find attractive about the non-narcissist, or the less narcissistic people, is they had a lot in common, so similarity, which is really important in relationships, and the person was a nice guy, seemed nice. That was kind of the attraction difference.
- 4.65 I hear—and this is just talking to students—you hear guys going, "Women don't like nice guys." I say, "Well, really? You think they don't like nice guys? Or are you saying that you're not ambitious, you're not status-seeking, and you're just what we used to call a loser, but I can't say anymore?" I said, "If you're really nice, does that mean you're down at church volunteering every Sunday? Do you work at a shelter helping cats? Do you clean up the streets? Are you well known around town as a holder of moral virtue? No. You're not really nice. You're not really a nice person, and you're weak. That's why no one likes you." I shouldn't have said it out loud. But that's what it is.
- 4.66 What happens is, people go, "People don't like nice people." It's like, "No, people love nice people. People just like people who are ambitious. If your niceness was wrapped in ambition, if your goal was to heal world hunger, stop hunger in Paraguay or something, I bet people would be real attracted to you. But if your being nice means 'I'm not going to do anything,' that's not appealing." Sorry, that was a little bit of a tangent there. But that's why people are attracted to narcissism. It's confidence and status. It's not the mean stuff. It's people, I'm not attracted to you because you're mean. I'm attracted to you because you're confident. And secretly, not secretly, I really hope you're nice. I really hope I find out in six months, you're a nice, caring, deeply compassionate person. That's what I want.
- 4.67 So then you ask people, "What's the worst part of the relationship?" And you find that the relationships with the narcissistic individuals were much worse. They were described as self-centered, which is not good for a relationship. **Game playing**, which we've talked about, not good for a relationship. Deceptive and dishonest, so lying, not good for a relationship. Controlling. Nobody likes being controlled unless you've got **dependent personality disorder**. But generally, no one likes to be controlled.
- 4.68 People felt like a **trophy**. That's an interesting one because, often when you feel like a **trophy** at first, it can feel good. I remember when my wife was consulting back, this is '90s stuff, and I was at a big party in Atlanta with a bunch of these consultants. I'm just the arm candy. I walk in, my wife goes, "Oh, here's my husband. He's a professor." The woman she introduced me to goes, "Oh, I want one of those." I started laughing. My **self-esteem** had never been higher. I was like, "Oh my god, I'm being treated like a **trophy**. This is so embarrassing, but it feels so good." It was so weird. Anyway, I'm just sharing that with you, that it can feel good, but if that happens over and over and over again, and every time your wife introduces you, it's like, "Here's my

professor," you're like, "Wait, I'm a person, too. I have a name." Then it's not so fun. So sometimes these things can be fun, but then they're not so fun after a while.

- 4.69 And then the final thing they talked about was materialism. The narcissistic individual seemed more materialistic. I think part of this is just caring about the material appearance of things. Just being shallow and materialistic is an issue. And then if you ask people, "Do you regret ending a relationship with somebody narcissistic?" Very rarely does that happen. Very rarely do people regret it. "Do you regret ending a relationship with somebody who is nice, not a narcissist?" That's more common. So what happens, in general, the pattern I see is, people get in relationships with somebody really narcissistic. They think about it a long time. It causes a lot of mental disturbance, for obvious reasons. We've discussed a lot of confusion. And so it becomes a very weighty relationship in life. But people don't regret it ending, typically. "I'm glad it ended. I'm just confused how I was dumb enough to get in this and how I can avoid this in the future." Was there somebody nice? Like, "Man, I was into my job. I thought I could do something better, but he was a pretty good dude, or she was really cool, and I blew that one." That's a little different. A little different feeling we have.
- 4.70 The other way you can think about this is you can have people graph feelings over the time course of a relationship. We've had people literally just take a piece of paper and just graph how you felt satisfied or excited or emotional intimacy. And that's pretty cool, too. So when you do that, what you see is this very interesting pattern. When you ask people how satisfied they are with their partner, and this is compared to a narcissistic partner versus, say, a non-narcissistic partner. I wish there's a better word for that. Normal. That's even weird. So what happens at the first stage of the relationship, what you find is the narcissist is the satisfying partner. It's more satisfying at the beginning to be dating somebody narcissistic, on average, than somebody less narcissistic.
- 4.71 At that first stage, the first six weeks, somewhere in there, first few months, you find this satisfaction advantage for narcissism, and then it switches. So you start off more satisfying, and then it switches, just like chocolate cake, more satisfying at first, then it switches where the salad is more satisfying. And then, excitement, you see a similar pattern, but even more so. So, dating narcissists, it's exciting. In general, it's more exciting, and it's exciting for a long time, until it's no longer exciting, it's horrible. So it's generally, people who are narcissistic would just be more exciting to date, more satisfying at first, more exciting for a long period of time. But where you see the real difference is in emotional intimacy. You never get the emotional intimacy with the narcissistic partner.
- 4.72 When you track the course of relationships, over time, with the narcissist, the emotional intimacy goes up a little bit, and then it just falls apart when you realize you don't really know the person. Meet somebody non-narcissistic, the intimacy starts a little higher, but then it gets real high. You go meet somebody's parents, you meet their family, you really get to know somebody, you get a lot of closeness. Then maybe you drift apart, but it's never as bad. Basically, what you're swapping, "Hey, I want to date somebody narcissistic." Well, what you're getting is excitement and maybe some short-term ego needs and some fun. What you're losing

is emotional intimacy and deep connection. That's your trade-off you're making. That was good. That was **chocolate cake model**.

- 4.73 What I thought I'd just end on here, we've covered the process of how this can work in general and in romantic relationships. I wanted to just end, taking a little bit of a broader view of narcissism and narcissists and how they approach relationships. I used to call this the **extended agency model**. I need a better name, like the super **chocolate cake model** or something. The Willy Wonka model. Anyway, stop. No, we don't need a name for a model. Just give you an idea. Here's how I sometimes see this. People, your grandiose narcissists. You want to get esteem. You look out at your social world, you see a bunch of people. Every person you view is a potential source of esteem.
- 4.74 I sometimes use a bit of an energy model for this. I almost see as people as firewood. "Hey, look at all that dry firewood out there. I need to start building some **self-esteem** inside. How do I go collect it?" And so what you'll see is, "Hey, I'm going to go find a good-looking partner, and that's going to help my **self-esteem**. I'm going to find some nice people to work for me that are going to suck up to me, and that's going to help my **self-esteem**. I'm going to manipulate my mom into buying me a Mercedes, and that's going to help my **self-esteem**." I don't know why mom's doing that. "I'm going to do all these different things. What I'm doing is, I'm going out to the world, I'm bringing people in, I'm chewing them, I'm burning them up." Let's keep with this burning metaphor.
- 4.75 "Burning them up as fuel for my **self-esteem**. Then when I'm done with them, I'm kicking them to the curb. I'm just kicking them out. Bringing in my trophies partner. I'm like—"I forget the actor—"I start dating the 22-year-old. As soon as she hits 25, I'm like, yeah, you're too old for me. I got to go film another movie with a bear. You're out of here." Whatever. You're basically just using people for fuel to go through your life. It's a very exploitative, it's a very destructive, shallow way to live. It's very predatory, it's very shark-like. I don't think it's ultimately fulfilling in the same way I don't think doing cocaine every day would be ultimately fulfilling. You'd get a good little rush every morning, but over time, you'd get emptier and emptier and emptier.
- 4.76 Then you get to the place where you go, "Wait a second. Nobody actually loves me. Nobody knows who I am. All I'm doing is filling myself up with people. As I get older and older, no one wants to be around me, so it's harder and harder to get people." It's not a good way to go. You end up isolated, alone, not well loved, maybe hated by a lot of people. Maybe people learn to forgive you, and they make their peace with you at your grave, but it's just not a pleasant way to go. That sounds like a good place to end. Big smiles, everybody. That's it for narcissistic relationships.
- 4.77 My question is, let's say a female has been married to a narcissist. She did all the initial attraction and all that, but she found out maybe a decade or two where she was. There's children involved. And because he is manipulating, he's **gaslighting**, he's controlling, he could be violent. Do you have any thoughts on how this can be a win-win situation, where he can continue with his life with his choices, but the female and her children are protected?

- 4.78 I was going to, at the last session, I wanted to talk about dealing with narcissism across these areas. So I'm going to hit these points again, I hope. What you're talking about is a very common and challenging situation where you're in a relationship with a very high level of investments, meaning you're in a relationship with a husband, you have shared kids, you have a shared family. You probably have a shared bank account, so there's financial ties. Probably all your friendship networks are connected. When you're in a situation like that, it gets very, very challenging to get out of it. What you're asking is, what do you do in a situation where you have to give up so much in order to get free if somebody's narcissistic?
- 4.79 I'm not going to tell anybody what to do in that situation because it's a personal—it's a really hard choice. What I suggest is, first thing is protection. You get a good family attorney; at least you have someone to talk to. Get a good network of friends to keep yourself grounded. Make sure your kids are protected. Hopefully, what's going on is the guy is just getting some status from the kids because they're good at baseball and that's enough and that works. Then your kids are fine, but that's something to check into. This depends on if there's violence and stuff, maybe you just get out and get police. But if you're talking just within that range, where it doesn't—it's not at that point.
- 4.80 The other thing to consider is setting down pretty firm boundaries about what you would want from the husband to be a good husband that seem pretty doable and get rewarded. "You know what's really great is if you take the kids to soccer practice, and everyone will see you, and we'll put a post on Instagram, and everyone will think you're a good dad." "Oh, I could do that." So setting up reward systems that reinforce communal behavior, that align it with ego. So you do this stuff that makes you a good husband, and guess what? People will give you a pat on the back for it. People will applaud you for it. This is all really complicated, and it's a really hard situation. I can't—is that enough of an answer? I can keep going. But really, it's protect yourself, find resources, good legal team.
- 4.81 Because I've heard such horror stories. I've heard of stories, for example, of narcissistic husbands trying to get a divorce. What they'll do is they'll go get their wife to hit them. You're like, "How do you get some wife to hit you?" It's pretty easy. Just go pester her enough, and then she throws something at you, and then you call the police, and you say, "There's a domestic assault at my house. You got to arrest somebody. My wife did it." I've heard this story several times. I wouldn't say it if it wasn't just once. Some real manipulative and dark, bad stuff can happen, so be smart, and get a good family attorney. There's some narcissistic coaches out there. It's just starting. Yeah, I've talked to some people. So somebody like that, if you can find somebody.
- 4.82 With regard to what men and women seek in relationships, if they're narcissistic, are those the same across the board?
- 4.83 So the question is, are men and women who are narcissistic seeking the same thing? Is that your question? The answer is yes and no. I think at the broader level, what you're seeking is **self-enhancement**, to feel good and to look good and to have status. When it comes to romantic

relationships, there can be a gender difference or sex difference. Men can gain status, especially in the eyes of other men, by having a number of sexual partners. So if my buddies were like, "Yeah, I slept with 10 people this weekend," their buddies would be like, "Nice." Women don't have that same status thing. You don't get status from other women by sleeping around. I think that there'd be a pretty significant difference in short-term mating.

- 4.84 That's not always the case. I remember the old show, Sex and the City. They had a very narcissistic female, I think Samantha. Forget her name, but one of the leads was very narcissistic, had lots of affairs, and had a very male presentation. I don't want to say it's totally gendered in any way. But just that, I think, is the one place where you see a difference is, dating a lot would be more valuable to male than female for gaining self-esteem.
- 4.85 Do you feel that where society is at right now predicates a lot of how many narcissists are around?
- 4.86 Yes. I think a society that emphasizes individual choice and self-promotion and individual marketing and branding of yourself is going to encourage narcissism. I think when you're dating based on pictures on an app that people select, like buying stuff on Amazon.com, that's going to make you a little more shallow and materialistic and instrumental in how you view things than if you were meeting human beings in person at an organizational function with people you cared about. Yeah, I think we're being pushed in a very shallow direction. Yeah.

5. Narcissism at Work

AT A GLANCE

Moves to the workplace and leadership, where narcissism has bright and dark sides. Narcissistic employees show counterproductive work behaviors, few organizational citizenship behaviors, the self-serving bias, and entitlement that nonetheless earns raises, yet they interview well, take risks, and gravitate toward status careers. Narcissistic leaders bring confidence, risk-taking, entrepreneurship, and public performance, but overconfidence, expensive acquisitions, poor ethics, and the tragedy of the commons; benefits come early and costs later, the leader usually still wins. Reviews presidential narcissism, partisan perceptions of Trump, the energy clash model of perturbation, conflict, and resolution, and contrasts dominance with prestige leadership through Patton, Bradley, Washington, and Henry V.

- 5.1 All right. In this session, we're going to move from talking about romantic relationships and family relationships to the workplace. Narcissism in the workplace or organizations or even political leadership, which I'll talk about, is interesting in a different way than relationships. In the world of work, in the world of politics, in the world of leadership, it's pretty clear that there's a bright and a **dark side** of narcissism. If you go back to some of the early writings by, say, **Bob Hogan**, the great psychologist, in industrial and organizational psychology and leadership, they talk about narcissism as being both a benefit and a cost for leadership. They talk about two different faces.
- 5.2 Often, they talk about the **bright side** of narcissism is what you see when you're not under stress, when you first meet somebody, and the **dark side** is what you see later on or when you're under stress. It's the worst presentation. It's really narcissism in this organizational world is very interesting because of the complexity of it and because sometimes we want it. Even if we don't think we want it, sometimes we want it. I just want to start off with that, and that's going to be a theme that runs through it.
- 5.3 In the relationship world, generally, my daughter brings home somebody, like, this person's narcissistic. I'm like, "Get him out of here." Leader, I'm like, "Well, maybe we need this person for a little while." It just depends. That's the complicated part. Today, what I want to talk about, given that framework, is I'm going to talk a little bit about narcissism in organizations, starting with career preference, what narcissists are looking for in organizations. I'm going to talk a little bit about some of the challenges at the workplace that you see with narcissism. Then I'm going to do some leadership stuff. The narcissism leadership area is a really big and interesting area. I'll do some more organizational leadership. Then I'm going to talk about political leadership, some **chocolate cake model** things, and then try to talk about something a little more positive at the end. We'll see if I can do that, but I always try to be there.
- 5.4 Narcissism in organization, again, has these bright and dark sides. When you look at somebody narcissistic as an employee, as somebody working for you, as somebody you're working with,

like a fellow coworker, you see some pretty basic challenges in the workplace. The people who do this work are what we call industrial organizational psychologists. They might be organizational researchers in a business school. That's typically who's looking at these organizations. They're interested in a couple of things that make good employees.

- 5.5 One thing that's a problem in relationships are what's called **counterproductive work behaviors**. There's a whole literature on things people do wrong at work. So **counterproductive work behaviors**, also called CWBs. What are these things? These are stealing the Post-It notes and taking them home. These are stealing money from the office and committing fraud. These are cooking the books so your bonus gets bigger at the end of the quarter. These are sexually harassing the staff and making everyone else's life at work kind of hell. There are lots of counterproductive behaviors people do at work. Everyone here has probably been in a workplace and probably dealt with some of this.
- 5.6 Generally, what you see is that's predicted by narcissism. It's not the only thing that predicts it, but generally, people who are narcissistic show more of these counterproductive behaviors. Where you see these exacerbated is when people who are narcissistic feel they're not being treated fairly. The classic model of a narcissistic counterproductive work behavior is, "I'm at work, the boss doesn't respect me, I haven't got a raise in a while. No one's looking out for me. I'm going to set the record straight. I'm going to put the scales of justice back into balance by taking home 42 reams of paper, and I'm going to use them on my printer."
- 5.7 If you're in business school, one of the classic movies is a movie called Office Space, which was a movie about dysfunctional workplace with some great consultants. One of the figures in the movie, not necessarily narcissistic, but he ends up just burning down everything at the end. It's one person steals a bunch of money, another person burns down everything, just trying to get back at the boss. That's a classic model of counterproductive workplace behaviors.
- 5.8 The other thing you see at workplaces that are the opposite of this that are really important are called **organizational citizenship behaviors**. Imagine you're working at Chuck's Auto Barn with your 24 coworkers, and everyone knows October 15th is Susie's birthday, and Susie loves her birthday, and somebody's got to go decorate for Susie's birthday and get cupcakes. Well, that's not in anybody's job description. You didn't get hired to Chuck's Auto Barn, and they said, "Oh, you're in charge of Susie's birthday." That's not a job, but somebody's got to do it. That's called an **organizational citizenship behavior**. It's like just doing stuff to make the company work. It's setting up the softball league. It's remembering Susie's birthday. It's just doing nice things that aren't necessarily scripted but have to be done.
- 5.9 This is another area where you don't really see narcissism working. People who are narcissistic aren't doing these citizenship behaviors. Other people are carrying the weight. Here's what happens at your organization. Half the people are pissed off. They're like, "I'm doing all this stuff. I'm doing the birthday parties. I'm being nice to people. Keith doesn't even show up. He works from home half the time. He's sick." Then you talk to Keith, and Keith's the narcissist in this example. Keith goes, "Well, I'm getting my job done. It didn't say I have to do a birthday party.

Why are you doing that? It seems like a waste of your time." That's the issue. Those **organizational citizenship behaviors** that are really important or something that aren't really being picked up by the narcissistic workers. This is why you want nice workers or more conscientious workers.

- 5.10** Another thing you see that really damages team coherence and performance at the workplace is the **self-serving bias**. We talked about this a little bit. Essentially, **self-serving bias** is taking credit for success and blaming external factors or other people for failure. If I'm at work and I do a good job, "Hey, Keith, how come you did a good job?" "Because I'm awesome." That's taking credit for success. "Hey, Keith, you failed. You didn't meet the numbers this month." "Well, that's Susie again. She was just phoning it in. I think she's too busy with her birthday to work hard." So I throw Susie under the bus. That's the **self-serving bias**. It protects my ego. It protects my esteem at the cost of Susie.
- 5.11** When people start operating in an organization where they're pointing the fingers at everybody else for failure and hogging credit for success, that organization will collapse. They will collapse because Susie is going to knife me in the back for throwing her under the bus. I'm using a lot of metaphors there. Threw her under the bus, jumped over the bus, and she jumps and knifes me in the back. The system is going to break down. It's very hard in a team for people that are hogging credit. It's like in sports, when you had a kid that was a ball hog. It's just ball hogs aren't fun and they wreck things for everybody else. We only put up with ball hogs if they're really, really, really talented. If somebody's not that talented, we're not putting up with it. Most of the time, the super narcissists we deal with are not that talented.
- 5.12** Quick tangent, the problem, the calls I get with the narcissists, we have somebody on the team that it's very hard to replace because they're a "rainmaker." They're bringing in a lot of money and we can't get rid of them, but we really, really want to. What do we do? Or else they get rid of you. That **self-serving bias** is a really toxic thing for workplaces. The final thing that's an issue, but it's another one of these double-edged swords, is a **sense of entitlement**. People come into the workplace, they go, "I deserve more. I'm not being paid enough, I'm not being treated well enough, I'm not being respected enough." Sometimes you're not, by the way. It's not always that way. What happens with that **sense of entitlement** is interesting. One is, no one likes to work with people who are entitled. No one wants a staff member who's got a **sense of entitlement**.
- 5.13** But people who are entitled get paid more. The reason they get paid more is because they're entitled and they go to the boss and say, "I want more money, and if I don't want more money, I'm leaving because I don't have any loyalty anyway." You have this unfortunate situation where this narcissistic **entitlement**, which they'll bring to the workplace and is very toxic and not fun to work with, and it's no fun to work with people that are always saying negative stuff all the time, they actually get rewarded for that on average. I mean, on average, you throw people out, too. But that **sense of entitlement**, it can help you win at times, too.

- 5.14 Just like romantic relationships, narcissists in the workplace have some issues, not the best issues you want. The question then is, well, why do you hire somebody who's narcissistic? What are the bright sides of narcissism, as opposed to the dark sides that make these people hireable? Well, one of the first things that makes people hireable who are more grandiose is their interview skills. It's just like dating. That **extraversion**, that sense of confidence, it works really well in interviews. Same way in the thin-slices of behavior, you like people when you meet them first. Somebody walks in for an interview, and they're narcissistic. You go, "That person seems like they know what they're doing. They seem like they can hit the ground running. They don't seem afraid of challenges. They seem like a perfect hire." This other person seems a little nervous.
- 5.15 One of the things that happens in the workplace is whenever you get promoted, there's a risk of what's called **imposter syndrome**, or imposter phenomenon, where you go, "Oh, my goodness, they made me the boss. Who would make me boss? I'm nervous," and it takes a little while to adapt. You go, I'm boss, and then after six weeks of doing it, you start feeling like you're the boss, and pretty soon you become comfortable. But it's very normal in life to feel, whenever you move through a social system, to feel like a phony. Some of that's just lack of confidence. Some of that's just low **self-esteem**. Some of that's just normal. I feel it all the time.
- 5.16 You don't really see that with narcissism. You're the boss. "Well, I should be the boss. I don't feel like an imposter. I feel like I don't have enough. I feel like I should have more." That can be really appealing when you're interviewing somebody because they seem so confident, and that looks like what you'd want in somebody. The interview skills are really good. Another thing that people really like is **boldness** and risk-taking. You want somebody who's willing to take a risk. People who are narcissistic, generally in leadership, are more willing to take risks. If you have a workplace where you're in maybe a very dynamic industry where people have to start breaking things. This is the tech industry, move fast and break things. If you want an industry like that and you need somebody like, "Hey, I'm willing to go do that," you're going to pull for somebody who's narcissistic.
- 5.17 Other people can take risk, too, but narcissism, you're going to pull for it. When you do this, the way around this is typically like, "Hey, I'm interviewing these people and I'm missing their narcissism because I like them too much." What do you do? Well, what you should do is you should do **structured interviews** with people. When you bring people in to hire, you should have these very formalized, structured interview processes. Truth is, even these sometimes will select for people who are narcissistic. I've done research with actual executive testing centers, and they're like, "Yeah, we're even selecting some narcissism, too, because we want confidence, and we want people who are willing to lead." That can be a challenge to find people who are narcissistic.
- 5.18 Then overall, I think when people are looking for these more narcissistic profiles, they're looking for job positions that demand confidence. They might be looking for people in leadership, and I'll talk more about leadership. They might be looking for people in more competitive industries. If you want people who are competitive, often people who are narcissistic are who you want

because the competition is kind of fun, the fighting. Sales, there's an idea that, hey, in sales, we need narcissism. That's not necessarily the case. It's a short-term versus long-term thing, where long-term sales relationships, more like relationship-based sales, narcissists are going to be a problem. Short-term sales, like hustling credit cards at the airport or whatever, I'd probably vote for some narcissism for that. But if you have a long-term sales relationship, I think the narcissism would probably help. But sales is a place where people talk a lot about narcissism, and I don't think it's as good as people would think.

- 5.19 If you ask people who are narcissistic or measure them, what they're looking for in a career, what are they interested in, what you see are a selection of careers that are targeted towards more status and more prominence and more success. Most people who are narcissistic, when they're looking for a job, they're like, "I want a job that's going to give me some ego boost or some ego needs." There was a recent study where they just did huge sampling, and things you see with narcissism are careers in performing arts. The performing arts are interesting. You get a lot of openness with that and impulsivity, too. But some performing arts, I'll talk about some in a second.
- 5.20 Leadership is a big one. Leadership jobs, finance jobs, high numbers, high money, engineering a little bit. Sales, I just talked about. Law, business law, just the professions are like—accounting, not so much. You don't see a narcissist going for accounting, but law would be one that would be more popular. Consulting, the classic consulting job, a little more narcissistic. I know people in every one of these professions. This isn't like some slam. It's just where you're seeing the energy going. You're a kid going through college, you got a bit of an ego, you're like, "I'm going to work for McKinsey, I'm going to work for a big consulting firm." That's not bad. That's just, it would be a natural thing to do.
- 5.21 Where you're not seeing narcissism so much is the helping professions. You're not saying, "You know what? I really want to go into education. I really want to go into"—like, if I compare the psychology students to the business students, business students can be more narcissistic on average, by a couple of points. I love the business students. They're just going to be a little different. If you look at physicians, people going into medicine, it's going to be a difference between fields. People who are narcissistic are going to be drawn to surgery or more high-value specialties where they get more status. People who are less narcissistic, drawn to general practice, internal medicine or other things that are maybe family medicine, more communal.
- 5.22 That's kind of your vet. Veterinarians are not going to be super narcissistic. I was just hanging with my vet this week talking about this. It's incredibly hard to be a vet. I think it's harder to get in than med school. But most vets, and they don't get paid really well. It's like an act of love. A lot of vets are pretty low in narcissism, very talented, very high-skilled professionals. It depends on the field. There was a study on actors in reality television. I'll talk about it a little bit more, but you see in terms of just the media that the narcissism is going to reality TV versus some other areas.

- 5.23 You see it in this one great study out of Canada, they looked at narcissism in pastors or priests or whatever, religious leaders. I don't know the right term. I think they used pastors in there. They found that the people who are narcissistic just had bigger flocks, bigger congregations. In terms of the religious world, where you're going to see narcissism is driving to more social status and power. That's the idea. You're just moving into a system and you're like, "Where can I get social status, power, positive attention?" That kind of thing. That's where you're going to see narcissism go, even if it's something, even if it's something like being a priest, that you think, well, that's a helping profession. I'm like, "Dude, I'm running a —"
- 5.24 Oh, gosh. I used to go to this megachurch with my family in California. This is why I think about this stuff. It was so awesome. I grew up going to a church that was just like a church. But this one, you roll in, and it's like Disneyland, where they have a huge thing with the church. They got a band, and then they've got a coffee shop. But if you don't want to go to the church, you can just watch it in the coffee shop. Then they have a traditional church. Then they had a skate park. Then they had a basketball court. Then they had this big lawn with balls on it for people to just throw balls if they want. My kids would call it, my nieces and nephews would call it Disneyland. That was the church. That, to me, seemed like a narcissistic church. I'm not saying that it was, it wasn't. But if I'm going there to listen to rock music and drink coffee, I'm like, this isn't—they're pulling for something here. I loved it. They're just pulling for something different. Not the same as a traditional Catholic ceremony in Ireland. It has a little different feel to it, a little SoCal vibe. I think that's the difference. You're pulling for a little more ego and how people come through.
- 5.25 There's been some interesting research on leadership and narcissism. Like I said, this area of narcissism and leadership is the big area, because people who are narcissistic seek leadership. They tend to be good at getting leadership, and once they have leadership, they have lots of power because your power is amplified when you're a leader. They've done work to try to identify narcissistic leaders, which is fun. I thought I'd talk about that for a second before going into the leadership idea. What's hard is, you can't go to a bunch of CEOs and get them to take questionnaires. I've tried it before. Sometimes you can, but it's really hard to do. What they've done is try to build these models that may or may not work, which are fun. But here's the type of thing they talk about with narcissistic leaders. It used to be like CEOs, business leaders.
- 5.26 Provocative clothing and attention to appearance, same as dating. So outfits of narcissistic leaders. You see this response to **ego threat**, the going off the handle sometimes when they're not really being controlled. You hear this with a lot of political leaders where you won't see it, but you'll hear like, oh, the staff said they used to lose their mind all the time, have these rage-outs and things. But you'll often not see that. You'll hear that from people. You'll see these jumping at opportunities to **self-enhance**. There always used to be jokes about somebody and not to be—I think the last one I heard was Chuck Schumer, but it could be any political leader of any party. I'm not a party guy, but they would make a joke and say, "The most dangerous place in Washington, DC, is between Chuck Schumer and a camera." That would be the joke. It didn't have to be Chuck Schumer. It could be anybody. I don't care. Mitch McConnell. Actually, he's not moving very fast, so maybe not. See, I got both sides. It was funny.

- 5.27 But the idea was that there's such an opportunity for enhancement at that camera that that guy's going to be rushing there so fast, he's going to trample you to get there. You'll see that **self-enhancement** in really narcissistic leaders. You don't see that in all leaders. A lot of leaders don't want to do any of that stuff. They just want to run a business. They just say, "Oh, I got to go do the marketing stuff." Other leaders love it.
- 5.28 You're going to see the typical relationship problems that we just talked about with relationships. With the narcissistic leaders, whatever, you're going to see infidelity, and you're going to see a history of personal wreckage. You're going to see their life is just—there's going to be a trail of disaster behind them. That's just how it works. You just do damage to people, and you'll see a trail of disaster. There's been a lot of interesting work where they look at things like corporate reports, and they look at the size of the CEO's picture and the signature of the CEO. I really don't know how well this works because I don't do corporate reports, but they've analyzed those things. The argument people have made in the business schools are that narcissistic CEOs have bigger, more dramatic signatures. Again, I'm not 100%. Bigger pictures in their corporate reports. This is not as common now that we do stuff online, but I thought that was interesting.
- 5.29 The other thing you notice is they get some cool nicknames. Back in the corporate raider days, where we had these big executives that were going to companies, chop, get rid of all the people, and then start making the assets work, they have names like—**Jack Welch**, who was head of GE, who was a very famous CEO for a while. His nickname was **Neutron Jack Welch** because **Neutron Jack** would kill all the people but leave the material standing. I mean, that's so horrible. But that was a good thing. Like, yeah, they call me **Neutron Jack** because I fired everybody from work. There's another corporate raider, **Al Dunlap**, who was famous for going through different companies and taking them over and retooling them, rebuilding them. His nickname was **Chainsaw Al Dunlap**. **Chainsaw Al** would go through, just go through a company with chainsaws.
- 5.30 There's an interview I read with him where they describe him as being at a desk just surrounded by predators. It's like a lion behind him, panthers, cougars, crocodiles, whatever. It's this very predatory leadership thing. But as a leader, you'd say that's my brand. I can get away with that because that's what I'm supposed to be doing. Another example that wasn't quite as predatory, but it was interesting, was **Elizabeth Holmes** at Theranos. I don't know if you remember this. They had this magic blood test that you could detect. She would dress as **Steve Jobs**, always wear a turtleneck. She lowered her voice. If you watch different interviews, she started talking with a really deep voice and wearing a turtleneck. It was just a branding thing. That was a really neat example of somebody coming up with a really good personal brand for leadership that turned out to be somewhat fraudulent. I hate to call anybody a fraud if I haven't looked at the data, but that one looked a little sketchy.
- 5.31 These narcissistic leaders are often —you can see them, but often we really like them when they're doing well, because we cheer for them when they're doing well and when they do poorly, we go, "Man, we called that guy **Neutron Jack**. I thought he was a good guy. What happened? How could I be so misled?" Well, his name was **Neutron Jack**. It gets really

interesting identifying this stuff. In terms of the narcissism in leadership and the big picture here, narcissism, again, is really a trade-off for leadership. It's a mixed blessing. It's a **double-edged sword**. It's bright and **dark side**. We use all these metaphors to show there's this complexity with narcissism in leadership.

- 5.32 What you tend to find is that the benefits and costs are spread unevenly through the process or cycle of leadership, like they are in relationships. The benefits of narcissism, you often see early on in the relationship process, and you often see, what you often see in the risk-taking, sometimes you see greatness with risk-taking, which I'll talk about. The negative sides with narcissism are usually self-centered, lack of ethics, stealing stuff, hurting people, doing what they want, breaking the rules, that kind of thing.
- 5.33 The final thing I'll mention, and I'll come back to, is that because narcissism is a trade-off, sometimes we want it. Whenever you go, "Why was that narcissistic person hired to run the company?" Because somebody thought that was a good idea. Somebody very smart and well-paid thought it would be a good idea to take this self-absorbed maniac and put them in charge of all these lives. People will do this on purpose, and I'll explain why in a second. In terms of the **double-edged sword** of narcissism, you can think about a list of benefits and costs. I'll go through some of those, and then I'll talk about how they spill out over time. They're interesting.
- 5.34 One of the big benefits of narcissism is confidence. Just I'm willing to do the job. I'm willing to do it. One of the big costs of narcissism is overconfidence, not learning from mistakes, not asking for help, thinking I can do things I have no experience at doing. When you hear people doing entrepreneurship, sometimes what happens is they do something they can't do and they succeed, and everyone goes, "You're a hero." Sometimes they do something they can't do and it's a disaster and you go, "You're a fraud." It often, our judgment depends on the outcome. If Elizabeth, whatever, if Theranos had actually made the magic blood measurement thing, we would call her a hero. She would be in business books right now because she pulled it off. It's complicated. It often depends on if you pull it off or not.
- 5.35 Same thing with risk-taking. People who are narcissistic are more willing to take risks. They're just willing to take these big public risks. The problem with that is this expensive risk-taking. There's been some cool studies on this in business schools. One study looked at a bunch of tech CEOs and looked at how they managed once they became CEOs. And they found that the more narcissistic CEOs would make big public acquisitions, meaning I'm CEO of a company, I will go buy another company and make and do this in public. What it looks like what was going on, where you get a narcissistic leader, they have to do something. They do something big and splashy.
- 5.36 "Hey, we're going to go merge with—we're going to go merge with Kodak. It's time to bring back film. We're going to bring back manual cameras." Everyone goes, oh my goodness. They write about it in the press, and you get written up in the Wall Street Journal, and you're a big deal. Sometimes that works, and sometimes it fails. You just take a risk, and it works or it fails. What you see with these narcissistic CEOs is this very expensive risk-taking. Sometimes it works, and

we think they're the greatest leader ever, and sometimes it fails, and they get fired. Sometimes in weird cases, they get fired and rehired. Somebody like **Steve Jobs**, they're like, "We got to get rid of this guy and bring in the Pepsi guy." Then the company goes, and they go, "Why did we hire a Pepsi guy to run Apple?" They bring back **Steve Jobs**. So it's sometimes they throw them out and they bring them back. It just gets complicated. That expensive risk-taking is something you notice.

- 5.37** Entrepreneurship is an interesting one. Entrepreneurship, basically starting new companies, starting new organizations, is predicted by narcissism. Why is that? Well, because you're willing to take risks and you have overconfidence, and you're especially willing to take risks with other people's money. So part of entrepreneurship is, "Hey, I'm going to go get a bunch of money from people, and I'm going to go make a business risk, and if it works, we're all going to win. And if we fail, my friends who gave me the money are going to lose, and I'll lose a little bit." Narcissists are good at entrepreneurship, but when you look at the entrepreneurship literature, which is really interesting, they just did a huge study out of Silicon Valley. They found that the people who were better able to get money were actually nicer people. So it kind of didn't work.
- 5.38** The narcissists were confident and good at starting companies, but it was easier for friendly people to get money from people, which I thought was cool. I mean, it's a little bit of a **double-edged sword**. The nice people could go get money because if you have someone you like, you're more likely to give them money than some self-important superstar. But generally, narcissism is something you'd say is pretty good for entrepreneurship or at least helpful for an entrepreneurship. The problems that come with that are failing and it's not learning from mistakes, especially if you're grabbing other people's money and basically you're risking other people's downside for your upside. So that's something narcissists can do that can be a problem.
- 5.39** In terms, what else we got? The other benefits, and this is a big one, is public performance and charisma. So if your job is to be a CEO or a corporate leader, or you're running a nonprofit in your small town, whatever the case is, you're going to have to go out in public sometimes. If you're in a small town, you're going to have to go in front of the city council and say why you need to help my homeless shelter. If you're a CEO of a company, you're going to have to go on CNBC and do some pitch about why your company is a good investment. You have to do a lot of this basic performance. And so narcissistic leaders are good at this. It's performance. That performance aspect of leadership is good. If you're not really narcissistic, it's hard to do. You end up getting trainers for this. You end up getting media coaches or whatever because you have to learn how to do it, but it's hard to do.
- 5.40** So that part of the job—I think of university presidents. A lot of your job is just going out there and promotion and fundraising. That's an ego job. That's not management. That's just glad handing. Narcissism is good for that. Then the other downsides are really the ethics. It's just self-serving behavior, self-serving decision-making, poor ethical behavior. "I'm going to run this organization in the interest of me and maybe other people, but me first." You'll see people run an organization into the ground, but it turns out they got paid off somewhere along the way. You'll see this story a hundred times, where everything went down, but there was a bunch of

payoff checks, and the person who ran it into the ground got paid off. It's putting your own interests before other people and poor ethics.

- 5.41 That's the setup you get. You get the good things with narcissism and the bad things with narcissism. Then what makes this work in more of a dynamic, or more of in a movement sense, is that the benefits of narcissism occur early in an organizational setting, in more emerging context when things are starting, and the costs of narcissism appear when things have been going along, when things are enduring, when things are ongoing. Sort of like in dating, the benefits of a narcissistic leader are when you're going to see right away, and the costs are going to tend to bubble up later. It's a trade-off over time, just like the chocolate cake thing. At those initial phases of narcissistic leadership, you've got people who are confident, you've got this excellence in public performance I just talked about, you have initial likability.
- 5.42 There's a great study. One of my colleagues, [Harry Wallace](#), did this. This is back at Case Western. It was about dart-throwing. It was an old dart study. But he had people come in and throw darts, and he measured narcissism, so high narcissists, low narcissists, throwing darts at a dartboard. And he had two conditions. He's like, "We're filming this. Everybody is going to watch this in public." I don't know if they filmed it, but they said this is going to be in public. Second condition is this is going to be in private. What you see is that when it's a time for public performance, people who are narcissistic outperform because they're in public. So they'll put it all out there and outperform. When it's a private performance, they underperform. There's something about public performance that brings out the best in people who are narcissistic.
- 5.43 You see this with actors. You see it with everything. It works. That narcissism is going to be really good at that first thing. Over time, what you're going to see with narcissism are those negative things. You're going to start to see the bad decision-making, the big risk-taking. I got to do something. Leaders lead. How do you lead? You do stuff. When you do stuff, some of that stuff's good, some of it's bad. If you're motivated primarily by ego, you're more likely to get bad stuff. Eventually, people stop liking you because they realize you're a jerk. Often what you'll see are self-destructive behaviors. People in leadership position will go trash a hotel. I mean, these are things I've read in business magazines. It's like, go trash a hotel room on a corporate holiday and then charge it to the company. Like, why are you doing that stuff? Or drinking at jobs. Or just doing stuff that gets them fired, brings everybody down.
- 5.44 You get that pattern of trade-offs. Narcissism generally benefits early on and not later on. Overall, across everything, the winner in most of these things is the narcissistic leader. When the narcissistic leader goes in the company, runs through it, the company goes bankrupt, the leader usually does OK at the end. Occasionally, you end up with a leader in jail. I think one of the examples I gave, maybe you end up with a leader in jail. Very often what happens is you end up with the leader making a whole lot of money from this thing and doing fine, and then going and doing it again.
- 5.45 I used to talk to people, but I still do. I talk to people about this in the Atlanta area because that's where I live, near there. Atlanta area was home of a company, Home Depot. This is a little

bit of an old story I think I can tell, but people would always mention this when I talk about narcissistic leadership. Home Depot was a wonderful company. They got rid of some of the early CEOs, brought in professional management, hired somebody out of GE. Yes, that was it. They hired somebody out of GE, Jack Welch's company. The way GE worked, if you guys know anything about GE hiring, it was very much we'd rank everybody. If you're in the top 20%, we give you a raise. Bottom 10%, we'd fire you, and that was it. I might be getting these a little wrong because I'm not a corporate guy, but it was basically a very aggressive, competitive environment. That's just how they ran their stuff.

- 5.46 You bring in a GE guy, the best leaders in the world before GE went under because it was doing a lot of financial shenanigans. This person starts running the GE model in Home Depot and just wrecks it. Just wrecks it. It was a very collective, cooperative corporate culture. My understanding is, he just wrecks the culture. They put up with it for a while. Eventually, the board gets rid of him. The story is, he takes off onto I-85 in his eight-cylinder BMW. I don't know why they told me how many cylinders he had in his BMW. Maybe it was 12. I don't even know. Takes off about 90 miles an hour out of this, in this BMW, flipping the bird. I don't think he was doing that. I added that to the story. Takes off.
- 5.47 Then he goes, gets hired to run Chrysler or something. Then after that, they just hire him to run something else. It didn't matter. Makes millions. That's just a, that's a very, very common story with corporate leadership, where someone comes in, wreck a place, get paid, and just move on, do it again, because people are like, yeah, we needed somebody to wreck this place, and they were willing to do it. Generally, the narcissist ends up better.
- 5.48 The other thing that happens that gets really complicated here is often having narcissistic leaders in these situations kind of makes everybody more self-serving, everybody more narcissistic, everybody more acquisitive. I keep saying classic example, but this is the classic example. The classic example of how this works is the **commons dilemma**, also known as the **tragedy of the commons**. This is an old research article that was done in science, I think. Was it Hardin in the '60s? Man, I probably got that wrong. But the idea of a **commons dilemma** is you imagine there's a common grazing area, like Boston Commons. There's a common grassland in the middle of a city, and everyone can graze sheep. If everyone grazes five sheep, the grass grows back every year, and we can graze sheep forever.
- 5.49 But somebody goes, "You know what I'm going to do? I'm going to make a selfish choice that's going to benefit me, but maybe harm everybody else, but who's going to notice? I'm going to graze 10 sheep." So one person starts grazing 10 sheep. Well, what happens? The grass doesn't come back quite as much, and other people notice that they're grazing 10 sheep. So somebody else goes, "Well, I'm going to graze 10 sheep." And then the grass comes back even more slowly. And somebody else goes, "Man, that grass is going, I'd better graze 10 sheep." And then the grass is really not coming back. And they go, "Man, we got to get all this grass. Now I'm using all the sheep I can before this is gone," and they just eat everything.

- 5.50 That is called the **tragedy of the commons**, where individual choices that make individual benefit cause the destruction of the benefit for everyone. Another place you see this is something like overfishing or overharvesting in a forest. "Hey, if we all go catch 10 cod, we can have this cod fishery forever, and our great-great grandkids can catch 10 cod." One guy goes, "Well, I'm going to catch 20." Then the next person does 20, and pretty soon, the whole system collapses. That's the **tragedy of the commons**, the collapse.
- 5.51 That's what narcissism does. I did this in lab studies back at Georgia, probably 15 years ago, but you can see it in lots of places. If you set people up in a **commons dilemma**, and there's ways you can do this in a lab like, "Hey, you're a CEO. Chop down forest. It'll grow back at 10% a year. How much forest do you want to chop? Whatever. How much fish do you want to harvest from the sea?" What you find are that people who are narcissistic start off making more selfish choices, and then they drag everybody with them. They make more selfish choices, and then they force everyone else to become more selfish. They basically are the trigger that ends up destroying commons. That's a real problem with narcissism.
- 5.52 But even despite that, you're like, well, they destroyed the commons, but they still beat everybody else. When you run these simulations, like a **commons dilemma**, the commons get destroyed, but the narcissists are the winners, because they destroyed it faster and first. I like that word, first. First and faster. So like, yeah, there's no more salmon left, but the narcissist is like, "Dude, I caught more than anybody else. I'm going to go catch some whitefish now. Time for those Patagonia toothfish to, what'd everybody call it, Chilean sea bass, to take out a —" Sorry, I got a tangent.
- 5.53 That's how fish markets work. Fishing is, they'll come up with a fish that's popular, then they'll kill them all, just a **commons dilemma**. Then they'll come up with another fish that's popular. I was hanging out in Chile, fishing, and the captain of the boat was a fish poacher in the off-season. He would go down to catch Patagonian toothfish, which are what we call Chilean sea bass. That was the big fish. He said what they'd do is he'd run down to the Antarctic. He said there was one French boat down there trying to catch him, but the French were a little slow. They go down and just poach these Patagonian toothfish.
- 5.54 This is all horrible. I don't mean to be—a nice guy, but got to feed your family, but not anyway. That's the **tragedy of the commons**. You don't hear about Chilean sea bass anymore because they probably wiped them all out, and now they've probably got something else they're feeding us. I don't know what it is. That's how commons dilemmas work. But this is the key thing. The narcissists still win. That's why they keep doing it. The only defense against this is really strong—you need really strong regulations, rules about fisheries, and you probably need more than one French boat down there to stop this stuff. Again, narcissism is this complex trade-off.
- 5.55 The final thing I wanted to say about it is that some people have argued, and the data are almost perfectly mixed, that because narcissism seems to be both good and bad at different points, maybe what is optimal for leadership is a moderate level of narcissism. What they've argued is for what's called a **curvilinear** relationship. So low narcissism isn't so good for

leadership. Moderate narcissism is good for leadership, but really high narcissism turns around and it's kind of bad for leadership. People have made that argument that maybe there's this **curvilinear** effect. That could be true. I've seen people find it maybe half the time, and then half the time, you don't find it at all. There could be something interesting going on there. I just don't know what it is.

- 5.56** You can think about all this, this benefits and costs. You think about when we talked about the **chocolate cake model** with relationships, and you can see the same thing with leadership, same kind of leader. Well, who's going to become a leader? Who's going to be first? Well, the person who's going to become a leader is going to be more narcissistic. Why? Well, they're going to want it. They want to be a leader. They're going to have charisma. They're going to seem confident, and they have the **first mover** advantage. What you see with leadership across species, not just humans, but a lot of leadership is just willingness to act.
- 5.57** I didn't even define leadership. I've been talking about leadership for 20 minutes. I didn't even define it. I apologize. What is leadership? In academics, we talk about leadership is the ability to move a group of people towards a goal. I have a group of people and I motivate them, I energize them and motivate them towards a goal. That's leadership. "Hey, guys, let's win this football game. Hey, guys, let's sell 25 hot dogs today. Hey, guys, let's do whatever." That's leadership. The person who becomes a leader is very often the first person who wants to be a leader. "Hey, guys, who wants to be in charge?" "I will." That's part of it with narcissism. It's that **first mover**. It's wanting it. It's appearing confident. Often, this is linked to **extraversion**.
- 5.58** The other thing about narcissistic leadership that's interesting, where we find it attractive, where it gets this chocolate cakey quality, is we like narcissistic leaders when things are unstable. I mentioned that billfish model of destabilizing things. When things aren't stable, when it feels like the world is out of control, I don't know what to do, what I will look for as a human is I will look for a strong and confident leader. When things look bad, when things look destabilized, when I don't feel I can do anything, what I want is a strong and confident leader. That's when you're going to pull for narcissism. Unfortunately, whenever they make the world seem unstable, out of control, disorganized, when they make people scared and anxious, what they're setting people up for is the acceptance of strong authority or leadership from the outside to make them feel good. That's just how it works.
- 5.59** So that instability will pull for narcissistic leaders because that's what we want. Also, ethical context. In really ethical environments, you tend not to see narcissistic leaders as much. In poor ethical environments, you see more narcissism emerge. The classic movie examples of poor ethical environments would be something like a bucket shop or a sales shop for stocks. If you ever watch the Wolf of Wall Street, where they're selling stocks out of a boiler room, or the movie Boiler Room, I think was a movie—any of those really low ethical context, the people who are going to be really drawn to that are very narcissistic. The Wolf of Wall Street is pretty narcissistic. I talked to his wife a little bit. I should say his wife is a therapist who works with people who were married to narcissists. There's some history there.

- 5.60 But that environment is going to pull for some ego and some narcissism if you don't have a lot of ethical context as well. You find those kinds of contexts. You find a narcissistic leader. They're often very popular at first because they're charismatic or charming. You get a bit of a honeymoon period. Not always, but often you do. Then you get those problems we talked about —making risky decisions, doing self-centered stuff, helping themselves and hurting other people, aggression towards enemies. Generally, they generate a bunch of animosity, and then they get thrown out, or there's some conflict.
- 5.61 I'll give you an example of this in a second, but that's kind of the process, where we bring in these narcissistic leaders because they seem confident. We assume they're going to do a good job, and we need help because things are unstable. Then it turns out that maybe it was worse. They're worse than they are, and we get rid of them, and then we bring in another one. Every once in a while, you get a Jimmy Carter who's a pretty nice guy, and then you go, "Oh, they're not mean enough to do the job," and you get rid of them. It's just hard. It's just hard to find good leaders. Jimmy Carter is such a great example of low narcissistic leaders because people actually like him. People, like, his wife died, people were sad because he seemed like a good guy. Everybody. People, like, I didn't want him, wouldn't vote for him, but he seemed like a good dude. But that's the process you see in this.
- 5.62 If you take these ideas from leadership and organization and you look at political leadership, what you find, which shouldn't be a surprise at this point, is that political leadership is a big pull for narcissism. One study just came out. This was a buddy of mine up at Penn, I think he's at Penn State, in political science, and was able to get a huge database of people that were seriously running for office in the US. Like 50,000 people who were serious about it. Got that one item, got that Single Item Narcissism Measure, the SINS. You got that put in there. I get all excited. This is how you do science. You find a big data set and you're like, "Please, just put in one scale, just one item for me." You sneak it in.
- 5.63 He did that. Lo and behold, what you find is this correlation that people wanting to be more narcissism and more desire to be political leaders. I don't know lots of politicians. I know a bunch of politicians, don't have any problem with politicians, not all narcissists. Just generally, that's the pull because it's social status and power. US presidents, we have some really interesting work on US presidents. I like to say we when I had nothing to do with it. What we did is a field working together without me having anything to do with it. It's like when we win football games, like I'm always out there helping.
- 5.64 What a group of academics did was they wanted to understand the personality of US presidents. What's interesting about people like presidents is that they're so famous that every president has several biographies written about them, even the ones you've never heard about, like Buchanan. I think he was a president or Harrison, maybe. I don't know who they are, but they have several biographies written about them. So there are people who are experts in these presidents, not just their life as president, but also their early life. Everybody who's president.

- 5.65 So what—I think it was Rubenzer and I forget the other person did was they went to all these experts, these biographers of presidents, and they said, "Hey, we'd like you to rate these presidents using the Big Five personality scale," OCEAN, that we've talked about. We want you to do it at the level of the facet. Instead of just the Big Five, we're going to have you rate—for each of the five, we're going to have to rate you six specific facets. It's 30 personality ratings of each president. So, what we ended up with from that was personality data based on the pre-presidency personality on every US president up to, I think it was Bush, second Bush.
- 5.66 Once we had those Big Five data, through the magic of the nomological network, what we were able to do was convert those data into narcissism data. Because you can take all those facets of personality, you go, well, there's a lot of—there's low agreeableness and high extraversion, neuroticism, and using that combination and some correlations, we can magically turn those into something that looked like narcissism scores. By doing that, we're able to estimate the narcissism of US presidents historically. When you do that, it's pretty cool what you find.
- 5.67 And then on top of that, once you get the narcissism scores, you can correlate that with all sorts of other things about presidents because they've rated presidents for everything. So you not only know the actual vote count, how popular they were, but they've also been rated by historians for things like greatness. So how great a president were you? How much did you accomplish? We have just a lot of data on presidents. So what you find with US president narcissism is, first of all, it just seems to go up and up, historically. The one exception back in the day was Andrew Jackson, who I think was fighting the British at 14. He had some gumption.
- 5.68 But typically, presidents weren't as self-serving. You see it pop up with Jackson. You see it with Teddy Roosevelt, who's very driven, very ambitious. I mean, he's just an incredible human being. But then when they really start to pop with narcissism is when presidents, when TV happened. The old story is Nixon versus the Nixon-JFK debate whenever that Nixon would win. But then on TV, he didn't have makeup on, looked horrible. JFK looked so fresh, and people liked him better. That's the idea, that when presidency became basically a social media job, it's a media, it's an entertainment job. When we select presidents, we're basically doing a reality TV campaign. When that happened, what we started pulling for were just more narcissistic leaders.
- 5.69 If you look historically, the highest scorers, I think the most narcissistic you see is probably Lyndon Johnson. If you read his autobiography, which I haven't done, I just read pieces of it, Caro has this giant biography, not autobiography, a giant biography of him—he was just a horrible human being. At one point, my favorite story of him being a horrible human being was he was being asked by a group of reporters why he was in Vietnam, and he just pulled his pants down. That was his response. You couldn't imagine this because if people knew what he was doing, it wouldn't have worked. You have these very horrible human beings going into office at times. So that's just what's popped over time.
- 5.70 But what's interesting is if you look at these presidential narcissism scores, what you see is it's really a trade-off. Lyndon Johnson got a lot of stuff done. He got Medicare done. He got more done than a lot of people. So it's not a simple story. What you see with the more narcissistic

presidents on average is you see better crisis management. They seem stronger in a crisis. The world's at war. You want somebody out there who seems strong and confident. They're better at getting legislation done. So typically, they enact more legislation. They win more of the popular vote on average. People like narcissism.

- 5.71 Again, people will be very sad when Jimmy Carter dies. Did he die? I don't think he died. But no, people will be very sad. But no one wants him as president again because they don't think he has the action, but they like him as a human. The narcissistic presidents are more publicly persuasive. They're generally judged as greater, like using some of these greatness measurements, like Dean Simonson's greatness measurement, and risk-taking. You see higher risk-taking. Again, what you expect with narcissistic presidents, and then you see the bad stuff. You see abuse of power. That's a big one. You see cheating. Even like cheating at sports. Some presidents cheat at golf. Can you imagine being a president and cheating at golf? But yeah, that's the stuff you see. More likely to be impeached, but impeachment is pretty rare, until about a year ago. I mean, it was pretty uncommon.
- 5.72 Places political success before policy. That's that self-serving stuff. Puts yourself before policy. Power-oriented, yeah, so focused on power, and then tolerates unethical behavior and does unethical stuff. So generally, you find, with these more narcissistic presidents, you find poor ethics, but more stuff getting done. Again, it's a trade-off. This is where it gets even more complicated, is that people's perception of presidential narcissism depends on if they're on the same party as the person. Because if the person's on your side, you're like, they're awesome. And if they're not on your side, they're like a maniac.
- 5.73 And so what I'm going to do is I'm going to talk about some data we have on Trump and Hillary Clinton from before the last campaign. God knows I don't want to talk about Trump anymore, but I have to because this is the world that's been given to me. But it's really interesting data, and I want to do this without being political because I hate politics. I went into academics to think about issues that affected humans for thousands and thousands of years, not like what affects us in 2022. But that's not the world I was given.
- 5.74 What we did is we had people rate Trump and Hillary Clinton. No, we just had people rate Trump—Trump supporters and Clinton supporters—rate Donald Trump on Big Five, but at a very facet level, meaning like 30 facets. We're able to pull out narcissism like I described before with the presidents. And then we compared how people saw Trump, how the Trump supporters, and where they agreed and where they disagreed. It was fascinating. So if you look at extraversion, that Big Five trait of extraversion that would be key for grandiose narcissism, everybody agrees Trump's extraverted. Like, no, everybody's like, yeah, Trump is really assertive and he's really outgoing. Nobody doesn't. It's not like the Hillary supporters are like, no, he's just a shrinking violet. He hates him. They're like, no, he's pretty assertive.
- 5.75 Everybody agrees on extraversion. That piece of narcissism. What about the agreeableness piece? Narcissism, grandiose narcissism, high extraversion, low agreeableness. You see a difference. People who support Hillary think Trump is the least agreeable person that could

humanly be made. Like, literally, if you made a human out of a machine and put **agreeableness** at the lowest possible setting, that is **Donald Trump**. That's their view. You look at **Trump** supporters, no one says, yeah, **Trump** is Mother Teresa, but he is a pretty good guy, and he's telling us the truth. He's a straight shooter. They think **Trump** is a straight shooter, the people who support him, versus people who think he's not a straight shooter. They trust him versus don't trust him. That gap in **agreeableness** is big.

- 5.76 Does that make sense? There's an agreement on **extraversion**, there's disagreement on **agreeableness**. Then when you look at impulsivity and **conscientiousness**, which a little outside of narcissism, you see disagreement, too. Where people support **Trump** are like, he's hard-working, diligent, but he's a little impulsive. People who don't support **Trump** is, he doesn't work at all, he doesn't do anything, and he's a little impulsive, too. People agree he's impulsive. What can happen with leadership is you can have two people, two people viewing the same leader. One person sees somebody who's really narcissistic, and one person sees somebody who's a tough go-getter, but not fundamentally a bad person. It can be shades of this stuff, and this is why it's so complicated.
- 5.77 I'm just college football, coming back from the SEC and losing to Alabama again. I'm going to get this out of my brain in a week. But I tell you, if you ask people in Georgia about **Nick Saban**, coach of Alabama, they think he's not necessarily a good person. I'll just say that. Now, objectively, if I'm an Alabama fan, you think he's the greatest coach ever. He made a deal with God and Saint Michael to win everything. If you're from Georgia, you're like, I don't know what paper he signed at what crossroad at midnight, where, but he's not good. So you have the same figure seen as really good or really bad by different people depending on whose side. The truth is obviously in the middle. The truth is somewhere lost in here. I think there's some real nuance in this leadership piece, and this is why it gets really complicated.
- 5.78 Then what I told you I'd mentioned is the times we use narcissistic leaders. I sometimes think of this, I don't know why, but imagine you have a company, you're on the board of directors, you don't like how it's going, you're like, "Well, I got this crazy cat in a bag. Why don't I just grab this cat and just throw it into the company and see what happens? Mix it up." That's what happens with narcissistic leaders. This is an idea that I—this is with **Constantine Sedikides**, my advisor. He came up with this and made me work on it with him because he was worried I wasn't—I have a very good advisor who even at this old age is worried about me.
- 5.79 We started talking about this and we came up with what we called the **energy clash model** of narcissism, **energy clash model** of narcissistic leadership. Basically, the idea is that narcissistic leaders, when they enter an organization, go through this turbulent dynamic stage that gets resolved one way or the other. The three stages are perturbation, conflict, and resolution. God, those words aren't great. But the first word perturbation, we were thinking of physics. We were thinking of a physics model, that's why. But when you throw a narcissistic leader into an organization, it will become destabilized. They will start doing things. They will start making changes. They are not going to do a six-month listening tour. They're going to come in and shake stuff up.

- 5.80 Because it's new, often there's a little honeymoon period. But then what happens is certain people in the organization are going to start to fight back. They're going to say, "Man, there's this new narcissistic leader. They're messing with my department. I don't want them. We know what we're doing over here at drive shafts and brakes department. This new leader doesn't know anything. We got to do something." Then the people in the organization will start to develop a defense against that new leader. They might start to get together and fight. If they're academics, they get real tough and they have a vote of no confidence. That's the worst thing you can do. Sorry, it's not a joke, it's true. But that's what we do. We go, "We're going to vote no confidence." Everyone goes, "So?" You have a vote of no confidence. You're going to try to get rid of the person.
- 5.81 You're going to add pressure to get rid of the person, and then there's going to be a resolution. Either the new CEO is going to take over, throw out a bunch of people, it's done, or that new CEO is going to get tossed, and the whole system is going to reset. You think about what just happened at Twitter/X/whatever with [Elon Musk](#). He takes over. There's all sorts of chaos. Everyone goes, "We're leaving. We're going to throw away the advertising, blah, blah, blah." I think half the—he loses 80% of the company or something. I don't even know the numbers. He ends up leaving the CEO, brings in another CEO. Right now, we have sort of resolution, but we don't know where this is. This is not totally resolved. It could be chaos for another six years. I don't know. But that's what just happened in that system. You totally changed that system, threw people out, move it, and we're in the middle of that transition process.
- 5.82 He did that himself. He bought the company and did it, but that's something a board of directors would do, too. We've got this company. It's just not working well. We're going to bring in a new leader. University. We don't like the direction the university is. We're going to bring in a new president, whatever. There's a very intense dynamic whenever you have a company—I'm trying to think of another one. ChatGPT, another one of these tech companies where they just threw out the CEO, and I think brought him back in three days. It was the craziest thing. But that was some—I don't know what happened, but obviously, the CEO went in there and tried to mess with some stuff. Other people in the company said, "We've had enough. You're peace out." Then other people said, "Peace back in." Now they're resolving that.
- 5.83 But again, people are doing this intentionally to change organizations. Like you said, throwing the cat in. You got to change stuff. You don't do this to your relationship. You don't do it to a family system. You do it to a company. I'm running out of time here, but what I wanted to finish up talking about is, I tend to get down on narcissistic leaders, and I always want to come up with something positive at the end. What I wanted to end with is this idea that there are two ways of becoming a leader that people have talked about. One of these ways is through dominance, and the other is through prestige. You can think about a dominant leader is somebody who's feared and fights their way to the top, maybe respected, but also feared. A prestige-based leader is somebody who is loved and respected and lifted to the top.
- 5.84 There's different ways you can get there. When I started at University of Georgia, one of my colleagues, Sid Rosen, who's passed away now, he was a tank commander in World War II and

fought for Patton in the invasion of Italy. I met and I was like, I grew up with World War II movies. I'm a guy who was born in the '60s. This was just a different world. I was so excited. I'm like, "Oh my goodness. Tell me about Patton. Tell me about fighting with Patton." He goes, "It was awful. Patton was the worst." "What do you mean? I love Patton. I saw the movie." "The Germans had much better tanks than us, and we used to uparm our tanks. We'd put sandbags on them and barbed wire because that was our way of meeting the Germans. Patton saw that and made take us off, made him take them off. He goes it made us look weak. He didn't want us to look weak fighting the Germans. We were weak. We just got our butts kicked, but he didn't want us to look weak. We didn't like Patton."

- 5.85 He said, "We liked Bradley. Bradley talked to us. Bradley treated us like human beings. We liked Bradley. He was more of a soldier's general." You could see that in World War II. Both of those are great generals. Both had vehicles named after them. Patton got the great movie. Everyone loves the Patton movie because he's a larger-than-life character. He dresses, he's got a cool gun, like a pearl-handled revolver. I mean, who does that? He's Patton. He's a narcissistic guy. He's fun. Bradley's boring, but a likable good guy. And so that's the difference. Patton is a dominance-based, Bradley is prestige-based.
- 5.86 When you break it down with narcissism, the dominance-based leaders are the narcissistic ones. Prestige-based aren't. Dominance-based leaders are more aggressive. They're a little more neurotic. Prestige-based leaders are a little more extraverted, a little more sociable, definitely more agreeable, and definitely more ethical. So people who are ethical, still driven, but kind, and not aggressive, and respected, are brought into leadership, and the other people fight for leadership.
- 5.87 Where do I want to end? I'll end with this. You can talk about good and bad leaders, prestige-based leaders, and dominance leaders. The truth is, throughout history, the vast majority of people who took power and leadership were self-serving and never, ever wanted to let it go. People, then people's nature is to seize leadership, to acquire power, and to hold it for themselves and their families. This always happened. How do we know this? Well, when George Washington, our first president under the Constitution, served his term of president, he gave it up. People were shocked. People could not believe someone would give up that much power.
- 5.88 What happened is, they started comparing George Washington to the Roman general or council or leader, Cincinnatus, because that was the last—Cincinnatus, who we named Cincinnati after—was the last leader anybody could think of who intentionally served his country and then gave up power and went back to the farm. You actually can go on Google and you can see George Washington carved in marble to look like the Roman leader, Cincinnatus, because it was that far in between good leaders. It's just so rare.
- 5.89 My favorite example of leadership, I think, comes from the St. Crispin's Day speech in Henry V by Shakespeare, which I'm not going to read because it's so long and it's so Shakespearean, and I'm so much dumber than I was when I was in high school and could actually read that stuff. But in this speech, it was the battle, I think it was Agincourt, and the British, I think they're fighting the

French. Everything I say, I'm always like, I try to be 80% right. That's my general heuristic. Henry's going to lose, or he thinks he's going to lose. He has all these people with him. He's got his archers, he's got the normal people, and he's the king. He says, "Anyone who—" I'm going to cry when I talk about it. "Anyone who serves with me today is my brother. Anyone on this field with me is my brother. If any of us who live, there will be more honor to share, and nobody will forget what we did on this day."

- 5.90** I'm sorry. It's great leadership. My god, it's such great leadership. This is the king telling a bunch of serfs that they're brothers. All they have to do is fight together. That leadership that engenders such respect and loyalty from people, it's incredible. It's where that phrase, band of brothers, us few, us band of brothers, that they used for that World War II movie, that comes from that Saint Crispin's Day speech. What I want to conclude by saying is that you can have really strong, powerful, noble, positive leadership. It can be based on strength, it can be based on ethics, it can be based on courage, it can be based on risk-taking, and it can not be narcissistic. The truth is, we just don't see it that much. It's just very rare. I'll end it with that. Thank you.

6. Digital Narcissism

AT A GLANCE

Explores narcissism and social media. Social media is a medium narcissists use to gain attention, status, and esteem, exemplified by Khloe Kardashian disintermediating the media industry, glamour and travel selfies, and killfies. Narcissists have more connections, which biases our online image of the world. Reviews antisocial online behavior (trolling, anonymity), social media addiction as grandiose reward-seeking or vulnerable soothing, and detecting personality through cues using a Brunswikian lens model and at scale, as in Cambridge Analytica. Argues social media is an ego-based network that reinforces rather than creates narcissism, drives FOMO and status cycles, democratizes fame and celebrity problems, and shifts society from institutions to networks.

- 6.1 Narcissism and social media is going to be the topic for this lecture. This is one of the most interesting areas for narcissism. I think just from my own research experience, when I started doing this, we didn't have social media. It wasn't a thing. We had email, and I remember very distinctly when I discovered Facebook. I was like, oh my god, this is Facebook. I thought, "This is bigger than Woodstock. There are more people on this than at Woodstock." I ran down to my student, Laura. I said, "Laura, we got to study this Facebook thing and narcissism. Figure it out." Laura was a very smart student. She figured out how to do it. I got into this social media because it just appeared in my life. That was one of them.
- 6.2 The other thing that really stuck out to me was selfies. If you remember the history, people started on social media. One of the big sites was called MySpace. People would take pictures of themselves or selfies, but they didn't have the reversible camera, so they'd hold the picture like this. The pictures were always a little off because you're snapping yourself. That's when this idea of selfies started floating around. I think it was the word of the year, and I have this data in another place, but I think in 2013. We're not talking about a long time that this social media has been around. But in that very short period of time, it's taken over like crazy.
- 6.3 What we've seen since that early study with Laura on Facebook and some early stuff on social media, personal websites. Remember back in the day before we had social media pages, people had personal websites? There was a very early study out of Germany showing a correlation between narcissism and having a personal website. This idea of narcissism in social media has been discussed since the very beginning of all this stuff. It's an interesting topic. What I want to talk about today is a little bit like why narcissists use social media, which I bet you can guess, but I'll go into it a little bit. Then I'm going to talk about some of the findings we have of narcissism in social media behavior, like the friends, the connection, some of the stuff on social media addiction and trolling and things. There's some new work on that.
- 6.4 Then I'm going to talk about detecting personality on social media. This is a really cool area that I can't quite get access to necessarily, but there's the ability to detect and determine people's personality from the media, like narcissism. I'll talk about how to do that. Then a little bit more

about culture. Then I think the lecture after this will hit culture a little more directly. But that's the overall plan.

- 6.5** What is social media? Social media are these connected online networks where people are able to share and control the information they share with each other. There's some real distinct differences with these networks. They're not all the same, even though we say they're all social media. Some of these networks are more like peer-to-peer base. If I'm your friend, you're my friend. The old Facebook days, if I become your friend, you're my friend. There's an equality of friendship on Facebook. Something like Instagram or Twitter, you have followers. You go, I've got 6 million followers on Instagram, and I don't follow anybody. So it's more of a one-way street. It's just a little different setup.
- 6.6** Some sites are permanent, or designed to be more permanent, like Instagram. Some sites are designed to go away very quickly, like Snapchat. You've seen these interesting historical things where some kids will use Instagram for some things and Snapchat for other things because they want the more permanent record on Instagram and the more quick stuff on Snapchat, so it's complicated. The sites I've mentioned are all social media, but there're also really big social media sites like Amazon's review page. Amazon's reviews is an enormous social network, but no one really thinks of that as a social network because for the most part, most of us aren't going, "You know what? I'm going to get on Amazon and talk about how awesome I am." It's not really a social network. It's, "Hey, I like this chocolate I got, and they paid me for this review, but it didn't change me." Or maybe you want to become a super reviewer, and that's your little thing. But that's not for everybody.
- 6.7** We often chart, even study things like Amazon. There's also big cross-cultural differences. In the US, a lot of the research is on Facebook. China, there's the great firewall of China. They don't have Facebook in China, so we study WeChat. I work with a lot of Chinese academics, so there's a lot of good academic research out of China on WeChat and a lot of US research on Facebook. We put those together, but they're a little different things. Russia has a whole different search site that we don't use. There's not a lot of work coming out of there, but so there is these big cultural differences.
- 6.8** You can think about how the feedback on these different sites are structured. Some have thumbs up or hearts, some have stars, some have dislikes and likes. Sometimes they have dislikes, and then they get rid of the dislikes. If you think about it, different incentive structures are going to pull or push for narcissism. If I have an online site where the only feedback you can get is nothing or a thumbs up, that's going to be more appealing than a site where you can get a thumbs up or a thumbs down. Meaning, I can set up the feedback so it's more inflating or less inflating. I want to make that point.
- 6.9** Two final points. One is that it's very easy to talk about people on social media and make fun of people. I love making fun of people who are more successful than me because it makes me feel good and less little. But the truth is, the way the modern economy works is everybody is forced to self-promote. If any of you get a job, or you write a book, or you do anything popular, or

you're working for a company, somebody's going to say, "You got to go out there and promote." You're going to say, "I don't want to do that. That seems like something creepy that 14-year-olds should do." They go, "We don't care. This is how the world works. You need to self-promote. We're going to get you a coach." Then you're going to start smiling and doing **selfies** and self-promoting.

- 6.10** The reason I'm saying that is when you go online and seeing your buddy self-promoting, some of them love doing this and they're doing it for the ego, and some of them are doing it because it's in their contract. They have to do it. It's hard. This is complicated. I'm not trying to put down anybody for hustling and self-promoting because I think that's part of our culture. It's like, you have to hustle. People don't like it, but they do it anyway. That's a big point.
- 6.11** The final point I want to make is that I used to say, as doing social science, we're always driving, looking in the rearview mirror. Science always takes a couple years. A new thing comes up and it takes us a couple of years to do it. Cool stuff online that the kids are doing, by the time somebody does research on it, it's going to be years and years and years. So we're just slow. When technology is moving quickly, it's like, "Dude, we don't have science. We're just winging it at this point." I'm just being honest. I can tell you, I got a pretty good model of 2010 online world, but I don't know now. It could be changing in ways we don't really understand.
- 6.12** With that little bit of background, start out with a question, why do narcissists use social media, especially with **grandiose narcissism**? What social media is, it's media. It's a way of communicating. It's a channel, a medium, like a medium you talk to the dead people with. It's a medium for communicating with people, and you can put out positive information that you control. It's basically like you have your own TV station or your own network or your own whatever. When you have that opportunity to control content that you put out in a public space, that's going to be appealing to people who want to get **self-enhancement**, who want to be famous and everything else.
- 6.13** Imagine you had a million people who are narcissistic. They all wanted to be on TV. It was very hard to get on TV in the old days. Three channels, four or five channels. It's very hard to get on TV. It was expensive. You had to have satellites, or you had to fly to New York or fly to LA. Now anybody who wants to get on TV can just take a camera, do a picture, and do it. Narcissists are using social media primarily to gain attention, status, power, and esteem, and they're using it just like they would any media. That's the deal. You would expect people who are narcissistic to dominate social media because of the way it's structured, and that's, I think, what you find. You find people who are narcissistic are more connected. I'll talk about this in a second.
- 6.14** I used to think of it as an evolutionary niche. If you invite them, the perfect niche for lions is a big savannah filled with gazelle. They can just sit there, blend in with the grass, and every once in a while a gazelle comes; they can just go eat it. Perfect environment for narcissism is social media. "I can control what goes out there. I can pick the right glamour shot. I can tell when I'm going to do it. I can spend a lot of time crafting my message. Basically, I'm running my own studio, and so it's great." There's a —well, when I first saw this, and I apologize if I've told this

story before. The first time I noticed how this was going to work was I was teaching a class, and all the students were looking at their phones instead of listening to me.

- 6.15 And these two girls were looking at—so I'm like, "What are you looking at?" And they were watching Khloe Kardashian, I think it was Khloe Kardashian, driving a Ferrari through LA. So she's driving a Ferrari through LA, and they showed me this. My first thought is, "My god, what a waste of a Ferrari just going over a curb in LA." I mean, that beast, it should be on a beautiful road over the Amalfi Coast. That's where that Ferrari belonged, not in some backwood in LA. But after that, I realized, "Oh my god, she just disintermediated the entire media supply chain industry."
- 6.16 Meaning, the old days was Khloe would do her stuff. She'd have a camera team. They'd chop it up, they'd put it together, they'd package it, they'd sell it, they'd have a production company. They'd sell it to a network. The network would post it and sell ads. Khloe would get a little bit of that money. Khloe just said, "Hey, you know what? Maybe I'll just fire every one of you guys, and I'll just make my own reality television and show it to the kids, and then I'll advertise my own products, and I'll become a billionaire and a genius." That's essentially what she did. I don't know why she's not—I don't know why they don't teach courses about her at Harvard. Maybe they do. But she just intermediated the entire media industry and just took it over. That's why narcissism works online, because you can just take out industry like that.
- 6.17 You see this narcissism online in lots of examples. You see the glamour selfies. Glamour shots, these really positive selfies. You see now the filters people are using to get those looks. You see this in travel shots. There's been some interesting research on travel. I've hung out with people in the travel. There's a whole science of travel and tourism, which I should have done instead of psychology. I should have just been the cool travel guy. But what people will do is they'll go to exotic places and they'll take shots. See, that's why you see a million people in Dubai with the same picture. It's status. It's a way of getting status.
- 6.18 Then some of them are really funny. When you talk to—there's a lot of private plane photos. Here's me in a private plane, but what I've heard is that people will just go to private planes that are parked. They don't charter the plane. They just rent the plane, but then not the pilot. I don't know if it's true. I've seen ones where people will hold a toilet bowl up like this and then take a selfie so it looks like it's the window on a private aircraft they're looking out. You see people taking shots in first class. In the old days, you'd see, maybe they still do this, people would take pictures of their haul. They call it a haul. They go buy a bunch of stuff, or their parents would get them a bunch of stuff, and they'd take pictures, so there's my materialism.
- 6.19 You can see why social media is a good opportunity to gain status and esteem and attention from people because you can just brag, show off, self-promote, do all that stuff online. It's socially acceptable. It's just acceptable to do it. It didn't used to be, is now. What this ends up looking like is like your classic self-enhancement loop. You just see it with everything. You're narcissistic. I want to go get some positive attention. I'll go put a picture on social media of me hanging out in Dubai. I'll get a bunch of likes or hearts or thumbs up, or people will repost my

picture. That'll make me feel better about myself. That'll boost my self-esteem. That'll help me do something else. I'll take another picture of it, and it starts to cycle back and forth. We just get more and more extreme.

- 6.20 I'm thinking of like, there's somebody like that on YouTube, that Mr. Beast, who I saw, who does these things where he gets like a million, millions of dollars and millions of people watch him. It just got bigger and bigger and bigger. Not really narcissistic. It seems more charitable, more humorous. But you could see doing that with narcissism, where I've got to get even better. I've got to be in better pictures, more filters, more cool stuff. There's one guy in, I forget his name. Starts with a B in Nevada, Las Vegas, maybe. Anyway, Instagram, where all his friends are like, "You got to check this guy out." It's always like women, guns, beards, just Instagram. It gets out of control. So you imagine just these feedback loops where you're getting this status and esteem from online, you just keep going. Then imagine what it would be like to be online all the time, and then you're just offline all the time. You're like, "I got nothing." Just that emptiness, nothing coming back. I think that's kind of what's going on.
- 6.21 When you look at the actual data with narcissism online using something like the Narcissistic Personality Inventory to measure narcissism, you see a pattern of correlations. They're not huge effects, but it's a general pattern. You see people are narcissistic, spend a little more time online, pretty small effect, more status updates, so a little more energy online. I think that's real. Where you see the biggest and, I think, most reliable difference, and this is across studies, meta-analytically, is that you see people who are narcissistic have more friends or connections or followers or whatever you want to call it, more connections online. This is probably because they're putting out more content, because they're trying to get more connections, because their content's more entertaining, etc. You see this with grandiose narcissism. With vulnerable narcissism, we don't have enough data, so I think the effect's there, but I'm not sure. It's just there's a lot of noise in the data.
- 6.22 But what's really interesting about this is, what this means is, when you go online, when you go on to your Facebook page or your Twitter or whatever, Instagram, and you look at all the people you're following, they're going to be more narcissistic than the average population. Because people who are narcissistic have more connections. When you go look at your connections, they're going to be overrepresented by people who are narcissistic. If the narcissists are the ones connecting with everybody, they're connecting with you, too. So your connections are going to be overrepresented by narcissism. So when you go view the world through social media, when you turn on your social media and go view the world, you're going to say, "My goodness, the world has some narcissism in it." People are going to Dubai and showing off and using filters, and you're going to get a little bit of a narcissistic flavor of the world.
- 6.23 If you just walk out in the street and start talking to random people, you're going to have a little less narcissistic flavor of the world. If I go on my Internet and my Twitter page, and I see the Twitter posts, and I walk onto campus and start talking with people, the Twitter posts are going to be more aggressive, self-promoting, hostile, attention-seeking, and vaguely humorous. The people I meet in the normal world are going to be kind of nice. How are you doing? Good. Nice

day, isn't it? I love this heat. Oh, it's nice. Oh, it's a little chilly. Oh, good. That's our conversation, right? That's not social media. It's not, how's the weather?

- 6.24 Because of social media, not only do we have this playground for ego, but we also have created an image of the world. When we see the world, we're seeing a lot more ego than it is. It distorts how we see things. Kind of makes sense. I think that's neat about how narcissism works and some of the biases we see. General thing you'll see is the world isn't as narcissistic as we think because people who are narcissistic are just bigger. They just take up more space.
- 6.25 I mentioned another area, after they came up with online, was this idea of **selfies**. **Selfies** are taking photos of yourself. This sounds normal to you. The first time I had to do it was they were doing a little magazine thing, and they said, "Keith, do a **selfie** for this cover." This is not a TIME magazine. It's like a Georgia Country Club magazine for six people. I'm not trying to flex here. I took the camera and I was doing this. I just couldn't do it. I was like, "Dude, I can't do this. This is too creepy." I can do it now all day. I overcame that threshold. But the idea of taking a picture of myself seemed the most self-absorbed, stupid, arrogant. It just went against everything I believed in. Not anymore. Like I said, I'm totally on board of just, this turn us into robots and all die. But before then, when I was a human, I couldn't do it. What I did was I put my arm out and had the photographer take a picture. I was like this, and he just did a picture. It was a hard thing to do.
- 6.26 It was weird. Why would you take a picture of yourself? It's weird. In the old days, you'd put a camera and put a timer and run back and take a picture, or you'd have a self-portrait in a mirror if you're an artist. It just wasn't common. People started taking **selfies**. Again, I think the first **selfie** was, I think it was made word of the year in 2013. The first report of the term **selfie** was a drunk Australian that fell on some stairs, split his lip open, and then took a picture and sent it to his friends and said, "I split my lip, here's a **selfie**." I think that's the first use of **selfie**. Again, 80% right. That's what I promise. When I'm teaching class, I'm like, somebody just Google me. I was just like, Google me. I think that's right.
- 6.27 What you find with narcissism is you do find narcissism predicts more **selfies**, but like everything, it's a little bit complicated. Lots of people take **selfies**. It's just a normal thing to do. What you see with people who are more narcissistic is there are more **selfies** that are just themselves, rather than it's me in a group. It's not like an us-y thing. It's more an individual, more narcissistic. They take more full-body **selfie**, not full-body, I guess, but more body **selfies**, more skin in **selfies**. If somebody's doing a **selfie**, if after this, I'm all fired up, I'm like, "I'm a legend. I'm going to Miami Beach," and you see me down there, I'll be doing a shirtless **selfie** on somebody's Lambo. I always wanted to see the Lambo. I swear, like a Lamborghini, every 14-year-old guy wants one, but I always wonder when an adult buys one.
- 6.28 But one of those days, I'll get a picture with a Lambo. That would be a more narcissistic **selfie**. I couldn't do that. I would feel such shame. I got to do some inner work. But if I did the inner work to feel no shame and did that **selfie**, I don't know if I'd be a legend or a laughingstock, and I'd probably be both. Campbell, legend or laughingstock? You get more full-body **selfies**. You get

more travel **selfies** with narcissism. I love myself a good travel **selfie**, but that's where you see them, because it's status, because you can afford to travel places. Again, it's usually more high-status destinations where you get the more narcissistic **selfies**.

- 6.29 People who are grandiose find it more enjoyable to take **selfies**. With **vulnerable narcissism**, it's a little more complicated. What you see is, it's harder for them to take **selfies** because there's more insecurity, and they take more practice **selfies**. When you ask people who are more vulnerable why they're doing it, they say it's more about belonging. With the grandiose people, it's more self-promotion, self-presentation. With vulnerability, it's more like, "I want people to think, accept me. I want them to think I'm cool. I want to fit in." It's a little bit more social than with **grandiose narcissism**. A little different flavor to it. More agreeable people, less narcissistic, will take more of these group **selfies**.
- 6.30 The final **selfie** thing I wanted to talk about, I don't know why I got interested in this. I guess I'm interested in everything, and I was studying **selfies**. There's this research done on what are called **killfies**, K-I-L-L-F-I-E-S, **killfies**. These are **selfies** where people die taking the **selfie**. Yeah, it's weird. I'll give you an example. I was down in Machu Picchu, down in Peru with the kids, and I went down there. I call a travel agent. I'm like, "Just tell me the coolest thing to do, and just get me a ticket." That's usually my deep—I do a lot of deep research. Just find the coolest ticket and just get me the ticket. I got the ticket. Turns out, the ticket was to this trail called Huayna Picchu or something. You climb up this death trail off Machu Picchu with your kids. I was like, well, OK. My guide was super cool. He was like, "Yeah, we do this on **ayahuasca** sometime." I'm like, "Dude."
- 6.31 We're doing this death trail up there, and we get up and they go, "Oh, yeah, this is where the German died." What? Well, somebody took a **selfie** up there and just went right over the edge. You can totally see it because you're like, I want to get a **selfie**, and you start looking at the camera and you want to get that perfect picture. You go, OK, I'm just right. Boom, you're just gone. I would laugh at that person, except I would do it myself. I can see myself. I remember in Canada once, I was trying to do a picture. I'm like, I could have died doing this just by paying attention to the camera, not being a total idiot, just being a moderate idiot. There's those examples, and those are often just very unintentional. That's not somebody who is really risk-taking. They just wanted to get a good shot.
- 6.32 The ones where it gets riskier are people that will do it hanging off a building. They'll get a picture off a building, or they'll lie on a train track and do a picture before a train comes. The animal ones. Like, "Oh, here's me with a moose." That's right before the moose just—I feel bad for that, too, because people don't know. They just don't know. People get in those situations with nature and they just don't know. Sometimes what can—I don't know, I find this interesting. Sometimes what happened is ego in these **selfies** can just kill you. Literally, it just can kill you, because you just get so intense on getting the right shot, etc. That's narcissism in use, narcissism in **selfies**.

- 6.33 What about some of the online behaviors? There's been a lot of interest in online **antisocial** behavior, just bad stuff people do online. I have this list here I like. These include things like **trolling**, cyber aggression, cyber loafing, sending unsolicited explicit messages, the nonconsensual dissemination of sex, cyberbullying, problematic social media use, problematic online gaming, problematic internet use, internet use disorder, **social media addiction**, internet partners, cyber stalking, technology facilitated sexual violence, and technology facilitated infidelity. That just gives you a little list of bad things that can happen online. There's a lot of bad stuff.
- 6.34 One of the first ones on there and the one people get really interested is **trolling**. What is **trolling**? I always thought of **trolling** when I first heard it, I was like a troll under a bridge. There's a troll under there that attacks you. But really, it's a fishing term. I should know; I'm a fisherman. But you're just out there, like when you fish, you troll. You just drag a bait around, drag a lure around, and hope something finds it. So **trolling** online is just doing stuff and hope that you're going to entice somebody to respond, just like you entice a fish, and then you just mess with them. There's **trolling**, there's the aggression.
- 6.35 Generally, what you find across all these different studies is when it comes to the more aggressive online behavior, the more nasty **trolling**, the more toxic stuff, that's predicted by narcissism. Narcissism is a pretty good predictor for that stuff. We also see sadism, **psychopathy**. Those are maybe a little—it's really a lot of it's about being mean. What it's capturing is a lot of meanness when you do that. That's some of narcissism, but it's not fully narcissism. You get a lot, like I said, **psychopathy**, a lot of other things.
- 6.36 The other thing in social media that can facilitate this more toxic behavior is **anonymity**. There's a classic finding, this is classic social psychology, is when you get rid of people's identity, their moral systems get pressed down. You see this in lots of ways. You see kids on Halloween—these are old studies—kids on Halloween are dressed in costumes; they'll go just raid all your candy. But if you're like, "hey, Johnny, down the street," he's like, "Oh, I'm Johnny." He's not going to steal all your candy because he's not anonymous. He's identified. Or you'll see it in a car. Everyone's like normal people, but they get behind a car and they're flipping each other off and scream—it's me. I do this. People are screaming at you, like, "Dude, let's just have a beer and talk." "No, I'd rather scream," because you're anonymous in a car.
- 6.37 You see it with parties, dark, well, this just gets a little into relationships. But people in the dark are much more social than when they're in a super light place like this. You feel like everyone's just so identified. So generally, what happens is, you make people anonymous online, you're going to get more of what they want give you. If you have people who are narcissistic, and instead of being Keith Campbell online, here's where I live, you can find me, I'm like, hecklerdude 65012, I'm probably going to be a little bit more of a jerk because no one can do anything about it. There's less consequences. The **anonymity**, it can magnify stuff, and it can magnify good stuff, too. It's not just bad stuff, but it can magnify the more toxic behaviors for obvious reasons.

- 6.38 I'm going to say the other piece that's in here, and again, this isn't so much narcissism, it's **psychopathy**. But a lot of people are just online messing with people because they're bored. This is hard to think about, but really, you just see this, I'm bored, and people will do it for the kicks or for the "lols." They'll just go mess with people because it's fun, and kids are bored. That's some of what goes on, too. That I wouldn't call classically narcissistic. I'd say that's more **antisocial** psychopathic, primarily.
- 6.39 Another idea people have been interested in, I just touched on, is this **social media addiction**. People are worried that people are going to become addicted to social media and, I guess, never leave their rooms because they're always on social media. This is actually a really fascinating cultural issue. I first discovered this when I was in Japan, and people were telling me about the "vegetable people," and I've heard other words for this, but they're basically people, often men, who spend, you know, 25-year-old guy that just stays home all day playing video games, doesn't work, doesn't do anything. Eventually, the parents have to call somebody just to get rid of them. I don't quite know where they get rid of them or who the person is. That's the story I was told. There's obviously a Japanese word for it.
- 6.40 There's this concern that people are going to become so addicted to these social media sites that they become, well, their job suffers and their work suffers. I mean, their job suffers and their relationship suffers. Love and work suffer. In terms of conceptualizing **social media addiction**, it's a little hard to do because people seem to be doing it in a couple different ways. One is more for fun. It's more like dopamine. It's more, this is exciting. I'm going to try this. I'm going to try that. That sounds more grandiose. Then the other is more based on **neuroticism** or kind of a serotonin. It's a soothing thing. "I'm just real distracted. I just need to scroll to stop. I got to help myself relax just by scrolling through social media."
- 6.41 I do this all the time, so I'm not like—I got something to do. I better just, OK, that helps me feel calm. OK, world's burning down. Good, good. Yeah, makes me feel good. Still going to hell. OK, yeah. I was so bummed about the apocalypse. Then I had this buddy goes, "Well, you know apocalypse just means unveiling." I'm like, "Really?" I went and googled it because, of course, I didn't want to look in a dictionary. The etymology of apocalypse, it just means the unveiling or the revelation. I'm like, the Book of Revelation? They just tell me the truth? This isn't so bad. Anyway, that's how I learned to be excited about it.
- 6.42 There's two different models of online addiction, one that's more like, I'm going to get stuff. It's exciting. One that's more of a stress reducer. I think what you get, I mean, what you see in the literature, it's a small correlation with narcissism and online addiction. My guess, it's primarily more **vulnerable narcissism**. It's more vulnerable narcissists doing this. I think with **grandiose narcissism**, it's not so much an addiction, it's more of a tool. Now, that's just my hunch. My guess is, you'll see it with more vulnerability. I'm trying to think. I don't know that—there's a lot of interest before in gaming addiction. I remember when I was teaching, you have these kids that would play these World of Warcraft, and they'd be up for four days straight and stuff, and then they'd come in.

- 6.43 I don't think that's so much narcissism. I think that's—you get more **neuroticism**. It's fun, it's engaging. I think it's more of a pull that way. I think the media addiction is complicated, and I don't think this is just a big **grandiose narcissism** piece. In general, what you find is social media is going to be used more by people who are narcissistic. They're going to be more connected to social media. They're primarily going to use it for **self-enhancement** purposes, along with everything else, obviously, but the bias is towards **self-enhancement**.
- 6.44 So next question is, can you detect personality from social media? The answer is yes. So your personality leaves traces or cues, whatever you do. Your personality is going to be seen in your clothes, it's going to be seen in your words, it's going to be seen in the stuff you share, it's going to be seen in the movies you like, the music you like, the books you like, whatever it is. So your personality bleeds or just leaves traces on everything. Social media is just another example of this. So your personality is going to leave traces throughout your social media life, all sorts of ways.
- 6.45 You can see it in email addresses, like people who are narcissistic have more self-promoting email addresses. I think the paper was something like "fascinating king 814" or something, but more grandiose personal email addresses. You're going to see it in the photos, like we talked about. The number of friends. You can see it in things like language. Originally, I thought, I think other people as well, that narcissism would be associated with I-words. "I" this, "I" that, "I" that. It doesn't seem to be the case. I'd love to see more data, but often what you'll see with narcissism is more swear words, more cursing, more hostility, a little more anger. It's not just self-talk, it's a little different, but you can see it in the language. You can detect narcissism from all sorts of things.
- 6.46 When I first did this research, I was telling you about my student, **Laura**, and we went down. **Laura**, let's figure this out. What we'll do is we'll use what's called a **lens model**, or what's called, to make it even more fancy, a **Brunswikian lens model**. This is the model we use when we want to detect traces of personality. It works for other things, but detecting traces of personality online can work for a lot of things. We want to know two big pieces of information. First, we want to know—let's say it's maybe more than two. We want to know the site owner's narcissism scores, whoever's Twitter feed or Facebook site or whatever it is. I want to know their actual narcissism score.
- 6.47 Then I want to look at how that narcissism score predicts aspects of their site. Does narcissism correlate with how their photo looks, the words they use, how many followers they have, what hashtags they use, etc.? So I correlate narcissism in the site with all the stuff on the site, all the cues. Then what I do, so that's one piece, then what I do is I take a bunch of raters and I say, "Hey, rate narcissism on these sites. How narcissistic do you think this person is?" Then I correlate the rater's judgment of narcissism with those same things—the photo attractiveness, the number of friends, the words they use, everything else. Does that make sense? So I actually have the actual narcissism of the person, and then I have their website, then I have raters rate the website based **on narcissism**.

- 6.48 Then I go, "Hey, can people predict how narcissistic the people who are on the websites are? Can viewers predict that?" The answer is yes. People can detect narcissism from people's websites. They can detect other traits as well. But the prediction or the correlation isn't huge. It means they can detect it, but it's not like a magic insight. It's like, "I couldn't tell. I gave them all these personality tests. I really got to know him, but then I looked at his website and I knew the truth." It's not like that. My favorite story is, I was watching the TV show *Bones* about a crime-solving anthropologist, and they solved a crime because they realized the killer had **narcissistic personality disorder** by looking at her Facebook page. I got very excited that the FBI was using my research to solve crimes, but then I realized it was fake, and it wouldn't actually work. It doesn't work like that. You can detect narcissism, but it's pretty thin. It's not like a secret, it's not like you're solving crimes. It's like you're going to see the narcissism anyway.
- 6.49 One thing about this idea of narcissism detection is we can detect narcissism. The second thing you can do with a model like that, a **lens model**, is you can say, are people using good cues or valid cues, or are they using bad cues? There's not a real simple answer to this. It gets nuanced. But generally, I'd say generally people are sort of accurate. They're like, yeah, that person's got a good-looking picture. They're probably narcissistic. The people who are narcissistic are like, yeah, I got a good-looking picture. There's some correspondence there, but you get some places where maybe that doesn't work as well. Maybe people think, "Oh, narcissists always like heavy metal," and maybe they don't. Sometimes the cues are accurate, sometimes the cues aren't accurate. You could obviously train people to get better at this to detect the cues.
- 6.50 But instead, what people are going to do is figure out how to make computers do this and cut the people out of it. I have one more. Oh, good. I was going to go through one example of these, just discussing some of these specific cues for narcissism, just from actual appearance, just to give you an idea of some of the things they look for that work pretty well. This is from a large sample of detecting narcissism via the photos, just looking at the photos, not just looking at the number of friends and everything else. Where you see narcissism would be fashionable clothes, stylish clothes, expensive clothes, fraternity-sorority type. That's one of my favorite terms. This is an undergrad sample.
- 6.51 Neat appearance, cheerful appearance, higher amount of preparation required to look good. Remember I talked about narcissists spend more time grooming? That's something people detect. Yeah, they put a lot of effort into grooming. They could be a little more narcissistic. Attractiveness. People judge attractive people as narcissistic. Sorry, if you're the world's nicest. If you're beautiful, people are like, "You must be a little vain." "I'm really the nicest person." "I don't believe you." There's this natural, people think beautiful people are a little bit more narcissistic.
- 6.52 Then you get a few gender differences. Men who are seen as a little more muscular are judged as narcissistic because they're spending more time on muscular. Women, it's a little more cleavage, your eyebrows plucked. Yeah. And makeup. Yeah. So basic difference is, if you look well-groomed, well put-together, and a little bit attractive, people are going to think you're a

little more vain, a little more narcissistic, and they're going to be a little bit accurate. Does that make sense? But again, this isn't perfect. These are correlations like 0.2, 0.3, but that's kind of it.

- 6.53** I can do this with people. The beauty of the internet and social media and big data are I can do this at scale as well, if I have access to the information. What I can do, conceivably, is I can say, "Hey, look, I found a thousand people online. I found their narcissism scores, and I also found what that predicted on their Facebook page. I found that I can predict people's Facebook page from their narcissism scores in these thousand people." I imagine I can do that. Then I go, "Now that I know what narcissism predicts on Facebook for those thousand people, why don't I go through a million Facebook pages, take that information, and try to estimate narcissism from that information?" If I know narcissism predicts X, Y, and Z in a sample of a thousand people, well, I'll go out to a million people, I'll measure X, Y, and Z, and I'll use that to predict narcissism. Does that make sense?
- 6.54** Once I build that model, I can scale it through my whole system. It's incredible. I was talking to a Facebook bro back in the day, and he comes over and goes, "Hey, check out what I have. Here's narcissism scores for the entire United States of America on a beautiful map. The more red colors, they're more narcissistic." I thought, well, that was fabulous. This is really interesting to see. I know this isn't perfect. I know these are just estimates at scale, but it gives you a really interesting idea of how the world works. There's only one problem. We had to shut all that research down because Facebook started thinking, "Oh, we're going to get in trouble mapping out world personality, and we're going to get bad press." That was the end of my narcissism research. It only exists in my head. It never was published, but they have all that information.
- 6.55** What you can do because of how personality is predicting online behavior, you can basically, once you build a model, you can extract people's personality at scale around the whole world. You just need access to the data. But again, it's not going to be perfect. I'm getting too in the weeds here. But when this became a big political to-do, if you ever remember the Cambridge Analytica scandal and all that, what they were actually doing was trying to estimate **Big Five** personality from people's likes. They thought if people were more conscientious, they'd be more likely to be conservative or Republican voters. That was the whole model. There's another piece, too. But it was a very, very simple model. It was not going to change the world. But people get very nervous about this. I think for good reason, because you can scale this stuff up and it's just ridiculous, the power you have. That's what people are able to do.
- 6.56** To just give a few reflections here before I get too weird, social media can be used for a lot of different purposes. Social media can be used to connect to friends. It can be used for information. A lot of this is informational influence. Like I said, what's a good suitcase to buy at Amazon? What's a good academic paper to read? I can get a lot of good, real solid information online. It's also used for humor or entertainment. Positive effects. A lot of things that are shared are funny things. The other things that get shared, a lot are angry things. A lot of emotional stuff gets shared.

- 6.57 Narcissists are using this primarily, like I said, for **self-enhancement**. If you step back, and this is where it starts to get a little bit weird. When you step back and you think about how social media networks were built, they weren't built like roads. When we built the US highway system in the '50s—I think, was it Eisenhower?—what we did was we said, well, we got these 30 big cities, and we need to connect them all with freeways, so let's build the freeways here, here, here, and here, and here. They planned it. When they built social media, the people in Silicon Valley didn't say, "Hey, there's these 20 cool people out here. Let's make sure those 20 cool people are on social media." They're like, "We got to let it build itself. We have to let it grow itself." Well, we could pay people to do that, but that would cost money. So what we need to do is convince a bunch of people to go build this social media infrastructure for free, and then we're going to monetize them.
- 6.58 How do we do that? Well, how about we use some ego? We can get people to go out there and get attention and get thumbs up, and as long as we're feeding them thumbs up or hearts or stars, they're going to do whatever we want. Essentially, we just took a bunch of Skinner's pigeons, taught them to peck and get a food pellet, and then said, "Go build that social network. Be free." What happened was we built an entire network that is largely, although not entirely, built on ego. It's an ego-based network. Bitcoin is a network built on mining. People have to go solve problems with their computer to keep that network going.
- 6.59 For social media, it's ego. If people stop being narcissistic, it would go away. I mean, maybe you'd have cat pictures. You're like, "Hey, Grandma, here's my cat." But other than that, it would die. We have this very weird system where one of our most important economic engines is based purely on manipulating people via their ego to go post a bunch of content for free. It's sick and sad and twisted and all that. I think that piece is really interesting to think about.
- 6.60 Another piece that I think is really important to talk about, which I didn't hit, but the question comes up is, does social media turn people into narcissists? So assuming we're using people who are narcissistic to create these networks, does just being on social media make you more narcissistic? And that question is tricky. What I first thought when I first started looking at this, and we'll hit this in some later lectures, I thought, yeah. I thought you give people cameras and put them on TV, you're going to end up with a lot of narcissism. It doesn't seem to necessarily be what's happening.
- 6.61 What seems to be happening more is that people who are narcissistic are able to reinforce or maintain their narcissism online. It's used to reinforce narcissism, but it doesn't—again, I could find more data that's going to change this, and the studies are small, but it doesn't seem that we're building ego. It seems like we're allowing some people to build ego, maintain ego, but it's not really narcissism for everyone. I'll get to a consequence of that in a second. I think that's a pretty big issue.
- 6.62 The other thing that makes this work, assuming these networks are built by narcissists, in large part by people who are narcissistic, there's a few things to think about. One is people who are narcissistic are setting the cultural tone on social media. The cultural tone is about self-

promotion and looking good. Most people on social media are like, my life on social media looks like my life is, just usually at sunset. I'm usually a little better-looking than normal, and I've usually got a smile on my face. My kids love me on social media. They love me most on social media. The world I present on social media is a little more positive than my life, but it's not crazy. It's not like it's totally different. It's just the good sides of my life.

- 6.63** What happens is social media becomes a world of winners and losers where people put out all this good stuff, and then you end up watching it. So imagine you've got all these people, narcissistic. They're putting out really good content. You got me on there going, I'm putting out good content, too. Just trying to act not like I care. You see all this good content out there. You're not very narcissistic. What happens is you start becoming anxious and you start feeling you're missing out. You start feeling like **FOMO**, fear of missing out. You start comparing yourself to an ideal image. So you imagine what's happening is a bit of a dynamic where you have really narcissistic individuals setting the tone for what's appropriate, what's attractive, and everything else, and other people going, "I just got to fit in. I feel like I'm a loser."
- 6.64** Because in narcissism world, it's all about winners and losers. In the nice person world, it's like, "Hey, we're inclusive. Everybody come in." It's like everyone's on the ship. My house during the pandemic, it's like everybody's welcome. We'll just stay on the ship, guys. Narcissism world, it's winners and losers. What it ends up doing online is you have the winners, and then you end up with a lot of people trying to fit in. You have a lot of anxious people trying to fit in because they don't feel good enough. You end up with a cycle of ego, and then ego drives anxiety and people trying to fit in. That drives a lot of these fitting-in behaviors, and also a lot of problems.
- 6.65** For example, people on social—this is one of the first things that I noticed. People on social media have good-looking teeth, just like celebrities. You see all your friends on social media with good-looking teeth, you do a **selfie** and you're like, "God, my teeth are yellow. I shouldn't have had all that coffee in 1980 through 1990 through the 2000s. I need to get veneers." I keep trying to get veneers. Like, I'm from Hollywood. I'm just too lazy. I got to do that to keep up. Or, "God, everyone looks so good. I got to get fit, or I need a new outfit because everyone's outfits are good, or I got to go to Dubai because everyone else is going to Dubai." It leads to this cycle of status and then people following status, which is a problem.
- 6.66** But what you'll notice is people who have status, they'll always change what's high in status, so they're always ahead, so you can never, ever catch up. In the old days, rich people had carpet in their houses, and they had really pasty skin because they didn't go outside because only poor people worked in the fields and had wood floors. Then we learned how to manufacture carpet real cheap up in North Carolina and Georgia and stuff. Then it turned out that the poor people had to work in factories. Rich people were like, "I've got a lot of color on my face because I'm at the golf course or I'm playing tennis all the time, and my house has hardwood floors because they're more expensive."
- 6.67** You get, what happens is, the status, what is considered status, will constantly change, and there's always going to be winners, and there's always going to be losers. Unless you're

somebody like me that just picked an era like 1993, and I just stuck with it my whole life. Then when the cycle hits, like every seven or eight years, I'm like, I'm right at the sweet spot. They started making in California, they started making all this stuff, all these shirts with rainbows on them and stuff. It's all the stuff I wore when I was a kid. I go buy these clothes and I'm super fashionable. I'm like, "Yeah, because I wore this in '75." It's like you just can't come up with anything new. Anyway, sorry. Nostalgia. That's the process. Excuse me.

- 6.68 There's a cycle to this. Another way to think about this is about the democratization of fame, or the democratization of celebrity. In the old days, there were very few celebrities. I can remember every famous actor I ever ran into for one second in my life. I remember—I can't remember her name. Some famous actress passed by me in a grocery store once. She goes, "I'm going to pass by you like the plague." I still remember that because it was such a weird thing. What? That was very weird. It's a very biblical reference. It's just very strange. But I remembered that my whole life because they're a celebrity, they're famous. It used to be very hard to be famous. Before I was born, there was only one famous person named Elvis. He was the only famous person in the world, I think. Then they had the Beatles and a few other famous people. But fame was very hard to find. It was very hard to get fame.
- 6.69 With social media, it democratizes fame. We all can be famous. The only difference between Khloe Kardashian and me is she's willing to go for it. Probably a little better-looking, too. A little more talent. But other than that, we got the same shot, because we can all get our own camera, we can all produce our own thing. When you democratize fame, you democratize celebrity problems or problems of the famous people. What are the celebrity problems? What are the problems that the Hollywood people have? Well, they're narcissistic. They feel deeply empty inside. Why do they feel empty? Because you get everything you want, and then you're not fulfilled, and then you feel empty, and then you go to Dianetics or something or Scientology or whatever. You just fill the void. It's a curse to get everything you want.
- 6.70 You end up with body dysmorphia. You end up going, "I'm not that attractive." If you've gone to your plastic surgeon's office lately, what you've seen is a sign that says, "Hey, look good in selfies. Get this procedure done." They're literally selling plastic surgery so people look better in selfies. There's some really interesting research on this. For example, you take a picture and it makes your nose look bigger because the way a camera works. It's ended up distorting a lot of people's views of how they look. They go to a surgeon, like, "I want to look like this selfie, and so just cut this part out." I'd love to do that. Just cut my nose and I'd be, like, so it's attractive. You end up with body dysmorphia, narcissism, booze. You got all these basically celebrity problems.
- 6.71 The problem with being an online celebrity is you don't have any money. If you're an actual Hollywood celebrity, they pay you occasionally. Occasionally, you have an agent, you got a PR person, you got a team around you. This democratization of fame, I think, has led to a lot of challenges and a lot of problems, especially for young people, especially for young girls. That's a whole another discussion. But if you've read about what's going on, that's a real issue. The point I want to—I'm good here. Where I want to end is that we are now moving for a variety of reasons from an era of institutions to an era of networks. Meaning, in the old days, when we

didn't have a lot of communication, we had institutions, like universities. We had newspapers. We had legal departments and justice systems. We had all these big, huge institutions. Medical systems.

- 6.72 Right now, we're losing faith in all our institutions. I'll show you some trust data in some of our upcoming lectures. We're losing faith in institutions, and instead, we're moving to networks. Instead of an institutional-based system, we have a network-based system. The network-based system is going to be nested on individuals who have power. When I'd ask my class about this, I'm like, "Would you rather be Warner Brothers Music or Taylor Swift? Who's more valuable?" They're like, "Taylor Swift," right? She's more valuable than the entire music industry. I don't know if that's true, but that's how people would see it because she can go, "Hey, I'll fire all you guys, start my own music company. I'm more valuable." What the heck happened?
- 6.73 When that happens, the people who are going to be running the world are going to be more narcissistic. No hate for Taylor Swift. I love Taylor Swift and Beyoncé and all their fans. I'm very clear about that publicly. But despite Taylor and Beyoncé, who are great, you're going to end up, just on average, a little bit more with the people running the show are going to be more narcissistic at the center of these networks. And so we're going to move to a networked world from an institutional world. It's just happening right now. There's going to be a lot of weight on individual narcissism and self-promotion when you do that.
- 6.74 In big institutions, they were supposed to wipe out narcissism. You're supposed to not have a lot of narcissism in the Catholic Church. You're supposed to not have a lot of narcissism in hospitals, not supposed to have it in academia. You do, but it's supposed to keep it suppressed. But when we're on our own, it's just going to get more and more. I think we're going through this remarkable change to a greater networked world, and I think the beneficiaries of that, in part, will be more narcissistic, more self-promoting individuals because they're going to love the opportunity to get out there. And that's a positive note to end this on. Thanks.
- 6.75 What could we do? You mentioned in the leadership talk how narcissistic leaders are most likely to rise up over the course of history, especially now going from an era of institutions to an era of individualism. What could we do? I don't want to generalize and say narcissism is just evil, but it seems like there's a lot of evil things that are with it. It seems we have to do something. What could the honest good person do? How do you compete with narcissists?
- 6.76 That's a great question. I think. It's a great question. Let me think for a second. A challenge is, if you have individuals out there promoting themselves, you're going to get more narcissism. Doesn't mean they're always evil, but those are the people you're going to get. You're going to get people who are more confident, who aren't going to say they're wrong, etc. One possibility is to instead of promoting individuals versus systems, have small groups. Now, I'm just thinking this through. A lot of very good things get accomplished throughout human history with small groups of individuals working together in a collegial way and not in a—I'm thinking Manhattan Project. Manhattan Project, that was actually a bigger one.

- 6.77 But lots of small groups of people can get stuff done. Maybe it's moving not just individuals, but smaller groups. I'm just making that up on the spot, which is a terrible answer. But a small group of high-trust individuals founded this country. Small group of high-trust individuals working together can do a lot of good. If it's a small group who care about each other, that's going to keep the narcissism suppressed. That's one idea. The other idea, this is what's so hard, is you really need truth. You need a good, you need good journalism. But we don't have good journalism anymore because we shut down all the newspapers. We don't have a good system to detect honesty. I think we need a good system to detect honesty.
- 6.78 Is narcissism ever necessary to have a successful society?
- 6.79 I think people have to be willing to take risks and go for it. And for a society to work, you need risk-takers, you need people who are willing to build stuff, people who are willing to lay it on the line. You can do that and not be arrogant. I'm a little narcissistic, believe me. I'm an academic. It's part of the job. But I'm not super narcissistic, but I'm willing to do anything. Somebody's like, "Hey, Keith, after this, let's go jump out a plane off Key West and maybe go night diving for sharks." I'd be like, "Mushrooms? OK." I'm a maniac in a way. I think you can do stuff if you're willing to do it. But you have to be willing to take risks and do stuff. I think you can do it without the ego, but you need courage, and that's a little different.
- 6.80 I do think that's part—I think of somebody like Chuck Yeager, the pilot, the great test pilot, risky. You go, that guy, most alpha, gutsy person, not narcissistic. On the edge, but not—just fearless. I think you can be on that edge of being driven, assertive, but also be a decent human being, or at least be willing. I think you need more people like that. The problem is when you start, "Hey, let's get a bunch of astronauts," you're going to get, end up with a bunch of people who just want the attention. But I think you need the risk, the capacity for risk, though. Sorry, I'm rambling here.
- 6.81 One thing I notice when I look at the world is I see a lot of fear. I just see people are very, very scared. In a world like that, you end up looking to somebody with an ego to take charge. But if you're like, "Hey, you don't have to be a big deal. Just go for it. See what happens," you can get stuff done and not be an ego maniac. Yeah. Sorry, I'm going to keep talking here. The other thing I've noticed with people who really do stuff, people who actually go out and have lives, they're usually not ego-maniacs. I hang out with big wave surfers, and they're pretty chill because every one of them has almost died a couple of times. Hang out with real estate guys. Most of them are pretty chill because every one of them has almost got wiped out in '08, '09, this other time in that one flood.
- 6.82 It's like, people who live actual lives, actually embrace life, are usually pretty chill. The people I see as more arrogant are people who haven't done a lot. Then they have this the fantasy that they could if they —it's a very long answer. I like that answer better than your answer. I'm trying to improve, guys. I'm trying to get better.

- 6.83 Going back to talking about just this generation growing up with social media, do you think that does have an impact on the **vulnerable narcissism** side? Because you were saying it doesn't create narcissism technically, but it could at some point? I don't know.
- 6.84 I think that's a great question. I'm going to hit on this a little bit in our next lecture. My hunch is that **vulnerable narcissism** is increasing. What I mean by that is, I see people who are fearful, who aren't going out and trying to do stuff, but seem very envious that other people have success and seem embittered that they don't have success. My hunch is that a lot of the narcissism we saw after the economic collapse transformed into this more vulnerable flavor. I just don't have data to say that for sure. My hunch is that's what's going on, that we're seeing a lot of **vulnerable narcissism**, but I don't have a great data set where I can say it for sure. But it's that neurotic ego-based. It's like, I'm scared, but I still want to be in the game. I think I see a lot of that.
- 6.85 Thank you. Do you know of any data on the use of psychotropic medication to treat **NPD**?
- 6.86 The short answer is no. Psychotropic medication, that's a broad term. I'll mention this stuff a little bit, but the one time you'd see it, you might see it with more vulnerable features of **narcissistic personality disorder**. You might see something like an SSRI being used. For vulnerability, we did have one data set where we looked at narcissism with **ayahuasca**, which I would put as a psychotropic medicine, maybe a super psychotropic medicine, and looked at changes in narcissism and did not find them, other than the vulnerability. It seems that some of these medications might help with **neuroticism**, fearfulness, anxiety. But what's going on is it's maybe reinforcing **extraversion** or reinforcing positivity or **self-esteem** or ego, which is in the direction of narcissism. It's complicated.
- 6.87 There isn't a—what would be the word? An ego agonist? Or would it be an ego antagonist? I forget my—there isn't an anti-ego drug, I don't think. There's a pro-ego drug. There's a lot of those, like cocaine or I think methamphetamine. I've talked to a few people who became meth addicts because I was curious why. I think you get some ego from meth. I think booze; people call booze liquid courage. I think a few drinks is going to inflate ego. I think we have ways we can inflate our ego. I don't know about drugs that take ego away very well. Other again, than that neurotic ego, but not classic narcissism. But I'm not a big drug guy. I'm not a bio guy that's trying to turn things on and off with simple molecules.
- 6.88 Thank you guys very much.

7. Culture of Narcissism

AT A GLANCE

Shifts from individuals to culture. Defines cultural narcissism as individualism without responsibility, self-enhancement, exhibitionism, entitlement, and weakening social connection. Reviews rising US narcissism scores to a 2008 peak, inflated self-ratings of college freshmen, the California self-esteem movement, China's Little Emperor Syndrome and rice-wheat differences, and global data linking narcissism to low-trust societies. Distinguishes stereotypes of national character from actual traits, then surveys five themes: the celebritization of culture (with the Dr. Drew celebrity study), individualism in baby names, language, and housing, the great fantasy migration into geek and online culture, the Adulthood Optional Society, and the breakdown of religion, trust, community, and family. Ends by hoping for a counterculture.

- 7.1** In today's session, we're going to take a little bit of a detour. We spent the initial sessions talking about narcissism, primarily as a quality of an individual, whether it be a personality trait or disorder. What I want to talk about in this session is narcissism as a quality of a culture. I want to focus on this idea of **cultural narcissism**. I mentioned this at the beginning, this idea goes back, it probably goes back to Lasch's book, **The Culture of Narcissism**, or Tom Wolfe's *Me, Me, Me*, Decade. That's when people really started thinking about a self-centered culture. Now, as soon as I say that, I'm starting to think of some historical classical example. It's the Phoenicians. No, I didn't say that about the Phoenicians. This is when people started thinking about it. It's maybe the '60s and '70s in the US.
- 7.2** So what I want to talk about is **culture of narcissism**. I'm going to do this in a couple of ways. So when you think about a narcissistic culture, you can think about two things. You can think about a whole bunch of narcissistic people that come together to make a culture, or you can think about a culture that captures a bunch of narcissistic elements of which some of the people are narcissistic, but not everybody. There's a couple different ways you can think about culture as narcissism, at the individual level or at the more structural level. This is what I'm going to try to get through today, is to talk about both these levels.
- 7.3** I'll talk about US narcissism. I'll do some of the global narcissism. Then I thought what I'd do is hit on a few themes that pop up with these themes of **individualism**, things of declining trust in institutions. I'm going to talk about the **great fantasy migration**, which is one of the things I got interested in, the movement online. I'll talk about some of these cultural themes and then try to end on a positive note. It won't be positive, but I'm really going to try to end on a positive note because it's —Anyway, people always want to, whenever you write about stuff as an academic, they're like, "And then what do we do?" You're like, "Dude, that's not my job. I'm the academic side. That's the what-we-do side job, but they're not working." I don't know.
- 7.4** What is **cultural narcissism**? What do we mean by that? I'd say a narcissistic culture is a culture that's focused on **individualism**. The individual is the primary agent of the culture, not the

family, not the community, not something greater than the individual. It's a culture focused on **self-enhancement**, looking good. It's a culture focused on doing what you want. Maybe you can say that it's hedonism, it's doing what you want, but it also can be just more broad liberalism. Like, "I just do whatever I want, and what I want is the most valuable thing." It's a culture of exhibitionism, which is, "I'm doing what I want. By the way, I want everyone to see me doing these cool things because it's all about me, but it would be better if it was about you, too."

- 7.5 Then in a narcissistic culture, you get higher levels of **entitlement**. People just expect more for them and less for this. They expect to get more and give less. What's that, it's the old John Kennedy, "Ask not what your country can do for you, but what you can do for your country." Yeah, that's not narcissistic. That's the opposite of what we do now. Then you also get a breakdown in social connection. Just like narcissism is an individual level, it's like there's this enhancement, this **extraversion**, and also this lack of **agreeableness**, lack of connection. In a narcissistic culture, what you have is a breakdown of social connection. People just care about themselves more than they care about other people. You imagine a narcissistic culture, it's about you and self-promotion, but it's also about a breakdown of connection, breakdown of family connection, breakdown of social connection, breakdown of trust, breakdown of cohesion, and breakdown of **empathy**. I'll talk about trends in these different directions.
- 7.6 Another way I think about narcissistic culture is a culture that values or enshrines **individualism** without responsibility. I love **individualism**. I'm an American. I'm a Californian. I love it. But it's the **individualism** without the responsibility piece. It's like, "Hey, just do you, but don't worry about anything else. That stuff, people will take care of all that stuff." That's where it gets broken. I told you this is something that Lasch wrote about originally, and maybe Tom Wolfe, and then Jean Twenge and I wrote about it before the great financial crisis, when we wrote **The Narcissism Epidemic**. We thought of this as very much an American issue, but it's very global. We've seen this narcissism, **individualism**, around the world, and there's some interesting debate. Well, I'll get to it. There's interesting debate about where it's showing up.
- 7.7 As I said, when we talk about **culture of narcissism**, we can talk about the individual members of that society, how are their personality traits, and we can talk about the society itself. What I thought I would do quickly is talk about trends in actual narcissism scores in the US to start with, because that's something we've looked at. We looked at a lot. We don't have a lot of recent data people are asking about, but we have pretty good historic data. What you see in the US is that **grandiose narcissism** scores, like **NPI** scores, Narcissistic Personality scores, started going up in the '80s. They were low in the '80s. They started going up through the '90s. They started and they peaked in maybe 2008 and 2009. That's when we wrote **The Narcissism Epidemic**. Of course, we wrote the book right at the peak.
- 7.8 That was right before the great financial crisis, which some of you remember, and some of you were probably, fortunately, too young, and all you remember is your parents being panicked, but maybe you didn't remember it so much yourself. But what happened was, before that, there was a huge interest in reality television and wealth and material goods and things, and that changed a little bit with the crisis. We have seen narcissism scores go up with individuals. It

looks like it started trending down in '08 and '09. What I think is going on, somebody asked about this earlier, and this is speculation. I hate to speculate, but what the heck? I don't have data and money to get it. I think what's going on is we're seeing greater **vulnerable narcissism** now.

- 7.9** The reason I think that is because we've seen anxiety and depression scores start going up, starting in about 2012, especially with younger girls, but you've seen guys, too. We started seeing this more negative self-view start to increase. My hunch is the narcissism we're seeing now has a more vulnerable, envious, insecure, neurotic flavor to it. Still self-centered, but a little different than, "Hey, check me out." It's a little more, "You're acting like a big deal. I need to take you down." I think that's what's going on. But anyway, we did get a pretty good spike in narcissism up to '08. We can also look at it with other data. There's other data we have, not just narcissism scores.
- 7.10** One huge data set, they measure American freshmen, like every year. Samples of millions of people. They ask freshmen to just rate themselves compared to average people on a bunch of traits. How self-confident are you? How good at public speaking are you? How good at math are you? What's your academic ability? What's your drive to achieve? So all these self-related traits. What you see with that, going back to the '60s, is that college students just think they're more positive now. Just a general trend in positivity up, where people are like, "Yeah, I'm better than the average." It's not that college students are like, "I'm a 10 out of 10." They just tend to think they're smarter than other people now compared to how they did 20 years ago or 30 years ago. So there's been this inflation in self-belief in college students, and it's happened across, it's happened across these different dimensions.
- 7.11** I should mention college students aren't getting smarter or anything. They're not getting better. It's really weird. This is some of these numbers that get confusing. It's selective universities the kids have gotten better, up to maybe a few years ago. If you're to select for a state flagship school or Ivy League, any really good school, they've gotten harder to get into. But more and more kids are going to college, so the average college student has gone down in quality, just because we're taking more people. It's a little bit complicated what's happened with that. It's not that the kids are that much smarter, and so this is accurate, is what I'm saying.
- 7.12** Then we also see this on—we've seen this trend in **self-esteem** going up. The **self-esteem** story is really interesting. There was a concern in the late '70s, early '80s in California. It was started by a state legislator named **Vasconcellos**, and he was interested in the fact that kids seemed to be suffering. It was the '70s, kids had poor grades, there was criminality, kids were having children out of wedlock. He thought, what can we do about this? He was interested in humanistic psychology, and he thought, "You know what we need is we need to give these kids some **self-esteem**. If we got these kids some **self-esteem**, then they wouldn't have all these problems." They started the California Task Force on **Self-Esteem**, and then the Republicans got involved, so they added "and social responsibility" to the task force. They decided to say, "Hey, let's look at what **self-esteem** will do if we can give kids **self-esteem**." This is about 1980.

- 7.13 They did a whole bunch of research, published a book. You don't really see **self-esteem** does much for kids. It doesn't really seem to do that much good. **Self-esteem** feels good. It seems to predict depression a little bit. But generally, it doesn't make you not do crimes. It doesn't make you do better in school. It doesn't do a lot of the things they'd hoped. It was a bust, but that didn't stop —the fact that the research didn't show much didn't stop the social movement. What we ended up happening was this effort to inject **self-esteem** into schools, which we call the **self-esteem movement**. Some of you probably experienced this when you were in school.
- 7.14 They did different things. They increased grades. They removed some punishments. They've done even more of that. They started telling kids they're special. My kids would get these assignments like, "Fill out these coloring things. Oh, what does it spell? I am special." Or you'd write a list. My daughter would come home and say, "I'm making a poster board about all my special qualities, Dad." I remember once my daughter was like, "What's my special talent?" I'm thinking, "I don't know what mine is, sweetheart. I'm 50." She goes, "I'm nice." I'm like, "Oh, good. You're nice." I'm like, "Yeah, that really sets you apart." I didn't say that. But I'm like, "Who the heck is asking a seven-year-old what their special talent is?" I mean, come on. They're not like a young Mozart or something. These are just kids.
- 7.15 But that was the **self-esteem movement**. It was done to help people. They did it to help kids do better. It was effective. **Self-esteem** went up a lot in our country. When we looked at the data, **Jean Twenge** and I did some meta-analyses. **Self-esteem** bottomed out in about 1980 for the kids, '81 in the US, and then it just started going up and up and up. Now, it's going back down, I think, a little bit with some of this depression. But generally, most American young people have very high **self-esteem**. On a 40-point scale, if I went to a class, if the scale is from 10 to 40, the average would be about 35. That's my guess. Meaning, people are scoring very high to the top.
- 7.16 We've seen this big rise in **self-esteem**. It didn't have any of the positive effects anyone predicted. It didn't make kids smarter. It didn't make them get along better. In fact, it does the opposite. When I first heard about this, I said, if you want to bring a group together and make them like each other and cohere, what you do is you make them all the same. You go to the military and they shave your head and give everyone the same outfit. They don't say, "Hey, you're special. We're going to call you Cool Keith and give you this military outfit, and you're going to get this outfit, and then we're going to work together as a unit." It just doesn't—anyway, exact opposite of what should have happened.
- 7.17 That **self-esteem** that we're seeing, I think now is being matched with some anxiety, pretty high anxiety, pretty high depression scores, again. I'm not getting into the social media and **FOMO** stuff, but I think that's part of what's going on. There is this interest in narcissism scores in the US. In the US, we had enough historical data to track it. We don't really have historical data in a lot of other countries. There became this interest in Asia. Some of my Chinese colleagues got involved, but there's also this very interesting discussion. I remember talking to academics from Singapore about this. They thought, well, America is really creative and really narcissistic. So maybe we need to import some narcissism to get some creativity.

- 7.18 There was this debate a little bit about, do we need some narcissism to get American creativity? This is coming out of Singapore because, if you have a very Confucian culture where people don't want to upset or make the people above them in the hierarchy look bad, it stifles creativity a little bit. There's a bit of a debate. People started researching narcissism in China, and it's fascinating what you find. There's a couple really cool findings. The first, which is a more deeper environmental effect, is that you find higher levels of narcissism and **individualism** in northern China versus southern China. The argument that they've made is part of that is historical, has to do with farming rice versus farming wheat and animal husbandry. Sounds weird, but this is one of these cool **cultural narcissism** arguments.
- 7.19 If you have a cultural system that demands a lot of collective action to work, people are going to be less narcissistic in that culture. When you're harvesting rice, the way it works is, water comes in, it goes into my buddy's paddy, and it floods his paddy, then it comes to my paddy and floods my paddy, then it goes to my buddy's paddy. We all have to work together for the rice harvest to work. It doesn't work the same with wheat. You don't have to have everyone sharing the same way. You end up with water wars. With animal husbandry, where you're running herds or flocks, that's when people get very possessive and very violent because you can't have anyone steal your cows.
- 7.20 This is a longer discussion, but let me put it this way. If I've got a herd of cattle somewhere, a herd of yak in Mongolia, and someone steals one of my yak, that yak is worth my year's salary. I can't have anyone steal my yak. If I'm farming wheat and somebody comes and runs over and grabs a bunch of wheat, I don't care because that wheat isn't worth that much. You end up with a little different culture depending on the basic economics. In China, you get that northern and southern difference because of the rice farming, which is fascinating.
- 7.21 But that's a little beside the point because the more interesting stuff is the modernization of China. What's happened to China, just like the US 50 years before, is this massive movement from rural areas to urban areas. You've seen massive urbanization, and then you've seen the one-child policy, which was put in place and then removed. But for a long period of time, you were only allowed to have one kid. Now no one wants to have kids anyway. But during that crucial period, when they did, you only had one kid. What happened in China is, you end up with people living urban lives instead of rural lives, being socially isolated, only having one kid.
- 7.22 Then you had this really interesting phenomenon they called **Little Emperor Syndrome**. It happens as you have four grandparents, and then the grandparents have two kids, and then they have one kid. Basically, all the wealth is spilling to this one kid, hence the term **Little Emperor Syndrome**, because they're getting the wealth from the whole family because they shrunk the family so much. Sort of the anti-Confucian model. It's very interesting. When people have looked at this cultural change in China, what they're seeing is sort of like the US. You're seeing a rise in narcissism. Again, urbanization, lack of social cohesion, et cetera. It's not just a US phenomenon.

- 7.23 We've looked at it in a lot of places. In one of the—there's a lot of really good narcissism work coming out of Poland. It's been these efforts to bring together large groups of international researchers to measure narcissism in lots of countries where it's harder to get data. We had one study, I think, with 47, maybe it was 37 different countries. Very large samples. When you do that, the story gets a little bit different. It's not just modernization and globalization that leads to narcissism. It also seems to be some lower trust societies that are more tribalistic. A little more, well, it'd be low social cohesion societies that aren't necessarily modern. You'll find a lot of narcissism, too. Lower trust societies will be places where you see narcissism because if it's a low trust society, everyone's got to promote themselves, defend themselves. It's not just the US, it's not just other places. You do see it around the world.
- 7.24 But I do like to think of the US as the capital or world leader of narcissism and exporting narcissism, because I don't see anyone else really doing it. I don't see anyone else, I mean, maybe the British during the Beatles invasion or something, but most of the time, most cultures aren't pumping out narcissism. I guess the biggest cultural— the big cultural source right now would be K-pop, so South Korea. But those bands aren't really, they're not super narcissistic what they're feeding out. They're feeding out boy bands where there's usually one—I think they usually have one narcissistic guy in them. I don't remember my boy bands. I thought the boy band was usually the nice guy. Then there's one bad boy in the band. Maybe I'm wrong. I don't know. No one's smiling. I guess I don't remember my boy bands too well. I always thought they had one tough guy in there. But America I like to think of as putting out a lot of narcissistic content.
- 7.25 So one way you can look at narcissism is, you can just look at narcissism scores, individual scores in culture. Another way you can look at cultural narcissism is basically through stereotypes, which we call perceptions of national character. So what you can do is you can say, hey, what is the typical American like? Rate the typical American on this personality scale. Rate the typical Spaniard on this personality scale. Rate the typical Turk on this personality scale, whatever it is. You can get people to rate the typical member of a society.
- 7.26 When you do that, what you are not actually measuring is the average personality score of that society. What you're measuring is the stereotype of that society. It seems this is just the way this works. When you ask about the typical member of a society, you're getting the stereotype, you're not getting an average. We've done this, we've done this with Americans, just asking Americans, how narcissistic do you see the typical American? Then, how narcissistic are you? How narcissistic is your friend? We've asked people in other countries to rate America in their own country. We've done this in a few different ways.
- 7.27 First off, without getting too wonky here, is if you look at how Americans rate the typical American, and you convert that to personality disorders, they mostly see Americans as narcissistic. That's our profile. It's narcissistic, it's antisocial, then it's histrionic, borderline, and then paranoid, in that order. Meaning, that we see ourselves, because remember this from when we talked about the personality disorders, we see ourselves as a cluster B society. We see

America as, the typical American as, a narcissistic, antisocial, histrionic, borderline, a little bit paranoid weirdo. The next is schizotypal. Literally, that's what it is.

- 7.28 Our view of a typical American is not super positive, but it's not super positive in the direction of narcissism and self-centeredness and cluster B, which makes sense because this is what we watch on the television. When we turn on reality television, who are we watching? Cluster B individuals. When you turn on politics, who are you watching? Cluster B individuals. When you turn on about anything. I guess the athletes have to be pretty well adjusted to succeed. You can't be that crazy to be an athlete. But we probably like the crazy ones better. They probably get more attention because they're probably more entertaining. That's how people see American culture.
- 7.29 It's really true around the world. We've done research for different cultures. Here's the pattern you see, which is really interesting. If you ask people to rate themselves, rate a friend, rate their culture, and rate the US, as narcissism, here's what people usually show. "I'm not super narcissistic. I'm OK. My friend is a little more narcissistic than I am. Not too bad, though, but a little bit of a jerk. My culture is more narcissistic than my friend, and America is more narcissistic than my culture." That's the pattern people see.
- 7.30 We've done this, like I said, we did it—we have Chinese samples, we had a Turkish. When I used to do cross-cultural work, I haven't done it in a while, I'd always try to get pretty diverse language groups. A Turkish group, because Turkish is just very different than a European language. I'm sure Turkish is Indo-European, but it's pretty far from English and Latin. We had a Basque sample to try to get something a little interesting in Spain. But you see the same pattern everywhere. What I want to say by this, when we talk about cultural narcissism, we're talking about something that's different than all the individuals. It's possible to have a narcissistic culture without a bunch of narcissistic individuals, which is how America is.
- 7.31 You come to America, you go, "I'm going to meet a bunch of reality TV people." When I came to Miami, I thought I'd see a bunch of guys with no shirts on driving Lamborghinis. That was my impression. I saw a Lambo today. I came out of my hotel and I'm like, "There's a Lambo." It's all black. I was like, "This is cool." I almost got a picture in front of it. But that was my image of Miami. Really narcissistic, shallow, vain, with good family values, strangely enough. That's what I expect to see in Miami. I get here and it's like, "My shirt's been on the whole time. Everyone's shirts have been on." Not only that, but everybody's been really nice to me. No one's like—one guy wanted me to check out his car, and it was awesome. He was a young guy, and I was happy to tell him his car was awesome.
- 7.32 But other than that, I have had nothing but people being lovely, kind, warm, and welcoming. But still, when I go home, what's your stereotype of Miami? Oh, my god. It's these shirtless guys with Lambos. That's just all it is. A lot of Bitcoin, too. A lot of Bitcoin and Lambos. That's the difference between a cultural stereotype and a culture, and they're just two different things. They're just different things. But we get hung up because, well, that's stereotypes. That's the difference in the person and the culture. What I thought I would do for the rest of this talk is talk

a little bit about some of the cultural themes we're seeing that are in the direction of narcissism. I'm just picking some of my favorites. There's some more.

- 7.33** The first of these themes I want to talk about touches on what we talked about in our lecture on social media, which is the **celebritization** of culture. I'll go through this quickly, but it's an interesting idea. What happened was the original fame system of culture, which was a very well-structured, organized machine out of New York City, where they wrote the music in Tin Pan Alley, out of Hollywood. We had the studios who owned the stars that put together the stuff. I joked last time, in the old days, Elvis was the only star. But you remember Elvis always had this colonel that would go around with him or some military guy that made sure that Elvis stayed on track. It was a very controlled entertainment system. They wouldn't kiss on TV. It was just a very controlled system.
- 7.34** It started getting less and less controlled over time. We had cable. You guys are probably too young to remember. That was a big deal when you could get more than three channels, plus that other one that was always fuzzy. Then you got social media. Then you had this mass distribution of really high-quality digital stuff, cameras, recording devices, et cetera. Via people like the **Kardashians** who figured this out and other people, you developed an entire democratized celebrity culture. I think the key, probably the key bridge was reality television. Reality television actually goes back, it goes back into the '70s. If you watch the first reality television show, it's really boring. It's just like a dumb family at home doing nothing. It's really not a fun show.
- 7.35** But they learned how to make reality television. Reality television was, hey, we'll bring in all these people. They all want to be celebrities, so they all have some personal problems. A little bit of **cluster B**. We're going to put them in a situation where they have to compete and not trust each other. We're going to add a lot of alcohol to the situation just to make sure that they're not sane. Then if they're too nice, we're going to set it up. So the producer is going to walk over and go like, "Hey, did you hear what Keith said about you over there? He said you were going to lose. You're not going to be the survivor." And then they go over there and like, "I heard Keith's coming to get you. You'd better watch." They set this whole thing up.
- 7.36** I did a show called Bullshit with the Penn and Teller, the magicians, a long time ago. The camera crew was there. I like to talk to people. You might not have guessed this. This is how I learn everything. I just talk to camera crews. I said, "Well, tell me about reality television." They go, "Oh, yeah, it's all fake," and they're telling me everything about it. It was really interesting. They go, "You know the guys that aren't fake? It's Jackass. Those Jackass guys are crazy. They're really like—" He goes, "That one scene where he jumped that rocket, slid off a pier, I thought he was going to die." That made me feel good. I'm like, well, at least Jackass is a great American. Everything else is fake.
- 7.37** What happened was, they turned us all into celebrities. As I said, we got celebrity problems. But what I wanted to talk about, since we talked about some of this, was a great study where they actually looked at narcissism in celebrities. This was done by **Dr. Drew** from the show Love Lines,

and I've never met Dr. Drew, and another professor named Mark Young, who's an accounting professor at Southern Cal. He is a very nice guy. I talked to Mark about this for a while.

- 7.38 What they were interested in is, hey, we want to understand narcissism in celebrities. It's impossible to get data from celebrities because you can't talk to a celebrity. You got to go through five people. What they were able to do is, as Mark would go to hang out in the green room before the show, and hang out with the celebrities, and he'd have copies of the NPI, the 40-item Narcissistic Personality Inventory, and he'd ask people to do it with pencil, with no names, put it in a big thing. We'll never know who you are. All we're going to know is what field you're in generally. I don't even think—they asked how long you'd been in the profession and gender. I think that was it. Very, very limited. I was a reviewer on this, which I guess I can admit.
- 7.39 The reason they did this is because that's the only way they could get these data from celebrities. It was an absolutely fascinating data set. They got over 100 people. What they found was, they found that overall, celebrity narcissism was a little bit high, not super high for everybody. It was high, like you'd expect. But then it was high in really interesting ways. The highest scores of narcissism, and it's hard to distinguish between, are these significantly different? Because how do you even know how big your sample is, what your population is? But highest scores were reality television. Reality television actors. Why? Well, what do you bring to reality TV? I want to be on reality TV because I want to be famous. What do I got? I got a personality and looks, and that's it. That's what I'm bringing to the table, right? I'm no Meryl Streep. I didn't go through 40 years of Shakespearean acting school at Avon-upon-Stratford, or is it Stratford-upon-Avon? I forget.
- 7.40 When you see the narcissism scores, the highest scores were reality television. The second highest, I thought were interesting, were stand-up comedians. I thought about that for a while, and I thought, well, part of it is you got to tell jokes, which isn't being mean to people, which is part of it. But the other part, if you're doing stand-up, you walk into a room like this, instead of you nice folks, you've got a thousand drunk people that think they're funnier than you that want to heckle you. You got to be a little bit antagonistic and a little bit competitive when you get on stage. I think it makes sense that it would pull for some of that. If you were really nice, then everyone's like, "You suck," I'm like, "I do suck. I'm so sorry." You just, that would be the end of your career. I thought that made a lot of sense, too.
- 7.41 Actors were relatively high, but they actually have talent, so not as high. I don't know a lot of actors, but what I've noticed in my very limited time is there seems to be a little bit of a difference between actors who have a craft and celebrities who act in order to get attention. I think there's a little difference in that because I met a lot of actors who are real craftsmen, real craftswomen, very skilled. Then finally, the lowest score of narcissism was in musicians. That one I thought about, and I live in Athens, Georgia, which is a music town, so I went and talked to some of the musicians about it, and they said, "I bet those narcissism scores were high for those musicians." I said, "No, they were actually not as high as other people." They said, "Oh, that's pretty funny."

- 7.42 They said, well, I think what's going on is, if you're working with a group of people, unless you got lead singer syndrome, which they call lead singer syndrome, other than that, you got to get along with everybody in your band. If you don't get along, they go, yeah, and if you're in Athens and you don't get along, we just send you to Nashville. So I thought, well, so maybe that's where the ego is. They send the ego to Nashville once your head gets too big for a little town like Athens. But I thought that was interesting. But that's very much of a group thing. It's like, if your head's too big, your group's like, dude, "You're getting too much fame here. You got to dial it back. Let me do a number, even though I'm playing bass. I just want one song."
- 7.43 Anyway, again, I touched on this last time, but what we're seeing, theme one is this **celebritization** of culture where everyone wants to be. Here's where I'll finish. Whenever you hear the interviews with kids, what do you want to be when you grow up? A TikToker. I don't know if this is true. I've heard this from so many people. I remember the old data, and I don't know if this is true, but I literally heard it from a driver yesterday. Number one thing is be a TikToker or be an influencer. Oh, god, that's a tough life. That's something going on.
- 7.44 Second big theme I want to talk about is just **individualism**. You can see this in so much. We look at different cultural products. What does culture produce? We try to analyze those different cultural products. There's lots of them that we've—when we did **the Narcissism Epidemic**, we were just trying to find things. One of the coolest data sets we have is the baby names data set. Every baby that's born in the US that gets a social security card, which is most of them, has their name recorded in a giant database. This goes back to the '30s, and it will show the popularity of all the different names. Every year you go, here are the top 10 most popular names, and also shows you how popular they are, how many people have those names.
- 7.45 We've looked at these databases just to look at the changing in name patterns, and you see a few different things. One thing is you see name works with fashion, so the sounds of names change. Right now, I don't know if they're Emmas and Avabas and Avas and Ellas, or I don't know, that may have been five years ago. A lot of times there's a sound that people like that sort of changes. But the thing we really focused on was uniqueness of names. Do people have more unique names now than they used to? The answer is yes. This is a little hard to explain. Let me try to explain it this way.
- 7.46 You go back to the 1940s, right after World War II. You go to a middle school classroom, grade school classroom, and what you're going to end up with is three Johns. There's going to be Johnny One, Fast Johnny, and Little John. Because in that era, a third of the boys, 30% of the boys, had one of the top 10 most popular names. Names like James, Robert, John. That means like 30% had one of those top 10 most popular names. You'd always have people with the same name in your class. Women, it was very similar. It was a little less common, but about a quarter of women had one of the top 10 names. Mary, Linda, Barbara. My mom's Linda, born around the '40s. If you go back earlier, every woman was named Mary. I think everybody was Mary in the whole country. About 80% were named Mary.

- 7.47 What you had were, you had very common names. What that does, what having a common name does, is makes you feel connected to something else. My name is William. I go by Keith, but I'm William Keith. Why am I William? Because every man in my family is named William. Every one of us, my nephews, I got William Connor, I got William Burke, I got my dad's William D, I got my uncle William A, my grandfather William D, other grandfather William A. He didn't have a name. I think he was just A. It was all Williams. Everyone goes by some other name. That makes me feel connected. That doesn't make me feel special and unique. It makes me feel connected. My father-in-law was Eddie. In his family, in a Brooklyn Irish family, everybody was like, there was Fast Eddie. He was Fast Eddie, Fast Eddie, Big Eddie, Eddie Hands, the Eddie Fingers. Everybody was Eddie something, all Edward. What that does is makes you feel connected.
- 7.48 What's happened over time is that the popular names are getting much less common. When we last looked at this about 10, 15 years ago, you're talking something like under 10%. Maybe 7, 8% of the kids will have one of the top 10 most common names. The popular names just aren't as popular as they used to be. If any of you are from the '80s, Jennifer was the popular name. There were six Jennifers in your class. Not anymore. Now, there'll be two of the most popular name or whatever. What we're doing is we're individualizing our kids, and the celebrities do this. Elon Musk's kid is like XYXQ or something or whatever, Apple. They always said celebrities will do this more than anybody. But it's just a way of individualizing how we see our identity.
- 7.49 I just want to say this, if you're ever naming a kid, this is my advice. I don't give advice, but this is advice, so I apologize. Put Senator in front of it or Chief Justice. My firstborn, I was going to name her Trout or Juniper Trout. But then if I put Chief Justice Juniper Trout, you're like, yeah, it's not getting the job. Usually, if you just put Senator in front of it, if it sounds good, that's a good one. If it doesn't sound good, it means you're being too creative and you should stop. Just general advice there, just to help your kids out.
- 7.50 The other thing is, it's very hard to beat the system. With my second daughter, I knew about how this worked. I wanted her to have a really popular name that's been popular for a long time but isn't trending. I look through all the names. I'm like, Charlotte. OK, that's good. That's been around a million years. You got a few queens named Charlotte, but it's not very popular. Well, two years later, you get some princess over in the UK, "Here's my new baby Charlotte, Princess Charlotte." I'm like, "I'm screwed." That's the most popular name in the world right now. My daughter's in trouble. But it's hard to beat the stuff because I was doing the same thing everyone else was doing, and I just picked the—anyway, it's fashion.
- 7.51 Names have changed. Our language has also become a little more individualistic. We've looked at this in some different ways. What's cool—I love looking for big databases. Google, for a while, scanned all the books until somebody said you can't steal everyone's books, and they did it anyway, but then eventually they stopped. They scanned everybody's books, and then they developed something called the **Ngram viewer**, like low case N, capital G, gram, viewer, which allows you to search for the frequency or percentages of certain words over time. You can search for phrases and how phrases have been used historically.

- 7.52** We tried to look for more individualistic phrases over time. We did find an increase. I have the list here of words—unique, personalized, self, all about me, I am special, I'm the best. All those things went up over time. We found the term "you" going up more over time, me and you going up. It was more of a you, which I'm not sure about. The other thing you're seeing in the books is a greater emphasis on self-help books or self-improvement books. A lot of our books have become more about us. Instead of reading stories about somebody else, it's here's your tool, how to change yourself. Now, I've written them because that's what we're interested in. I think generally, I think generally, our language is just becoming more individualized.
- 7.53** You see this in living spaces as well. Another big data set you have out there is the—oh, man. Forget it, is it CDC? Who does this? Anyway, some government agency collects housing size information, square footage of houses, numbers of rooms, and numbers of bathrooms. You can get these housing data over time. It's fascinating what's happened. I can give you the example. I live in a little old area in Athens, Georgia, that was built in the '20s, teens, '20s, '30s. It was originally built. It's called Five Points. If you drive around and look at the old homes, the way an old house was built in the '30s is you'd walk in the door, there was a small public area, which was a sitting area with a fireplace, and then that was the public part of the house. Then there was a private part of the house where there was a small kitchen, often like a galley kitchen, two or three bedrooms, and one bathroom because families were able to share a bathroom with each other. That was the house. It was a public versus a private house, and you had one bathroom and then separate rooms.
- 7.54** What's happened over the last 100 years, if people have gone in and remodeled every one of those houses, and how they've remodeled them is they've opened it up so that the kitchen and living room are connected, so we don't have a private and public space anymore. We now just have a public space, and when people come over, they'll walk right into your kitchen. In the '50s, that never would have happened. We built, everyone gets a bathroom now, so every kid, every adult, gets a bathroom. My kids' bathrooms have marble because they're special. Then some of these new houses, they're putting rooms for wrapping. Here's your gift wrapping room. Here's your TV media room. Here's your this.
- 7.55** What we're doing is, we're individualizing, literally, the physical spaces we live in are becoming more and more individualized. So even under the same roof, we're living more separately as families. By the way, families have gotten smaller and smaller this whole time. The large families shared one bathroom, but our tiny little families have eight bathrooms. That's how it works. College dorms, you see the same process, where they're just becoming luxurious. The dorms they have now are very nice with gyms and climbing walls and all that stuff. It's just because that's what we want. As a group, we just are much more individualized in terms of our physical space, our living space, how we identify ourselves, our names, everything else along those lines. I can keep going, but I'm going to keep going with some other theme.
- 7.56** One of my interests has been looking at the online world and the emergence of the online world. I remember when I was a kid, my parents took me to Kenya to go see the great migration of the wildebeest. In Kenya, and I guess in the Serengeti, so it probably goes into Tanzania, too,

these millions of these wildebeest will migrate seasonally, and they'll run across rivers, and then big alligators will eat them, or I guess, crocodiles will eat them, and lions will eat them, and it's really exciting. You just watch this big migration every season, and they make movies about it. I always love this idea of wildebeest migrating across the Serengeti.

- 7.57 When I saw what was going on with social media and the metaverse, I just started thinking about this as the **great fantasy migration**. Instead of the wildebeest's migration, I was like, this is the **great fantasy migration**, meaning we're moving as a culture from living in the real world, where you have stuff that can hurt you, you have actual physical things. If you play football in the real world, you get knocked in the head. You play golf in the real world, you actually have to be in the sun. You go surfing in the real world, you might bounce off a reef, or you can just do it online.
- 7.58 I think what we're doing now is, we've had this massive migration of people from—I shouldn't call it the real world because the virtual world is the real world. It's just virtual real. But we're having this massive movement from the traditional real world to the virtual real world. This has happened over 20 years. I got interested in this for a lot of reasons. One is I had a colleague come in, an academic, and he said, "Oh, yeah, I was a nationally ranked football player." I was like, really? I know a lot of great athletes because I'm at the University of Georgia. I know real world-class athletes. I looked at this guy and I thought maybe he wasn't telling me the truth because I know world-class football players. He didn't quite look like he had the build.
- 7.59 And so I chatted with him, and then it came out in the conversation, it was Madden football. It was e-sports. I was like, dude, seriously? E-sports? I shouldn't laugh. That's wrong. But it was so funny because I'm from a different generation. But in his world, that was football. Playing football online was a form of football. It was just a different form. OK, I guess that's how the culture is now. That made me laugh. Then I had another student, **Jessica McCain**, who was great. I was talking to her and she goes, "Well, yeah, I do this LARPing thing, and I'm a druid." I'm like, "What? What the?" Rewind. She goes, "Oh, it's live-action role play." I'm like, "Well, that sounds like at least you're in life, talking to real humans. What do you do?" "Well, we all dress up as characters, and then we enact this stuff." I'm like, "Dungeons and Dragons?" "Yeah, but in real life." I was like, "That's the craziest thing I've ever heard. This is awesome."
- 7.60 Then she says, "Yeah, there's this whole cultural group that's come across where people who are essentially geeks do all these different things, and we even have conventions." What do you mean? She goes, "Well, people that are into live-action role-playing, and people that are into sci-fi and people that are into Star Wars and people that are into zombies and people that are into British television like Doctor Who and people into other geeky stuff, anime, and cosplay, where you dress up like characters." She was, "Yeah, we all hang out together at these conferences. There's one in San Diego and there's one in Atlanta." I said, "Really? That sounds so interesting." I'm like, "Let's study this. Let's figure out **geek culture**."
- 7.61 I'm not using this, I hope I'm not using it in any disparaging way. I think this is considered prosocial now. I hope, I don't mean to be using—like, nerds are bad, I think, but geeks are good,

or maybe I got it backward. Anyway. I was like, "Let's figure this out." Jessica got a group together, started figuring how to measure **geek culture**. I'm like, "Well, we got to send a group down to check it out." She sends a team down to Dragon Con, which is down in Atlanta, the big geek thing, festival. I get up in the morning, I'm like, "Well, I'm a scientist. I got to take my daughter down." I grab little Charlotte who's about this big, and I go, "We're going to see the parade." I drive down there, and I don't know why I'm telling you all this story. Anyway, why not?

- 7.62 I get down to Atlanta. I don't know where I am. None of the phones work because there's too many people on the phones, so the phone system shuts down. I see this friendly-looking nerd with a CB radio on his back. I'm like, "Hello, nerd, can you help me?" He points me in the right direction. Then I go watch this parade. They have all these different people going down in the parade, and then they have all the Batmen going, like the Batman parade. Then one of them has a surfboard. I remember that was my favorite Batman episode, the Batman surfing episode. I cheered, and everyone looks at me, like, "You freaking geek, get out of here." I thought, "Oh, my goodness, I get the whole circle."
- 7.63 Anyway, that was a very long story to describe what we've developed, which is this very powerful alternative **geek culture** where people are able to dress up and live in some fantasy world and get a lot of esteem and respect for it. Does that make sense? Except for the Batman. That was great. In the show, it was the old '60s Batman, and he's surfing, and the shark attacks him, and he pulls out a shark repellent from his Batman tool belt. We just loved that. Oh my goodness, we loved that. I was probably 12, 10. Probably 10, I suppose. The greatest ever.
- 7.64 What we did was we started measuring people who identify with this **geek culture**. We developed a measure of this and then looked at their personality. Lo and behold, what you find with **geek culture** is you find higher levels of **grandiose narcissism**, which I found was fascinating, until I saw some of the people dressed up as Klingon princesses, and I'm like, "Yeah, you're doing this to get some status. Good for you." But it's not just **grandiosity**. You get some of the other stuff, too. You get some **vulnerable narcissism**. You also get a lot of **openness**. You get a lot of creativity, a lot of fantasy-proneness. You get a lot of curiosity. It's a really interesting mix of **grandiosity**, some depression, maybe some vulnerability, and also a lot of creativity that goes into this life.
- 7.65 I think what's going on with this **great fantasy migration**, at least my—well, jeez. My original thought was, what we're going to do is, take a bunch of people and we'll just move them online, a lot of young people where there's nothing to do, and then they can get esteem online and be happy. That was what I thought was going to happen. I think it's become, online's become a little more chaotic and a little more conflict-filled. I don't know if it's quite working the way I hoped it would, but excuse me. Anyway, that's what's going on. That's **great fantasy migration** idea.
- 7.66 A fourth theme I wanted to talk about, I'm going fast because these are themes are so big, is the theme I call the **Adulthood Optional Society**. I think I made that up. **Adulthood Optional Society**.

What we've noticed over time, and this is work I've done really with Jean Twenge, but a lot of other people have noticed this, too, in developmental psychology and other fields, is that kids are growing up more slowly. They're just, adulthood is becoming delayed. There's some reasons for this. When we've looked at it, part of it looks like it's linked to individualism. "Well, I don't want to grow up because that would mean being constrained into a social role. What I want to do is go figure out what I want to do. I'm going to go to college, and then I'm going to get a master's degree, and then I'm going to go mess around a little bit, and then I'll eventually figure out what I want. Maybe that'll be when I'm 30."

- 7.67 What seems to be going on is either we've created this new period of emerging adulthood where people are figuring stuff out for another 5, 6, 7, 8 years, and then they're going to become adults at 30. That's what I hope. The other option, that's more of a delayed adulthood. The adulthood optional idea is that people grow up to 30, and some of them go, "I don't really like being an adult at all. I'll do some adulting when I have to. I'll do adult as a verb. Sure, when I have to wash my clothes or pay the bills, I'll do some adulting. But otherwise, I'd rather hang around and just watch TV and spend time on the internet wearing my PJs." I don't know what people do. I don't know if they really wear PJs on the internet. That's probably just me.
- 7.68 The question is, are people going to develop later? Or is this just like, "You know what, this whole adult thing seems hard, and I don't see a payoff for it." Here's what you notice. People aren't getting their driver's licenses when they turn 16. People are like, "Oh, I'll just start to drive when I'm 20." Don't you want to drive? People are dating a lot later, or they're not dating. A lot of people don't ask people out on dates. They don't know how anymore, so that's being delayed. People are staying in school a whole lot longer, which is delaying things. People are getting married later or not getting married.
- 7.69 The traditional model of adulthood is to be able to support yourself, to be married, to have a house. That's kind of the model. Kids. Married, kids, house. That's supporting yourself. That's pretty much adult. You don't have to do all those things. There's no rule. We don't have a magic thing, but that's usually what it is. I think, for a lot of people, that doesn't sound appealing. A lot of people are delaying marriage. A lot of people are foregoing marriage, and a lot of people are foregoing having kids. I'm not going to talk about this because this is my latest, that's my latest rabbit hole. But just watching the fertility rates collapse. So just, people aren't having kids anymore.
- 7.70 What they're doing in part is they're substituting pets for kids. They're saying, "Yeah, I really want to have some adult responsibility. I'm going to have some fur babies." My dogs take a lot of work. Like Mr. Murphy, I got to get him up every morning. Little Killarney, she's a good girl. Got to get her up, got to walk them. Not the same as my kids. A lot easier. If I got problems with my dogs, I just send them to the farm. They love the farm. A little tough when I let them go, but once I get down that dirt road, I'm like, "OK, later, dogs." Can't do that with my kids.
- 7.71 I think what's going on is we're having this very delayed adulthood. I don't know if it's going to be delayed adulthood or if it's going to be purely optional, like we're just not going to have

adults anymore. It is a little scary to me. I will say, during the narcissism boom of the '70s, that I hinted about with talking about the culture of narcissism and Kohut and Kernberg, this was an issue as well. They talked about it with men in particular as Peter Pan syndrome. Have you ever heard that term? That was the old '70s term. That was the '70s term for the guy who wouldn't grow up, so being Peter Pan. This comes from a Jungian idea, which he called the Puer, or the Puer Aeternus. I think I got my Latin right. Puer means boy, eternal boy. It was this idea of remaining a boy forever. That's the Peter Pan story. In the '70s, when a guy was going to be a boy forever, it was mocked, and people thought, well, that's sad. Even if you're Warren Beatty and you're in Shampoo and you got all these girlfriends, it's sad. You're not growing up. Again, now I don't think the pressure is quite the same. We're in a very interesting time for that.

- 7.72 You have narcissism going up, you have people moving online, you have people not wanting to grow up. Then the fifth theme I wanted to talk about is the breakdown of connection, trust, and cohesion in society. You see this in a lot of ways. One of the biggest trends you see is the collapse of religious belief. I mean, it's just collapsed. We looked at this, I'm trying to remember, I guess it would be about 9, 10 years ago. Everything I do is like, Jean Twenge—it means Jean did all the work and then called me. I should just say that. Jean's so smart. But we were looking at religious beliefs, and what we saw is this massive, just a massive shift, a massive increase in non-religiousness, especially in college students starting in the mid '90s. Now we're looking at 25% non-religious in college. I don't know what it is now. Could be more. I don't know if we're going to—I do have a sense we might be going through a little bit of a shift.
- 7.73 But what we have is a breakdown of religious beliefs, which makes it hard. What do you connect with? Well, you connect with society, or you connect with religion, or you connect with family. Well, families are getting smaller, less kids. Religious beliefs are falling apart, so there's less to connect to with religious beliefs. Then there's the idea of trust in individuals and institutions. At least since the '70s, we've been collecting data on America's trust in each other. How much do you trust other individuals, and how much do you trust institutions? Institutions would be the education system, the banking system, the legal system, the government, the military, maybe the medical system. Trying to remember which ones they do.
- 7.74 Trust in institutions is interesting. It's not like it's just collapsed. It has a little bit of a story to it. In the '70s, people stopped trusting institutions. The '60s riots. We don't like the man, but people trusted each other. They trusted other Americans. They didn't trust institutions as much. Right now, what's going on is we're seeing a collapse in institutional trust. This usually goes with economic cycles. When the economy is bad, trust goes down. When the economy is good, it goes up. But the general pattern is down. Major lack of trust of institutions and a lack of trust in each other. We're becoming a moderate—we're not becoming a low-trust society. We're becoming a moderate-trust society.
- 7.75 Two really important things there. One, high-trust societies make everything work better. Trust is like a, what's the word? It's like a lubricant that makes society work. If I want to get stuff done, like in my little small town, when I work with people, I can just shake hands. "Hey, you want to do this? Great." Shake, done. Boom. I trust the person. I don't need a 20-page contract. I don't

need attorneys. I just, high-trust society, small town. I know I'll get screwed once, but I won't get screwed twice by the same person. If it's a small enough town, everyone figures that out. Trust is wonderful. As trust breaks down, everything gets hard because everything needs documentation, everything needs lawyers, everything is a pain in the butt, and you don't know what's going to work, so you can't relax.

- 7.76** The other thing we've seen is this collapse in trust in institutions. When I looked at that, I took a deep dive on this maybe five years ago, and every institution had collapsed in terms of trust, except the military. There was still trust in the military, but nothing else. I thought, well, that's interesting. Maybe what we end up with is a military coup, because everyone trusts the military, but no one else. Maybe we just have a military junta, and that's how we settle this out. Well, guess what? Nobody trusts the military anymore. After Afghanistan, that was pretty much the end of trust in the military. I can't think of any—I'm an academic, believe me. People aren't like, "Hey, we trust you guys." We lost a lot of trust. No one trusts the physicians anymore. Some people, obviously.
- 7.77** But I mean, so all our institutions are becoming low-trust. I will say we are moving into a moderate-trust society, which is going to be challenging and makes people more self-centered because you got to look out for number one, or you have to look out for people you trust, which is your close network. When I said we're moving from the age of **institutions to networks**, I think this is part of it. If you can't trust institutions, you trust yourself, and then you find a friend you trust. You go, I trust that person. Then that person trusts that person. You go, OK, now I got three people I trust. So you build a trust network, and it all has to come bottom-up, and it just takes a long time to do this. But I think that's where we're going.
- 7.78** Another thing we're seeing, this is another aspect of that breakdown in connection in society, is this community breakdown. You have a bunch of only children or small families, people living in isolated communities. What we're seeing, and I did this paper, again with **Jean** doing all the work, and this is, I think, 2018. We found this massive—I say massive, it's pretty, like, on the graph, you're looking like a big spike in **loneliness**. People just reporting being more lonely. It was very hard to get this published. I don't know, people didn't seem that interested, but it did. I was just shocked at how lonely people have gotten.
- 7.79** Now, **loneliness** is interesting because **loneliness** is not the exact same as being alone. It's a psychological feeling. When people feel lonely, what that means is they feel not connected to people. Some of it is depression, negative self. There's some negative self feelings with **loneliness**. It's not like, if I'm done work and I'm by the pool at the hotel, I'm like, I'm not lonely. This is awesome. It's not just being alone. It's this sense that you're alone, but you want connection, you want community, you want a sense of belongingness. We have really—well, I should say, then the Surgeon General, I think this year or last year, came out with the epidemic of **loneliness**, came out with a report. I think people, now it's on the radar of somebody up there. Again, social isolation is awful for people. Being lonely is awful. Depression, anxiety, self-harm. I don't like any of it.

- 7.80 Then my final positive slide on the breakdown of things, as we're seeing a collapse in the importance of marriage and family. These are just from survey data, General Social Survey or Monitoring the Future, other big data sets we get. What we're seeing is that the importance or the desirability of raising a family, becoming married, looks like it peaked in early 2000s, 2002, 2003, and it's just gone down since. Married and family life has been trending down since the '70s. The family has really come down. This is college students. We've seen a shift downwards towards, yeah, raising a family, starting a family.
- 7.81 What you have is a society of individuals with moderate trust, who don't really trust institutions, who are trained to want to seek attention and fame and get some value by having someone notice them on social media. That's the world we've set up. They're not that interested in forming families. They're not that interested in becoming adults. I shouldn't say—it's not a lack of interest, like "I never want this." It's also that it's really hard. How do I afford a house? How do I meet somebody? I don't want to say it's an intentional, "I don't ever want to do this." It's also society isn't pulling for this. It's a two-way street. You've got community breaking down, and people are feeling sad, lonely, isolated, and you're seeing lots of mental illness because of this. If you're on a college campus, you're going to see these waves of mental illness because you have a bunch of socially isolated people without goals or vision. That's positive. That's what you're seeing. That's **culture of narcissism**.
- 7.82 To finish up, what does this new culture look like? We got a lot of lonely people, but it gets interesting because some people are going to be winners. What we're going to have is, you have this culture of high self-focus that demands self-promotion. All of us have to learn how to promote ourselves. You don't want us to promote yourself. You're going to have to promote yourself, whatever you do. You're going to do—yeah. Whatever you do, you're going to have to learn to promote yourself. There's low social connection. No one's offering you social—you're not just born right. Maybe you're blessed. You're born into a church or a synagogue or something. You've got that connection. But most people are, with the decline of religion and community, you got no connection you're born into. In a small family. People aren't born into this.
- 7.83 What we're going to end up with, primarily, is a few winners, the few people that can master self-promotion, they can get attention, that can build families, can build systems, they're going to win. Everybody else is going to lose. We're going to end up with a Pareto, my guess, I could be wrong, like a Pareto distribution, like an 80/20 distribution. This is what you get with a lot of things that involve performance. You get about 20% do pretty well, 80% don't. It's pretty just what happens. To conclude this on a positive note, that's the direction we're going. I don't see anything positive about it. I can't see anything, I don't see any breaks on that direction.
- 7.84 What has to happen is, you need a counterculture. If the culture is like a one-way train of self-promotion, social isolation, and emptiness, and **loneliness**, because that's pretty much what you offer the kids, right? Here's what you got. What you need is a counterculture that's going to be a counterculture that's focused on family, that's focused on tradition, that's focused on belonging, that's focused on connection. I think that may be happening in a little bit. I think we're getting a

little bit of a spiritual great awakening happening now. I think a lot of people—I talk to a lot of random people about religious stuff. That didn't happen five years ago. Like random Uber drivers. Like, "Let's talk about Christ." "Why not? Why not? Sure better than talking about the news." I mean, just random stuff. I think there's that trend.

- 7.85** The other trend I think is really interesting is, I'm a Californian, my wife's a New Yorker. I'm very coastal. I think we're switching from the Pacific and Atlantic coasts to the south coast. I think the cultural center is shifting a little bit to Texas, Miami, Texas, Florida, Tennessee, maybe a little Georgia in there, maybe a little Alabama. I think we are having a bit of a cultural shift. I don't know how to quantify this, but usually, things don't just go in one direction forever without a counterculture. I think there is a little more of a pro-human, pro-family, pro-spirit, pro-depth, pro-being a human being with a soul counterculture coming up.
- 7.86** I don't know exactly what to call it. I do see it when I talk to people, but it doesn't have a lot of power right now moving through institutions. You're not seeing it coming from the medical system, from the legal system, from the academic system, but I do see it with the people. At least the Uber drivers have got it figured out, and the Lyft drivers, and maybe they can start the new world. Thank you very much.

8. Changing Narcissism

AT A GLANCE

Closes with changing narcissism, a trade-off whose benefits (confidence, energy) we want to keep. For parenting, offers CPR: compassion, passion, and responsibility, plus natural consequences. For oneself, breaks narcissism into specific practices: gratitude for entitlement, kindness and forgiveness for antagonism, humility and active listening for self-promotion, anger management, non-defensive responses, changing groups, and finding honest feedback. For partners, get allies and boundaries, use gray rocking or yellow rocking, and consider leaving. For workplaces, structured hiring, the no-asshole rule, and careful leadership selection. Reviews psychodynamic, CBT, DBT, schema, and group therapy for NPD, medication and psychedelics, therapeutic alliance, Milarepa, and societal fixes; answers questions on DINKs, cults, and switching faces.

- 8.1** What I wanted to finish up with today is talking about changing narcissism. I've talked about this a little bit, but I wanted to save it for the end. Narcissism is really interesting because most things that we think of as bad, we go, "Well, I just want to get rid of them. I just want to get rid of that bad thing." But narcissism is a trade-off. It's a mixed blessing. It's a **double-edged sword**. It's all those things we call it with bad metaphors. There's some good pieces and some bad pieces. That makes getting rid of narcissism more complicated.
- 8.2** The benefits of narcissism that we're mostly aware of are those things like **extraversion**, energy, some confidence. I mean, you have a kid, you're like, I want my kid to be energetic and self-confident and be able to shake hands and be able to talk in front of a microphone and things like that. We like those things. What we don't really like about narcissism so much are the fact that you're self-centered, so you're confident, but you only think about yourself. The fact that you deserve special treatment. The fact that you think you're better than me; that's a little annoying. The fact that you're mean. All those antagonistic traits, those low agreeable traits, aren't likable.
- 8.3** Then the vulnerability piece isn't really likable. Sort of like, "Oh, I get put out thinking about your opinions. It makes me sad." Or, "I get overwhelmed when I get negative feedback, so don't say anything negative to me ever because it will just give me the vapors." You're like, "Dude, I just got to work with you and give you feedback sometimes. I don't want to have to do the sandwich feed. You're awesome. You really screwed this up. But I just want to reinforce how awesome you are. I'm tired of that. I just want to be honest with you." So what we want to do is we want to capture some of that good stuff in narcissism.
- 8.4** The other problem you run into in changing the world of narcissism is, I talked to a whole lot of people. Out of a thousand people, about 999 want to change narcissism in somebody else. "Hey, I'm really interested in narcissism. Could you make my boyfriend's narcissism go away? I really am interested in narcissism. Can you change my parents? I'm really interested. Could you make my husband and son be better people?" A lot of the interest in changing narcissism isn't, "Hey,

I've been reflecting deeply on myself and I'm having problems." It's more, "I want to point fingers and change people." That's an issue.

- 8.5 Very rarely do I have someone contact me and say, "Hey, my narcissism is getting out of hand. Can you help?" Not that I can, but I can say, "Hey, here's someone to talk to. Here's maybe a place you can go to talk to people." But typically, when we're talking about changing narcissism, it's pointing fingers at everybody else's problem. That leads to a problem. It's very hard to change narcissism in other people. You just can't really do it. You can maybe do it with yourself. Very hard in other people. What I thought I'd do is I'd talk about changing narcissism. I'd talk a little bit about parenting because that's really the first place you can do it. I thought I'd start with parenting and then go through some of the relationships and some of the clinical things and others.
- 8.6 Parents ask me all the time because, again, they're concerned. "I'm fine as a parent, but I'm worried my kid's going to become a little narcissistic. What do I do?" The first answer to that question is be a good role model, which means be a loving and kind, caring parent who is a good spouse and a good friend and be a good model. But that's not what people really want to hear because they want to make sure their kid's OK. Then I came up with this little bit of a recipe for kids and helping kids' narcissism, which I thought would be memorable for parents, which is basically CPR. When parents go, "How do I make my kid not narcissistic?", I don't give them the whole lecture about genetics. I don't say, "Hey, you should have picked a more chill spouse." I don't do all that. I just say CPR.
- 8.7 What does that stand for? Compassion, passion, and responsibility. Those are the big three. What does that mean? Well, if I don't want my child to be narcissistic—remember, I'm happy with my kid being extraverted. I'm happy with my kid being confident. I'm happy with my child wanting to be the star of the school theater performance. If my daughter was like, "I'm going to play the role of Popeye in the new musical," I'd be like, "Great, good for you." I wouldn't be like, "Oh, that's weird. You're being too much of a celebrity."
- 8.8 But what we're worried about is lack of connection. The C is compassion, connection, cooperation, any way to connect with other people. If you're a loving person who cares about other people, that will be a massive buffer to narcissism. It's hard to be a compassionate narcissist. You can be compassionate and a little self-centered. You can be compassionate and really confident. You can be a compassionate risk-taker, but it's hard to be a compassionate narcissist. They don't go together. It's a buffer.
- 8.9 I think that focusing on compassion, feeling not sorry, but feeling sympathy for those less fortunate, feeling connected to people, feeling part of a team, feeling part of a group—any of that way you can connect with people, I think, is really useful. Team sports, I think, are great because a lot of team—I mean, if your kids are in that direction, team sports are great because it's a cooperation. It's all the classic teamwork, lack of ego, working together to get a goal done, et cetera. Connection and compassion is the big piece.

- 8.10** The second piece that people don't think about so much is passion. Remember, you're energized, you want to succeed. You can do it in a couple of ways. You can say, "Look how awesome I am. Check me out. Look how great I look. Here are some photos of me." Or you can just show a lot of enthusiasm or passion for what you're doing. When I was a kid, it was the '70s, people were really into motocross, like riding bikes. We used to ride bikes over jumps, always crash, because we'd watch guys do it on motorcycles. They'd always crash. That's what we did in the '70s. But when you watch somebody jumping a bike, there's a couple ways they could do it. One is they're just fired up. They're excited. Dude, I'm going for it. I'm going big. We're excited. It's about passion. They do it and they make it. They're in the zone, and they're excited, and it's fun for everybody. They win and they're cheering. We're all cheering. That's passion.
- 8.11** The other way you could do it is you could do the jump and you could go in and be, "Look, I did it. You can't do it. Can any of you do it? None of you can do it. I did it. I'm the best." Not passion. That's doing things for ego. That's doing it instrumentally. Kids, anyone, adults, if you do what you do with passion, that brings people in. It brings people in naturally, and it doesn't make people feel less than you. They get excited by the passion. You can get all those needs met. You can get people to love you. You can get people to want to be around you. You can get all those ego needs met without going out there and self-promoting, just by doing stuff that you're passionate about.
- 8.12** This is what Joseph Campbell used to call "follow your bliss" in a way. He gets a lot of grief for that. I love Joseph Campbell. He gets a lot of crap for that "follow your bliss" comment. Everybody's like, "You should be an accountant. Don't follow your bliss." But if there is something that does bring you bliss, that brings you joy, when we talk about intrinsic motivation, we're talking about joy. When you find something that brings you joy, that you're passionate about, and you follow that, you'll get all those benefits of ego needs without having to be a jerk. You just don't have to be a jerk. That's the passion piece. Again, that's what people often forget about.
- 8.13** The third is responsibility, responsibility-taking. What you find with narcissism is this ease of taking responsibility for success. "Hey, the world's awesome. That's on me. Great job, Keith. Yeah, that was all me." But the hard part is taking responsibility for failure. Taking responsibility for your shortcomings, taking responsibility for when you screwed up. Just teaching kids to say, "I screwed up. It's my fault. I'm going to do better next time," that does two things that's really cool. One, it reduces your ego because you're admitting to failure, but it also gives you ego strength. Because by saying, "I failed," by going up to somebody in power saying, "I failed, I'm going to make it up," you're saying, "I'm responsible, I have agency, I have power, I can do things."
- 8.14** It's not like you're saying, "I'm a failure." What you're saying is, "I'm responsible." I'm responding to this situation as an adult by taking responsibility, taking ownership of the negative outcome, and making it a positive outcome. It's about taking ownership or authority over your life for the good and for bad. By taking responsibility, you become agentic, you become in control, you're able to succeed, you're able to be respected. People respect people who take responsibility, but

you're not an arrogant jerk because you screw up all the time and you acknowledge that. I think that CPR piece is really a good model for this stuff. I don't know how much good it would actually do, but I think it's a good model. It's not going to hurt, like a lot of models.

- 8.15 The final thing I think about a lot with kids is natural consequences. This has to do with responsibility-taking and learning how to fail. Here's how life can work. One example is my daughters can go do something, and I can go, "You did that wrong. Here's how you need to do it right." Then all of a sudden, I've got a power play going on with my kids, and my kids go, "I'm going to do it wrong just to show you I have power," and then we're fighting. That doesn't do much good. Or I can have my kid experience natural consequences. The simplest version of that is, "Oh, I'm going to go grab this hot stove. Oh, that hurt. I'm not going to do that again." When your kid grabs a hot stove, you don't need to have a big lecture. You don't need to go, "Go to your room. You touched that hot stove. I'm never having you do that again." They're not doing it again. They learned, right?
- 8.16 That happens in a lot of things in life. I grew up surfing. I'm from southern California. I grew up like skateboarding. That was like, you'd go down these hills on these old skateboards, shake, and then a dog would run in front of you and you'd jump and someone would break his wrist. I always had a friend with a broken wrist. Those are natural consequences. By being exposed to natural consequences, you're able to develop a sense of control, of power, of responsibility. But you don't hate yourself. You go surfing and you fall all the time. You get hurt all the time. But you're not like, "I'm a bad person," and you're not shaking your fist at Poseidon. "Damn you, Poseidon, for making me fall." You're just like, "This is just how it works." Then you're able to get better and better.
- 8.17 I think putting people in the natural world where you're dealing with consequences that aren't social. It's not a social person saying you're a bad person or a good person. It's impersonal nature helps you develop strength and ability without all that ego stuff going on. I was hanging out with some surfers, and one was a legit pro, and the others amateurs. I asked the pro, I said, "Are there any egomaniac surfers that you know?" He goes, "Not really." He goes, "There's a few of the agro guys, just a few agro guys. But other than that, most people that surf big waves are pretty chill because they've gotten hurt enough that their ego has gotten beat out of them." You just get hurt enough times. I really love natural consequences. That's how you deal with a kid.
- 8.18 How do you deal with narcissism in yourself? That's the challenge. People call me. This is just—I'm not talking psychotherapy right now. I'm just talking trait narcissism. "Hey, Keith, I'm kind of narcissistic. My girlfriend keeps calling me a narcissist. I started texting all her friends about it, and what do I do? I want to be less narcissistic." My suggestion in that case for people is not to sit there and go, "I'm narcissistic. How do I be a not-narcissistic person?" What I suggest is, break it down to figure out what specific things that you're seeing in your life are the narcissistic pieces. So what is it specifically that you're doing that people are seeing as narcissistic or you're interpreting as narcissistic, that's causing you problems?

- 8.19 And then once you drill in and figure out what those issues are, come up with a practice, a very simple practice, to just not do it anymore. Just a very simple cognitive practice. I'll give you some examples. **Sense of entitlement**. Just a sense that you deserve more in life. You deserve special treatment. I'm sitting at home, I'm looking at my bills, I'm looking at the internet, I see my brother, he's waving from Cabo on a boat somewhere with a big fish in his line. I don't know. I'm like, "That should be my boat trip. I hate you. I deserve more in life." That's **entitlement**, right? That's a curse because we can never get enough to fill up. You try to fill up with stuff, you're never going to end. You're just hungry ghostland.
- 8.20 The treatment for **entitlement** is **gratitude**. That's the cure. There's probably others. But one of the classic cures for **entitlement** is the practice of **gratitude**. How do you practice **gratitude**? You make a list of things you're grateful for. You have a **gratitude** journal, say your prayers, and talk about what you're grateful for. You tell the people in your life that you care about. You say, "Hey, I really appreciate you. Thank you." God, I say, every once in a while, I do this now. I like, will call up buddies. I'm like, "Hey, I really appreciate you guys." People are like, "What? No one says anything nice to me ever." I'm like, "No, no one says anything nice to anybody," but I do.
- 8.21 There's some nuance, I think. I've read some of the research on **gratitude** journals, in the positive cycle. It's like, do it every week, or there's maybe some timing that's better. I don't know, but I think the general practice is, if you feel entitled, if you got a **sense of entitlement**, practice **gratitude**. That's a buffer. Just do that every day or whatever. Just say, "That's my practice. I'm grateful for what I have," and that'll be a buffer.
- 8.22 Maybe your problem is **antagonism**. You're just kind of mean to people. You're just a little bit selfish, a little bit vengeful, a little hostile to people, whatever. But let's say just you're kind of antagonistic. What can you practice? Well, one thing you can do is you can just practice kindness. People do this. It's like an Oprah thing. I'm going to go practice kindness or do a kindness every day. But little things like that can be very helpful. I'm a selfish person. I'm not really nice to people. I'm a little bit antagonistic. Every day, I'm just going to go out of my way and just be kind to somebody. Just make an effort to be a nice person. That's it.
- 8.23 Maybe I'll make an effort to forgive people. Maybe even, maybe I feel so antagonistic and everyone's out to get me. I'm going to just think of the people I really am pissed at, and I'm just going to try to forgive them. Just take some time and work on that. Again, this is a practice. Just every day, I'm going to be, try to be nice. Try to be nice. Try to be nice. Eventually, you'll actually be a little bit nice. It's not that hard to change yourself. But again, that's a practice.
- 8.24 Maybe your issue is self-promotion. Maybe it's you're always talking about yourself. This is an issue I can have because my **extraversion**, I'll start talking to people, and they're talking about stuff, and then I start talking, and then I get real excited, and pretty soon I've been talking for 20 minutes, and they're like, "What happened to me?" I'm like, "Dude, who are you? I didn't even know you were here." That self-promotion, and again, self-promotion can be really important, but if you find you're doing it all the time, you find every time you're in a conversation, you got to say something about yourself, you can practice a couple of things.

- 8.25 One, you can practice **humility**, which is just try to be humble. I don't know how you do it because **humility** is an interesting word. It comes from the word for humus, like earth. Be earthy in a way. There's a couple different ways you can be humble. What I don't mean is be negative on yourself, like I suck, but it's more like, just have some **humility** about things. One real good way to do this is just practice **active listening**. This is hard for me. Sometimes when I hang out with the meditators, when I hang out with people who meditate a lot, I call them the meditators. I'm usually five minutes into my meditation. I'm like, "Shut up, self. You're done. Peace out. Start thinking about stuff." But the real meditators, they can actually listen and relax. You can talk and people will look at you like they're really hearing what you say, really paying attention, **active listening**.
- 8.26 If you can learn that skill, it's going to balance off a lot of your self-promotion. Then people are really going to like you because, like I said, no one ever cares about anybody. If you show even the slightest interest in someone's life, they'll be very appreciative. That sounds pretty negative, but it's true because everyone is so neurotic and hung up in their own head right now. It's like you have a whole world. I'm on campus, you got a million people going, "What's everybody thinking about me?" You know what they're thinking about you? Nothing. They're not thinking about you. They're thinking about themselves. That's a good one.
- 8.27 Another thing you see with narcissism is a lot of anger, hostility, this classic anger. When I've looked into this, I've looked at research on anger, there is anger management, which is, I always think of that as a funny movie, but there's actually practices of anger management, which I don't know how to do, other than counting to 10 before you start screaming at somebody. Generally, I think there are these established practices of anger management for people who're more impulsive. I think that stuff works. I don't know how to do it, though, other than counting to 10.
- 8.28 I still remember, working at this mental hospital in the child unit with this little kid, a little Irish guy, just loved him, and he used to punch people a lot. At one time, and I was like, "We got to just count to 10 before we punch people." He'd be like, "OK. 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 9, 10, boom." I'm not saying this stuff's perfect. It's a practice. But I like the idea of that practicing anger and aggression.
- 8.29 Then finally, there's this defensiveness piece that people have. People get very defensive. Don't say this negative stuff about me. Don't criticize me. I mean, it's hard to be criticized. It's hard to be defensive. I think in that case, the responsibility-taking is really good. I think sometimes the voice responses can be really—"Keith, you really did poorly at that." "Oh, I'm sorry you feel that way. Can you tell me more?" Just stuff like that. That'll just freak people out. I always say, I always, I used to get it. It was always the new-age hippie people. They're like, "I'm so mad at you." "I'm sorry you feel that way." "What?" You took away all my power just by doing that hippie stuff? But that stuff works. It's just like, instead of being defensive, go, "Yeah, I guess I don't look that great. What do you think I should do next time?" It takes all the power off of it. It's just a way of gaining power.

- 8.30 Again, these things are all practices. You'll see, I'll see my place as I get defensive. You'll just learn them, and you'll learn when they're coming up, and you'll learn how to control them. Maybe if you're in a situation where you're getting real defensive, say, "Look, I just got to get out of here because I'm going to say something stupid." Or just verbalize things. "Yeah, you're making me feel defensive because of this, this, and this." But again, practice, practice, practice. Those are all specific issues.
- 8.31 The other two pieces for this, for individual narcissism, are if you're with a group that is encouraging your narcissism and you think that's a problem, find another group. This is like the AA thing. I want to quit drinking. Well, maybe don't hang out with your drinking buddies every day. That would probably be a good start. If there is, and I'm not saying there is always a social group, but if you do find yourself in a social group or with a small group that's encouraging narcissism, maybe find a different group.
- 8.32 The other piece of that is trying to find a way to get real feedback in life. It's really hard for a lot of us to get authentic feedback from people. People don't want to tell us the truth. People don't want to tell us negative things about ourselves because we're not going to like them, or they call this the **mum effect**. No one wants to hear negative news. You go to a therapist, maybe, and the therapist maybe will be honest with you, but maybe not because they're worried they're going to do some damage. Somehow you've got to figure out how—you just need somebody to keep it real with you. Somebody just go, "Keith, look, I got to keep it real."
- 8.33 I don't know how you find that person. Maybe it's your uncle, maybe it's a good old friend from grade school you've known forever that knows you really well. Maybe it's your brother, your sister, or somebody. But somebody to tell you the truth. Because you think about it, if you're living in a narcissistic distortion field, you're distorting the world to make yourself feel good and look good, and it's causing problems. You need somebody that you'll listen to, that can break through and just tell you the truth. Good luck finding that, but I think it's really good.
- 8.34 We have narcissism in parenting, narcissism in ourself. What about narcissism in relationships? We talked about narcissism and a lot of the problems that has in close relationships, especially romantic relationships. Very often, as I mentioned when I started, is people in relationships with somebody narcissistic, their question is, how do I make that person change? I really love my partner. I just wish they were a different person. Then I'd love them more. I love that. "I love you, but I'd just love you more if you weren't you." "Thank you, sweetie. That means so much. Does that mean you like my truck? Maybe it's my minivan you like. It's not my personality."
- 8.35 Here's the thing. It's very, very hard to change anybody. If you start thinking, I'm going to change my partner's narcissism, the answer is, you're probably not. If you're a very good clinician trying to treat a patient who's narcissistic, it's going to be hard to do. For you as a partner without training, with somebody in this weird power dynamic, probably not going to happen so well. I wouldn't spend a lot of time going, "I'm going to change my partner." It's not worth a ton of time. What you need to do, like in the last case, is get allies. I mentioned this before, but it's really important to get allies to maintain your ability to test reality.

- 8.36 Because what you're going to get with the narcissistic partner is you're going to get that **gaslighting**, that reality distortion, that, "Hey, this is how the world is. I'm right, you're wrong," et cetera. In order to resist that, what you need is, you need people that can tell you how reality really works. You need some authentic reality testing system. Again, could be a therapist, could be a narcissistic coach, could be a family member, could be your mom, best friend, whatever it is. You need to find allies. Then you need to set boundaries, and that's the challenge. Whatever the boundaries are, if there are boundaries that are being crossed, you need to set those boundaries to the extent you can.
- 8.37 If there's something going on that's illegal or dangerous or whatever, you need legal help. I mean, I said this before, but get an attorney, family court attorneys. Talk to somebody early, just so you have expertise in this thing. Then people ask, "Are there some tricks to dealing with narcissistic partners?" There's two methods I've heard, and I've heard these from people I respect that do this for a living, but there's not a lot of good research on it. But I'm going to share them anyway because I've heard them enough. These are called **gray rocking** and **yellow rocking**. They sound so silly.
- 8.38 The **gray rocking** method with somebody narcissistic is to be responsive, but in the most limited way possible. Essentially, you're in a relationship with somebody narcissistic. They're trying to get in your head. They're trying to play games. They're trying to get you to fight with them. They're trying to make you feel uncomfortable. Instead of letting them do that, you just go, "Yes, sure, no, thank you." That's enough. Bom, bing, bing, bom. Whatever, you're done. You just don't feed in to the drama. That's this **gray-rocking** idea. Now, the newer idea I heard, and this is straight out of LA, so I like this one, is **yellow rocking**. **Yellow rocking** is when you're not really neutral with somebody narcissistic; you're positive, but not committal. "Oh, that sounds great." End of discussion. "Oh, you look great." End of discussion. "Oh, we'll make that work. Got to go." End of discussion.
- 8.39 The **yellow rocking** is not so much being neutral. It's being a little bit positive, but with really strong boundaries and endpoints. "I'll be nice to you, but in a very, very limited way." I was talking to some of my musician buddies, and they were like, "Oh, this is really useful." Sorry. The celebrity world, they do a lot of **yellow rocking** in celebrity land because it's a good way to deal with people. It's a great way to deal with me. It's easy. That's a more positive way. But all of this is about not becoming caught up or entangled in what's going on. It's keeping yourself grounded, keeping your boundaries tight, keeping yourself becoming emotionally invested.
- 8.40 Then there is the question last time, which is a big one is, do I exit the situation? Here's the problem. You can get in a relationship and you have a huge amount of investment, especially in a marriage, because your marriage partner isn't just your friend or lover, it's also your business partner, and you have a 20-year business with them, and maybe they're a co-parent. You've got a 20-year family business where you have a house and a kid, and you have shared friends and family commitments, and you have a trip lined up to Cancun, and you've been saving for it for seven years. It's very hard to give up a relationship like that. That's the challenge. You get so much investments in something, it's hard to get out.

- 8.41 I don't tell anybody. You get out, you don't get out. That's a hard choice. You get yourself in a bind, you're like, I'm just going to suck this up for five years and make it work the best way I can. Do a lot of yellow-rocking. I don't know. If, however, you're in a situation where you can get out, you're like, "I've got this partner. They're narcissistic. They're a little bit dangerous. It just feels wrong. My vibes are off," my suggestion, and this is a line I stole from my father, one of his greatest lines ever, which is, "Get a U-Haul and leave a note." I just like that line. Just get out. Just tell him you're leaving and bail. My sense is, if you're in a relationship and the investments aren't high enough and you're getting vibes that this is not a healthy thing and this is a potentially narcissistic partner, I would just get out.
- 8.42 Because those relationships can turn. They tend not to get better. It's not like, "Oh, yeah," then they turn in—they tend to get worse, they tend to get more controlling, and they tend to get violent and even dangerous. If you're going to have kids with somebody, you sure as heck don't want to have kids with somebody like that if you can help it. I think that exit strategy is ideal, but sometimes you're married to somebody and you can't do it, and that's just how it is. God bless, you just make it work. People work it out. People work it out either way. The relationship piece is hard with narcissism.
- 8.43 Workplaces are easier. In general, workplaces are easier because you can fire people and you can hire them. It's a much easier hiring and firing process, at least in the US. Probably in France, you get a narcissistic employee, you got to hire them for another 15 years, but here, we can get rid of people. What do you do? Well, in a workplace situation, the easiest thing to do is not hire people who are narcissistic at all. That's hard to do if you use unstructured informal interviews. Because if I meet somebody who's really confident and narcissistic, I like them every single time. I'm like, "You're hired, amigo. God, I love your attitude. I like the cut of your jib. You're going to be manager in no time."
- 8.44 That's not the best way to do it. It's better to use something more formal. A lot of small business, you're not going to do it. But if you can't do something more formal, you need to check up people's reputation. You need to call up their references. Now, a lot of times, references won't tell you anything either, so it's hard. You try to avoid that. The second thing is if you get somebody bad, you get rid of them. The way they talk about this in corporate America, and I'm not joking, it's literally the no-asshole rule. There's a book on this. People talk about this all the time. What people have realized is that, if I have an organization and I bring somebody in who's an asshole, excuse my language, technically, what that means is, when we look at the research on what an asshole is, it's somebody very low on agreeableness. Narcissistic, self-centered, and psychopathic. There's something going on there. If you get somebody like that in your organization, it's a disaster, so you don't want them in there.
- 8.45 When I was department head long time ago when I had responsibilities, if I had someone—I'm not going to say anything too specific here, even though it's been a long time. If I had someone who was mean to my staff, if I had someone who was not nice to my business manager or my accountant, if they were rude or brusque with them, their chance of getting a job was, I'll just say it was very small. Their chance of getting a job dropped dramatically if they were mean to

the staff, because I didn't want anyone like that in my department. You're going to be mean to my staff, I don't want you here. We just don't have room for that. Running a ship like that, where you just get rid of people who suck, I think is really useful, and a lot of companies do this. That is really useful.

- 8.46 Leadership selection is another place, and we talked about this, where narcissism can be a real problem. You can do leadership selection well because when you're selecting a leader for a large organization, you have some money, and what you need to do is do in-depth psychological analysis of people, and maybe not even quantitative stuff. I think it's useful to do the quantitative stuff, but I also think it's useful to hire—I know some psychologists who basically, this is what they do. They just interview people for CEO positions. I think going to that level can be useful. You really want to do some work on somebody if they're going to have that much power. If you have the money to do it, you might as well do it.
- 8.47 Again, always real detailed clinical interviews, but always check history. Because personality psychology, best predictor of future behavior is past behavior. If you want to know how somebody's going to be, you just look at how they were. People just don't change that much. You need good history of people. With political leadership, we're just out of luck. It's a disaster, I'm sorry. Our political system of, like, "Hey, we're just going to do this reality show every four years," and the candidates bounce up, and then we make fun of their outfits or whatever, and then that's the end. It's terrifying.
- 8.48 I don't have a solution for it at all. Yeah, I don't have any solution at all. Maybe just have a list of everyone who wants to run for office and just pick the person who doesn't want to do it, something like that. It's an old Lao Tzu one. I don't know. But that's a real problem. You'd say, well, you could go to a parliamentary system, but even then you're not getting these narcissistic leaders, but they're bad. I don't know what works better. Maybe that would be a little better. I don't know.
- 8.49 In terms of **narcissistic personality disorder**, we talked about **NPD**, but we didn't spend a lot of time talking about psychotherapy. I thought I'd talk about that a little bit, too. This is the more intensive therapeutic approach to dealing with somebody who has actual **narcissistic personality disorder**. I get a call. "I got this guy I'm working with. He's in the company. We got to get him treated. He's got **NPD**. What do I do?" Well, there's a range of treatments you'll find. If you're in Boston, New York, maybe LA, maybe Houston or something, one of those, some of the big medical centers there, what you might find are **psychodynamic** therapies. What you might find is somebody using a more **psychoanalytic** or **psychodynamic** therapy for narcissism.
- 8.50 What's going to happen in that case is, you're going to go into therapy. You're going to talk about your childhood a little bit. You're going to talk about early unconscious conflict you had in your childhood. You're going to analyze **transference** and **countertransference**. What that means is, let's say I'm a patient, I'm on my couch. They don't use a lot of couches anymore. Let's say I'm in my comfortable talking to my analytically inclined therapist, and I'm going to develop feelings towards my therapist. I'm going to say, "I hate my therapist. He's the most arrogant,

stuck-up person ever." Or I'm going to fall in love with my therapist or something like that's going to happen. What they're going to do is analyze that. That's called the analysis of transference.

- 8.51 Then my therapist is going to feel something to me. "God, I hate that Keith guy. For some reason, I just hate his guts." That's countertransference. We're going to analyze that, too. We might even do some dream analysis in it. Psychoanalytic therapies or psychodynamic therapies for narcissism are very long and slow. You're talking multiple times a week for years. Old-school would be four or five years, four times a week. Now they're shorter, but maybe twice a week for a few years. What you're trying to do in those therapies are really break the personality down, figure out what happened in early childhood to set up the narcissism.
- 8.52 Does this work? Well, if you talk to people who do this, it works if people stay in therapy. I should say this before I go in all the therapies. Here's the general outcome with therapy with narcissism. Most therapies work if people stay in therapy. But people who are narcissistic don't want to go to therapy because there's not that much wrong with them. Then when they get in therapy, they sometimes have problems staying in therapy, partly because they don't want to hear it, and partly for some other reasons I'll show you. It's their own antagonism. Therapy generally works, but there's not like, one's better than the other. It's just if you get into therapy and stay with it, that seems to be what works.
- 8.53 The classic narcissistic therapies or the psychodynamic therapies, but again, you're not going to find them. Maybe Miami, there'd be a few Latin, because there's a lot of psychoanalytic work in Latin America. Maybe there's some good Argentinian psychoanalyst here or something. I was fly fishing with a psychoanalyst from Arkansas. He goes, "Yeah, I'm the last psychoanalyst in Arkansas." He goes, "I was an anachronism before I got my degree." I thought that was a great line. He was just from another era. There just aren't any—the last psychoanalyst in Arkansas. They just don't exist that much.
- 8.54 Much more commonly, if you go into psychotherapy with someone who's a modern, trained clinical psychologist, you're going to get cognitive behavioral therapy, or CBT. Cognitive behavioral therapy is a general family of therapies, maybe started in the '70s, '80s with Beck, that have to do with analyzing specific patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors, try to see how those are structured, and then build interventions to change them. For example, maybe I find that when people start talking about wealth, I feel insecure, and I feel compelled to brag about something. I notice a pattern. I talk to my therapist about that. They go, "That's a really interesting pattern. For homework, what I want you to do this week is, every time someone talks about wealth, I want you to write down how you feel about it. Then if you want to start talking about your own wealth, what I want you to do is snap this rubber band." I don't think they use a lot of rubber bands. That's the old thought-stopping technique. But that would be like an example. Snap this rubber band. Just to practice. We'll work on homework and we'll do this.
- 8.55 It's not so much, let's talk about how you were breastfeeding and had to develop a narcissistic self to protect from the rage of your father. It's more like, you feel like yourself becoming a jerk.

Let's deal right there. That's classic CBT. There's some different versions you're going to see. Like dialectical behavior therapy, or DBT, is one you see a lot. This is primarily done with borderline personality disorder. It's really dialed in more to emotional regulation about having a wise mind rather than a more impulsive mind with things. But this seems to work with narcissism because you get a lot of people with the more vulnerable narcissism that also have more borderline features, and that seems to be effective.

- 8.56 There's a therapy called schema therapy, I think out of New Jersey primarily, that's kind of a cognitive dynamic therapy that they've done a lot of work with narcissism on, and it seems to be pretty effective. When I talk to, like I said, I'm not a therapist. When you talk to therapists doing work with narcissists, it's really hard because you're trying to give people feedback, but when you give them too much feedback, they start to bail. Then you have to say, "But you're really awesome," and bring them back. I always think of it as fishing. It's like, you got to let them run, but then you got to reel them in, and then you let them run. You're like, "Oh, man, you really shouldn't have done that. Yeah, maybe saying I love you to your daughters would be good." Then they start getting defensive, and then you're like, OK, you're all—whatever, let them run.
- 8.57 Sometimes they talk about giving gifts in psychotherapy with narcissists. Like, when they get there early, tell them something really positive about themselves. "Dude, you're a real winner. Of course, this is a problem for you. I mean, it's hard in a world where everyone else is average. We just got to make this work, though, so you can fit in with the little people." They don't really say that, but that's what I would say if I were a therapist. "No, man, I get it. It's hard being that great. Yeah, a lot of sympathy." This is interesting, but there's some work on group therapy. Group therapy is very common, I said, with borderline personality disorder, and group therapy is very common with substance abuse, things like AA or NA. People are used to doing groups with some externalizing disorders. When you end up with people narcissistic in group therapy, it seems to work. But again, the dropout rate was really high.
- 8.58 One big study I read of group therapy, I think the dropouts, I'm making these numbers up. I think it was 40 or 60%. Well, I should just say 50, somewhere in there. Very high dropout rates of therapy. But people who stay in it seem to improve. That's the general model with these kind of talk therapies with narcissism, is if you stay with it, it kind of works. There's not one therapy that seems to work better than others. We haven't done any battle of the therapies to see what works. We don't have enough people to do it anyway. That's it.
- 8.59 Someone asked earlier about psycho or pharmacological interventions for narcissism, and there really isn't much. You can imagine for stopping the sense of vulnerability of neuroticism, that's something like SSRI or selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor, like an antidepressant, can help for that. That might be used maybe if you've got a lot of mood. With borderline, maybe you give somebody a benzodiazepine, like Ativan or Valium or something to get rid of mood regulation. I don't know if you'd see that as much with narcissism, but that's about it.
- 8.60 When I started studying psychedelics, and I started studying ayahuasca, which is this traditional plant medicine used in the Amazon that contains DMT. It's like a drinkable form of DMT, a very

powerful psychedelic. I thought what could happen is, well, you get somebody narcissistic, they go down there, have an **ego death** experience, reemerge on the other side, and the narcissism would go away. I had this idea, I'm just being honest, I thought it would help. We've done some research on this. My student, Brandon Weiss, led a lot of these studies, and we've collected data on groups of people, measured narcissism, looked at these experiences, measured narcissism afterwards. You do not seem to see narcissism going away at all. You just don't really see that.

- 8.61 You see vulnerability drop. You see the **neuroticism** decrease. You see that sense of overwhelm. I think with **vulnerable narcissism**, it can help. But with **grandiosity** and even **agreeableness**, you're not seeing a lot. People will say, "I feel more connected to nature." I think one of the challenges is, people have mystical experiences, and some people go, "Oh my god, I just saw God. I'm very small." Other people go, "I just saw God. I'm a legend. I'm going to go tell everybody and start a cult." You get massive **ego inflation** when people have religious experiences as well. I think that—so what I thought was going to be a really awesome solution. I remember, oh, how great you take all these maniacs down there. They just go have this psychedelic, mystical insight, and then they change their life. I don't really think that's working. I wish it would. I don't think so.
- 8.62 I've seen what —what I have seen a lot of is **spiritual inflation**. Sometimes the term people use is **spiritual materialism**. I'm going to get a lot of status. I'm so spiritual. I'm more spiritual than you. I went to 10 ceremonies. You've only done eight ceremonies? Oh, yeah, dude. I talked to God, no, at least nine or 10 times. Yeah, no, you'll get there when—maybe. It's a journey. We're all on a journey. We're all on a journey, and it's just like I'm on the journey just a little ahead of you. You know what I mean? But it's all the same journey. It's just, I'll get to the end and you won't. My concern with a lot of these things that I thought could be really helpful, I think they can be really helpful, but they can also do the opposite. I just do not want one more ego-maniac spiritual guru in this world. I'm so tired of freaking gurus. They're just everywhere now. That's my thought on that, that kind of therapy.
- 8.63 The other thing I wanted to talk about with narcissism in therapy isn't just **NPD**, but it's just the personality traits of narcissism. So not just having the disorder itself, but being narcissistic can be a challenge in therapy. There is a study that just came out, which makes me much happier because there's a lot of research. It was in JAMA, the Journal of American Medical Association, but this study out in Germany with, I think, 2,000 people. They looked at patients going into psychotherapy, and it was **psychoanalytic** therapy, and it was also **cognitive behavioral therapy** for depression, primarily depression. But they also measured narcissism. They use the **NARC** measure, which I mentioned at the beginning, but it just measures more —it measures the more extraverted, grandiose form. It also measures a more antagonistic or disagreeable form of narcissism.
- 8.64 And what they found was that patients who were narcissistic didn't do as well. In treating depression, they just didn't do as well. And the reason for that was they had a problem forming a **therapeutic alliance** with the therapist. So the **therapeutic alliance** is the relationship you have with your therapist. The two of us are working together as allies to treat my depression. So what

they found was, with the more narcissistic patients, especially those that were higher in this **antagonism**, this rivalry, this more hostile self-centeredness, they just didn't form those alliances well enough, and the treatment didn't work as well.

- 8.65** Even just at the normal level of narcissism, as a trait at normal scale, it's going to interfere with psychotherapy for anything. But the key is that it's that **therapeutic alliance** that's the issue. If you can get around that, meaning if you're a narcissistic, can find a therapist, develop a **therapeutic alliance**, go through the process, you should see change. I say this 15 times because when I started studying narcissism, the story was, nobody can change who's narcissistic. You're stuck and you're cursed. I just don't think that's the case. But I also don't think you can go change somebody. I don't want to sell it like you can change, but I also don't want to think it's the curse of narcissism.
- 8.66** This is a tangent that I didn't plan at all, but I will tell this story. Why I like to think this way. One of the great saints in Tibet was named **Milarepa**. He was a shaman, and he was a nasty guy. Somebody harmed his family, and he went and killed a bunch of people, used his spiritual powers to go to war. Yeah, became a very powerful and angry and narcissistic shaman, and then realized it wasn't working for him, and he had to go through training. His training was, it was wax on, wax off in those old movies, but he had to build something for three years. Then they're like, OK, tear it down, build something else for three years. He just builds stuff for 10 years.
- 8.67** Then he starts having a series of visions and becomes a good guy. One of those visions, he walks in, there's a whole room of snakes, and he sees all the snakes getting him. He just walks right into the snakes and becomes a snake. So **Milarepa** transforms through this intense work, this 10 years of labor, like Hercules' labors, he transforms from a very bad guy into a great saint. Now when they show pictures of **Milarepa** in Tibet, you'll see him because he's green. Because what he did was, he's meditating so much and eating nothing but nettles. He turns green just from eating the nettles. A lot like St. John the Baptist, John the Baptist, eating honey and locusts or whatever. That kind of vibe to him.
- 8.68** The idea is, you can change. People do change from these very selfish, self-centered, antagonistic to loving people. It's just a lot of work, and it's hard. Changing another person's narcissism, I mentioned this, but again, you can't really do it. You're not going to have any luck changing your husband's narcissism, your wife, your kids. It's just not really going to happen. You can encourage them, though, to get treatment. If you've got someone, you're like, "You're narcissistic," you're not going to be able to do the treatment, but you can encourage them to get treatment. I think that is useful to do. Even if it's not going to work, that is a step you can take.
- 8.69** So, you've got a problem with somebody. Maybe it's a relationship problem, maybe it's a family member, maybe it's someone you work with. Whatever the case, you're like, "Dude, you got issues. I can't deal with this anymore. You need to get some help." That might be useful. I'm not going to say it's going to work, but that's going to be more useful than you trying to help them yourself. That's what I want to say. It's just very, very challenging. I think in almost every case,

it's better to focus on what you can do to control your own behavior than to try to change somebody else. Instead of emailing me and saying, "Keith, how do I change this person who's narcissistic in my life?" I'm like, "How can you change your own life to protect yourself, to get out of this situation, to make your life better, and to protect those people you love, like your children, your family, from this toxic individual?"

- 8.70** The final question, we've talked about changing kids, our partners, ourselves, other people. How do we change society? How do we make society less narcissistic? I talked about this a little bit yesterday. It's tough because right now we have institutions we don't really trust, and we have individuals we don't really trust, and we have a very mediated, self-centered society. So what can you do about that? These would be, theoretically, what I'd guess is, one, is rebuild institutions so we can trust them. I don't know how to do that, but that seems something reasonable to do. Usually when you have low-trust institutions, how you make them trustworthy is you have a special blue ribbon committee. You do an analysis of the institution, you find the problems, and you implement a plan to change it. I don't see anyone doing that, but that's what you would do. It's not that hard to do. There's a book.
- 8.71** You need to establish a positive vision for people to be happy about. I talk to so many young people, and all I hear is, "I can't afford a house. I don't know what to do." That's what I hear. I don't hear anyone saying, "I'm so excited about the long-term vision that we all share together, that our leaders have been sharing. I can't wait to get on board that long-term vision and build something positive and great for everybody," because there is no long-term vision. Unless there is, and no one told me about it. It's like a secret long-term vision. But basically, there's no leadership. There's no goal-directed leadership as a community. We just don't have that. We have everyone fighting each other. That's the problem.
- 8.72** I would get rid damn phones. I am the most—it's very hard to meet somebody more libertarian-leaning than me. I'm from Laguna back when Laguna was Laguna, and I don't care when anybody does ever. I don't wake up in the morning like, God bless everybody. Do what you want to do. No judgment. But I think these phones are challenging. I think especially with young people and especially in schools, I'd just ban them. I know [Jon Haidt](#) has talked about this a lot, and [Jean](#), banning them in schools. I think this stuff is as dangerous as cigarettes. I'm pro-cigarette, too. Don't tell anybody that. I'm not even that bad. I even kind of like tobacco. I hang out with a bunch of shaman, they're always smoking. Well, this looks OK. My point is, I think these phones, especially for kids, are bad news, and they just shouldn't have them, period. It just should be treated just like tobacco for young people. That sounds really heavy-handed for me to say that, but if I had to do a very simple intervention, it's get phones out of kids.
- 8.73** Then I think there's a couple other things that would be useful. One is that we have movement to large cities and urbanization that's natural. It's happening all over the world. I talked about in Asia that—you've seen it hugely in China. It happened in the US after World War I in particular. But I think if we could find out a way to be a little less urbanized and a little more of a rural society, you'd have a little less narcissism. I think that goes for everybody on Earth. I think rural societies, people have more kids, there's more family focus, there's more religious focus, there's

more tradition. You've got all the farming communities, you have all the holidays around the seasons and around the fields. I think building that world up could be helpful, to the extent we could rebuild it. I drive through middle America, rural America all the time because I live in Georgia. It doesn't look awesome. Some of it looks awesome, but a lot of it's run down. It seems like that would be something that would be helpful.

- 8.74 I think the final piece that I worry about, and I worried about this a lot when we wrote **the Narcissism Epidemic**, is just, it's debt-based materialism in a debt-based materialistic society. The way our—instead of us growing up and going, "Hey, everybody, let's work for the big goal for everybody. Come on, big goal, guys. Yeah, what are you doing for the big goal?", what we do is go, "Oh, what are you going to get?" Then you go, "I'm going to get this, this, and this." You go, "I want that, that, and that. How are we going to get it?" "Well, I got to go to college, so I got to borrow a bunch of money. Then I'm going to go buy a house and borrow a bunch of money." What you end up with is a whole bunch of people with a whole bunch of debt, chasing stuff to fill them up.
- 8.75 I'm not saying that's a bad way to run an economy. I'm not an economist. Maybe that's the best way to run an economy, but it doesn't seem making people scared about going bankrupt in order to buy stuff to impress people they don't really know that well or care about doesn't seem like the healthiest way to run a system. Maybe a system that was a little less materialistic and a little less about showing off and maybe a little more about community, about bringing people together, that would be useful. There's not a lot of economics in community. There's a lot of economics in buying crap you don't need and showing off. It's hard to do these. But just generally, I think that's the direction we'd go in. More family, more spirituality, more community connection, probably less urban, less damn phones. I'll end with that. Things are awesome. Thank you, guys.
- 8.76 Hi. I wanted to see, going back to the narcissism and culture, and I think that we're heading to the peak of narcissism. I wanted to see if you've heard of a term that's been trending this past week called **DINKs**. And what's your opinion on that and where we're headed with that?
- 8.77 So I had a call from my daughter last week that said, "Dad, have you heard about this trend called **DINKs**?" I have. I watched some videos on the TikTok that people sent me. And so a **DINK** is dual income, no kids. And the videos people were showing were a couple, a young couple, saying, "Hey, we don't have kids. We can get lattes. And I have all the money I want. We can go to dinner whenever we want and have brunch." I think that was it. What's the response to that? I had a lot of responses. Mostly, God bless everyone, including the **DINKs**. But what I thought was, that makes me incredibly sad because I can't imagine an emptier life than going to brunch with somebody for 40 freaking years. That makes me sad.
- 8.78 The other thing, and this is—I look at people and like, when I didn't have kids, I had a really interesting life. I traveled the world. I got into trouble. I was arrested. I had fun stuff happen. I shouldn't be alive. It was great. When I see people going, "I don't have kids so I can go to brunch," I'm like, "That's what you're doing? How come you're not trying to break into North

Korea or something? That would be interesting." "Oh, yeah, we got brunch." I guess my feeling is that that celebration of very short-term hedonism is going to lead to long-term costs. And generally in life, doing what you want, being hedonistic, I wish it worked. I wish the data were like, you know what? People who just do whatever the heck they want all the time, they win. You don't win because you ruin your relationships, you don't do anything. So I think it's generally not going to end well for people. I think it's a negative trend, with love for everybody.

- 8.79 So touching back on **psychedelics** and how it's affected or unaffected with narcissistic behaviors, do you find that **psychedelics** can actually aggravate and promote narcissistic behaviors in people that were maybe not necessarily that way prior?
- 8.80 So that's a great question. I don't, I don't see—I'm not saying it can't happen. I haven't seen cases where somebody's like, "I'm a normal person. I did some psychedelic ceremonies or did some DMT with my buddies, and now I'm narcissistic." I haven't seen that. What I have heard about, I haven't seen personally, are people having basically manic episodes. That's a pretty well-established risk factor. People who have a risk for mania, that they can have mania triggered by psychedelic experiences. Mania can look like narcissism because I figured it out. I've seen interviews. "I saw God. I can't believe it. Everything's God." You're like, yeah, I get it. But they get so excited. They got to tell you again and again and again. I have seen that.
- 8.81 The other thing you see, this is something Jung talked about. Jung talked about this in his lectures on Nietzsche. Talked about **ego inflation**, that people that have spiritual insights, it goes to their head and they start going, "I'm God. I'm one with the universe. I am the universe." I'm like, "Dude, you're not really God." But people will get this **spiritual inflation**, and that can look like narcissism, but it's often seen as very prosocial. I'm like, "God, I'm going to help you. I'm going to do all these great things." But it does seem very narcissistic. I don't know if that answers your question. But it is a concern I have, of that ego and **spiritual inflation**.
- 8.82 Hi. Can a narcissist switch between the vulnerable type to the grandiose type, depending on who is around, or maybe it's more like with age?
- 8.83 That is a really good question. Can somebody switch between more vulnerable and **grandiose narcissism**? The answer seems to be yes. The way that seems to look, I mean, how it looks, I think most frequently, is you have people that are primarily vulnerable, but they have these pretty intense fantasies of **grandiosity**. So they'll end up having grandiose fantasies and feel really grandiose for a while, and then something will go wrong. They're like, "I'm a loser." And then they go back to the vulnerability phase. So they vacillate between vulnerability and **grandiosity**, depending on if they're getting positive feedback, if the world's going the right way. Again, that can definitely happen.
- 8.84 In terms of age, I haven't heard of it changing, but it certainly could. You could see somebody's vulnerability dropping as they get older because they become less neurotic, or you could see somebody's **grandiosity** dropping as they get older because they're less attractive and their vulnerability goes up. I could see either one of those happening. But generally, that pattern of

grandiosity and vulnerability, where people will just go, "I'm the best, I'm a loser," back and forth, not one after the other, but a few hours here, a few hours there. That's common. It's common for people to have those grandiose fantasies, even if they're vulnerable.

- 8.85 Is there data on cult leaders or cult founders or high-control religion and narcissism?
- 8.86 Yes. So talking about the psychedelics and ego inflation, you see the same thing in cult leaders. So a cult leader is somebody with high amounts of charisma that's controlling a group based around a belief system. Usually in cults, you have a leader and you're not letting people leave the cult. So there's a lot of control over who you can see and who you can't see. So basically, they're cutting you off from all your outside sources of influence or truth. You know how I said, if you're in a relationship with somebody narcissistic, get allies to keep you grounded? What a cult leader does is says, "Don't have any allies to keep you grounded. Just listen to me." And then they build a support system within that where they'll have some henchmen within their group to reinforce their beliefs. And so cult leaders can be incredibly attractive to people who are narcissistic.
- 8.87 You also see a lot of sexual exploitation. In a lot of cults, you'll have the leader sleeping around with a bunch of people on the top. These are religious cults. It doesn't matter. Yeah, religion is good for you, but I'm special, so I can do this. Narcissism and a cult leader, they just go together. I don't know a lot of cult leaders who aren't really narcissists. I don't know a lot of cult leaders, but people I talk to in cults is, I think that's what you end up with, are these very narcissistic leaders. The other thing I'll say is people really want leaders. They want somebody who sounds like they know what they're talking about. People are desperate. When a cult leader goes, "Yeah, I talk to God, and God told me this, and I got the direct channel," it's very appealing to people. It works. Cults work. Yeah. Good question.